Stitched Up

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/33438400.

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Explicit

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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F/F

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Castaspella (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), A bunch of other characters, But I don't wanna flood the tags

Additional Tags:
Post-Canon, Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder - PTSD, Anxiety, Depression, Mentions of past abuse, Implied Sexual Content, No Character Death, But lotsa pain, Don't worry everyone will be fine, Adora centric trauma, Adora Goes to Therapy (She-Ra), gratuitous fluff, Blood and Injury, light self-harm, but nothing too serious

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Part 4 of She-Ra Headcanon

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by Nordic_Fatcheese

Summary

Adora is seriously injured in battle and loses the ability to transform into She-Ra because of it. During her lengthy recovery, Adora has to overcome her own trauma instilled by the Horde and learn to love herself for who she is, not for what she can do. Begins about six months after the finale.

Notes

This monster of a fic was inspired way back in July 2020 when I saw this lovely painting by Viko Menezes and immediately made a poor redrawing of it with Adora and Catra because apparantly every muscular woman I see reminds me of She-Ra now. While I was drawing it, the idea for how the injury happened came to mind and pretty soon I've got a 16 chapter story about Adora healing from her trauma. I really love stories that focus on the emotional baggage that Adora's been left with, and this was the perfect opportunity to dive deep into that.
Rated Explicit because there's a whole lot of very graphic injury, plus several very horny scenes (but no actual smut). Also they say fuck. Other warnings include a lot of trauma, references to past child abuse and psychological manipulation, internalised self-hatred and ableism, general anxiety, and some depression. There is NO major character death; everyone, including Adora, *will be fine*. It's just gonna be a painful path there.

Trouble

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"What is it?" Adora took her seat in the war room. It had become more of the reconstruction room in the last few months, but they still got trouble every now and then. Like now, for instance. Glimmer had called her and Catra down saying they had a problem.

"More bandits?" Catra asked, leaping over the arm of her seat next to Adora. She sat sideways across the chair such that her tail was free to drift in Adora's direction.

Etheria had become a rather popular destination for interstellar pirates since its return to the universe. Magical items found nowhere else in the galaxy and Etheria's relatively low technology made them an appealing target, and with the Galactic Horde gone, there was nobody to police the marauders. But they hadn't proved much of a challenge so far; they always seemed to forget it was Etheria that destroyed the Horde, not any of the galaxy's "advanced" civilizations.

Glimmer shook her head. "Worse. A Horde dropship." She sat at the head of the table, Micah on her left, Bow on her right. She waved her hand and pulled up a holomap, displaying a moderate sized Galactic Horde dropship. It was designed for transporting troops and supplies, but still sported heavy armor plating and a nasty pair twin-linked of plasma cannons.

"They've been circling the planet for about ten days," Glimmer explained. "Possibly flying in a scouting grid, based on their movements."

"Why didn't we do anything about it sooner?" Catra asked.

"They weren't aggressive," Micah said. "We didn't want to provoke them if we didn't have to."

Glimmer sighed. "Unfortunately, that is no longer an option. Yesterday, their ship was caught in a storm and they crashed down here." Glimmer waved the holomap again and played an animation of the dropship crashing to the earth, leaving a huge skid crater in its wake. "They landed on the edge of the Whispering Woods, not far from a small village, Tyrsdale. When the town sent a search and rescue party, they were met with laser fire."

Adora sat up in her chair. "So what are we dealing with?"

"These dropships typically carry around twenty clones and triple the bots," Bow said. "But our scouts have reported that the crash was pretty severe." Bow pressed a button and several glowing dots appeared on the board. "Entrapta's new lifeform scanner tells us that only eleven clones survived the crash. Closer scouting also reveals that the cargo hold was severely damaged, only maybe a dozen bots survived."

"Maybe?" Catra repeated.

Bow sighed. "There's no way to know for certain, but it was a nasty crash. Not many of the bots could have survived that."

"Still, we need to be careful," Adora said, leaning forward. "What have they done since the crash?"

Glimmer zoomed the map in. "They appear to be setting up defenses around the crash site. Clearly they're expecting company."

Adora studied the hologram. Using the wreckage and a few fallen trees, the clones had assembled a makeshift palisade along the southern end of the crash. It was pretty impressive for under forty eight hours of work, enough to make things complicated.

"We need to act fast before they get dug in," Adora said. She considered the battle grid for a moment. "We'll need more bodies to take this."

"I can scrounge up some guards that aren't too busy with reconstruction," Micah offered. "Will ten be enough?"

"Plenty. Glimmer, how many people can you safely teleport into battle?"

"About five." That seemed like a lowball but Adora agreed that they should be conservative when teleporting into a combat situation.

"Good, you take Bow and four of the guards to the west flank, here," Adora ordered, pointing at the highest point of the wall. "You should have a clear line of fire from there.

"Catra, you and Melog take the rest up from the east in stealth. Scale the wall here and provide ground support for the fire group."

"And what about you?" Catra asked with a hint of worry.

"Swift Wind and I will approach by air from the south and draw their attention. Once they start shooting at us, both will groups attack their exposed rear and take them by surprise."

Catra sat up straight in her chair. "And you're just going to draw *all their fire*, just like that?"

"Small arms fire at an airborne target with She-Ra magic to boot, they won't get anywhere near hitting us," Adora replied in a militaristic tone, completely missing the concern in Catra's voice.

"That's insane, you'll be a human shooting range!"

"That's the plan. I can take their attention so nobody else has to deal with overwatch fire on the way in."

"By being shot to pieces?"

"No! I'll be fine, I've taken way more than this before."

Bow leaned in. "I don't know, Adora, that seems awfully risky."

Adora turned sharply. "Riskier than letting the other groups take a volley of plasma on their way in?"

Bow opened his mouth to protest but said nothing. All eyes turned to Glimmer.

She and Micah exchanged a glance and a nod. "Because we don't have enough time to prepare a proper force, I agree that this is our best option." Catra opened her mouth but was interrupted by Glimmer. "But *be careful*," she said, pointing aggressively at Adora. "I don't like this but we don't have many alternatives."

Adora nodded. "We'll stay at a safe distance until the fighting begins in earnest. We'll make our entrance once they're caught up in the firefight."

Catra shook her head. "You can't be serious..." she muttered.

Adora didn't hear her. "We'll leave in the morning, on foot to preserve Glimmer's energy."

"We could take Darla to get there faster," Bow suggested.

Adora shook her head. "Horseback, they'll be looking for ships. We should camp in the woods too, in case they're watching the town." Adora scanned the table. "Sound good?"

Glimmer, Bow, and Micah all nodded in turn.

Catra huffed. "Yeah. Sure." She stood up sharply and stalked out of the room.

Adora's stomach dropped a little. This was the best plan they had, it was the safest for Catra and the others. Surely Catra could see

that too? Adora wanted to say something but found no words.

The others exchanged awkward glances. Micah broke the silence. "I'll, uh, notify the guards."

Bow and Glimmer gratefully took the cue and stood up to leave. Adora mentally reviewed the plan once more and stood as well, satisfied with her work.

-

Adora wasn't surprised to find their room empty. She had recognized Catra's mood, only too late. She had gone to a hiding spot to cool off, where she couldn't hurt or be hurt by anyone. Adora could probably track her down if she wanted, and every part of her wanted to, but she knew that would do more harm than good. She knew when Catra needed space. She would be back by dinner.

Adora spent the rest of the afternoon in the gym, working her anxieties out on a punching bag. She kept running through the meeting in her head. Not the plan, she was confident in that. She was trying to remember what she had done to rub Catra the wrong way.

Maybe she had been too assertive. She strangled the others out of their opinions and forced them into her plan. She didn't ask Catra or any of them for input, she just went ahead and assumed they were on board.

No, that was stupid. If they disagreed they would have said something, they'd been doing this for years. But Catra hadn't. She was still relatively new to Bright Moon. She had only been friends with Bow and Glimmer for a few months, and she hardly knew Micah at all. Adora remembered how she was for the first month. She was so overwhelmed, she couldn't say or do anything. It could have been more of that. Adora should have payed closer attention to her, should have watched out for her, should have listened to her.

Adora punched harder to work the thought out of her head.

She knew what it actually was. Catra didn't like that she was taking so much heat in the fight. But this was the only way, Adora *had* to draw their fire. Even Glimmer agreed. Bow didn't. But Bow's a softie, he's always anxious. Shut up, he's a good friend, he's just worried about her. Like Catra was.

Adora punched until her knuckles bled. Catra would be fine. They'd had arguments before. Adora would be fine. She's taken on more before. And even if Catra still thought it was too much, Adora didn't have a choice. It was her duty.

She punched the bag clean off its chain. Adora stared at her bloody hands. What if she couldn't take it? She hadn't been in a real firefight for a few months now. But neither had Catra or any of the others. And they weren't indestructible. Adora could take the heat. She had to.

A surge of light sizzled the blood off Adora's hands. The pain remained, faded like the morning after a pulled muscle, but present. She didn't mind.

The sun was getting low. She should get dinner. Salmon fillet, Catra loves fish. They'll eat in the room, maybe talk things out. Adora sighed. As good a plan as any.

-

Adora bumped the door to their room open with her hip, a plate of food in each hand: two triple orders of salmon fillet and pasta, one for Adora and one for Catra to split with Melog.

They ate in silence. Adora wanted to give Catra space, let her talk when she was ready. But Catra just poked at her food, playing with a pea stuck on her claw. Adora couldn't take it anymore.

"What's wrong?" she asked in as gentle a voice as she could muster.

Catra stared at the pea. Her ear flicked and she side-eyed Melog. She sighed. "The mission is too dangerous for you."

"But I can-"

"You can take it, I know. Trust me, I of all people know that She-Ra is practically indestructible. But I also know that you," Catra pointed a claw at Adora's chest, "Adora, are *not*."

"What do you mean, I'll be fine. I've taken more than this before."

"It's still too much! I know you don't think so, but I can see how this kind of thing weighs on you. You have to trust that we can handle ourselves."

"I do trust you!" Adora said, reaching for Catra's hand.

Catra pulled back. "Then why can't you trust me when I say it's too dangerous?"

"Because it's better this way! I can reduce the risk for everyone else!"

"Even if it comes at the cost of your own safety?"

"That's what She-Ra is for! It's my duty to protect people!"

Catra's ears folded back. She shrank into herself a little and began poking at her food again. Melog bumped into her legs. She sighed.

"We've been over this, Adora," she finally said. "You don't have to always sacrifice like this."

"But I'm not sacrificing anything!" Adora paused and regained control of her temper. "I'll be fine."

Any trace of anger had left Catra. She silently rubbed Melog's mane. "Just be careful, okay?" she said in such a small voice.

Adora stood and crossed the table for a hug. "I will. I promise."

Catra tucked her head into Adora's chest and held her tight.

Chapter End Notes

I know Glimmer could probably just teleport them all there, she's pretty OP by the end of the series, but I need them to have a camp. My argument is that it's a long distance to teleport fourteen people, a flying unicorn, and a space cat and they don't want to risk Glimmer being tired for the fight or teleporting them too close. Or more likely, they all just want an excuse to be away from court politics for a few days. If you're reading this as it's uploaded, I already have the whole thing written and will be uploading it one chapter a day over the next couple weeks. I'm just doing some final proof readings before I put each chapter up. I've also never done multi-chapter works before, so bear with me if things get screwy.

Sister of Battle

Chapter Summary

> The battle goes awry when the clones boast more firepower than advertised.

Chapter Notes

> This chapter and the next are the reason this fic is an E. Content warning for graphic violence, injury, and a lot of blood.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora paced in anticipation. Late morning sunlight broke through the breathing canopy of the Whispering Woods in sporadic bursts. She wasn't nervous, not about the battle at least, but she always got antsy before a fight. A beep and green light from her tracker pad almost had her shouting in relief. Both teams were in position and awaiting Adora's signal.

"Alright, show time," Adora said, tucking the tracker pad away and turning to Swift Wind. "Ready?"

"Always." Swift Wind replied raised his horn majestically and let it shine in the sunlight that refracted off of it.

Adora shut her eyes and reached inside herself. "For the honor... OF GRAYSKULL!" She didn't need to say it anymore, but it made the transformation feel a little smoother, and golly it was fun.

Erupting from her chest, she felt the warm glow of magic spread throughout her body, invigorating her muscles and heightening her senses. Her limbs stretched and her torso was clad in shining plate. Hair flowing like liquid gold sprang from her scalp and billowed in a wind of its own making. Adora took an appreciative look at She-Ra's resplendent golden bracers and grinned. It was going to feel good to really *hit* something.

She leapt astride Swift Wind in a single fluid motion. He beat his wings powerfully and took to the sky. The crash site was immediately in view beyond the tree line. True to the reports, a rickety palisade had been erected along the southern side, Horde banners draped from what Adora assumed must be the gate.

Adora made a point of shining as brightly as she could as they neared the wreckage. She was the distraction after all. Swift Wind came to a stop around a hundred and fifty feet above the ground before the palisade. Clones scrambled into position along firing steps, raising their arm-mounted weapons, but none of them fired. Adora could make out six clones on the wall and a tightly packed formation of nine bots in the courtyard between the wall and the ship. This was going to be too easy.

"My name is She-Ra, Princess of Power, Protector of Etheria," Adora boomed, in a voice louder and clearer than she knew she was capable of. Another She-Ra ability for the list. She raised her hand and called her sword in a dazzling flash of light.

"During the war against the Horde I defeated hundreds of bots and clones, and personally slew Horde Prime." She lowered her blade. "I am giving you an opportunity to peacefully lay down your weapons so that you may be integrated as productive members of society, instead of spreading the mindless violence and destruction that Horde Prime forced you to inflict upon the universe."

Adora waited for a reply; a volley of plasma was her answer.

"Well, it was worth a shot," Swift Wind said, casually spinning in the air to avoid the arcing streams of energy. Plasma didn't have much drop over distance, but the clones still couldn't come anywhere near hitting them.

A shower of purple sparks followed by a series of explosions told Adora that Glimmer had made her entrance. She couldn't see Catra's group, but then that was the idea. "Let's go Swifty!"

Swift Wind bucked his hooves midair and whinnied as he charged downwards at alarming speeds towards the firefight. As planned, the clones were in complete disarray, caught off guard by the flanking groups.

Adora leapt off Swift Wind's back, directly towards the formation of bots. Their mechanical reflexes were just fast enough to get a couple shots off before she pulverized them. She landed fist first on the center bot, channeling a magical shockwave that left a small crater where the bot once stood. The impact staggered the others such that they couldn't even raise their weapons before Adora separated their tops from their bottoms with a single whirlwind sweep of her sword.

Adora noted with slight disapproval the scorch marks on her breastplate. She hadn't even noticed the hits on the way in. Sloppy.

Adora hardly had time to consider her mistakes as a trio of clones charged her, brandishing the humming blades standard to the Galactic Horde. The center clone swung a clumsy overhead which she parried with ease. Adora forgot how tough those things were, she would have sliced through a normal blade like it was made of rust.

The other two clones instantly moved to take advantage of Adora's exposed guard by jabbing at her stomach. The overhead wasn't clumsy, it was a distraction. Clever. Adora used her left bracer to parry the sword headed for her gut but the one on her right flank got through.

To Adora's shock, the blade bit into flesh. Not only that, but it *hurt*. Pain was normally dulled almost to numbness as She-Ra, but this sent rippling shocks of agony through her veins. Adora roared in battle rage and brought her fist into the offending clone's chin so powerfully she was pretty sure she heard his neck snap. Damn it, she had to keep control of her strength. She couldn't afford to lose focus or more would die.

Adora had only enough time to swear to herself as she turned towards the other two foes. As the duel resumed she quickly became lost in battle. She moved faster than her brain could think, parrying and ducking on instinct. For the first time in weeks, Adora felt *alive*. Her thoughts vanished as she was lost in the haze and adrenaline of combat.

A blade swept in on her left. She beat it aside with her own, the titanic force breaking the wielder's wrist as it was snapped backwards. In a single motion Adora flipped her sword in her hands, shifting her grip to hold it by the blade. In the same movement, she spun on her heel and brought her sword down, guard first, at the blade aimed for her back. She hooked the guard around the second clone's sword and twisted the weapon out of his hand. He roared and she brought the pommel back upwards into his jaw with a wicked crunch and a shower of teeth. Adora snapped around again to face the first clone, boot raised. She stayed her hand when she found him doubled over clutching his shattered arm.

Adora surveyed the battlefield. Despite having cleared out the bots, she still heard more laser fire than the remaining clones could have made on their own. There must have been more bots hidden inside the wreckage. That's fine, that's why they brought backup.

Glimmer's party was under pressure from the clones on the wall, but Catra and Melog's group had surrounded them and were tearing through their rear. Swift Wind had flown to the top of crashed dropship, and a good thing too, since there seemed to be sniper up there. He kicked the clone off the edge and impaled an accompanying bot on his horn. It looked like the battle was over before it had hardly even begun.

Adora turned her attention to the anomalous injury on her side. She moved the indestructible yet torn fabric aside and her hand came away wet. She realized with dawning horror that the injury was the exact shape and size of where Prime had struck her with the anti-She-Ra monster from the Heart. Was she still infected?

A particularly loud explosion rattled Adora's teeth. That felt much bigger than an arm-rifle. She sprinted around the wreckage towards the main skirmish. Glimmer and Bow were back to back on the palisade fighting off far more bots than should have survived the crash. Only a few clones were still standing but all were armed. Catra and Melog tore a pair of bots in half before rushing to aid the guards pinned down by the clones.

What caught Adora's attention was the cannon. The clones had managed to salvage one of the dropship's plasma cannons and retrofitted it to act as traditional artillery, mounted on a makeshift platform. They must have hidden it inside the wreckage and only revealed it once the fight began.

Without hesitation, Adora transformed her sword into a shield and charged the cannon. Two bots volleyed fire at her but the plasma splashed harmlessly off her shield. It did, however, notify the clone operating the cannon of her presence. He began to spin the barrel towards her but the ramshackle supporting structure collapsed. Unfortunately, it still managed to fall pointed at her.

Adora ducked to cover as much of herself with her shield as possible. An instant later, Adora gasped for breath as the shell knocked the wind out of her lungs. Her shield disintegrated and she was launched across the battlefield.

She slammed against the inside of the palisade, the back of her head colliding sharply with metal. She landed on her arms and felt suddenly very heavy. Pain screamed through her chest. That felt like a rib. Adora blinked blood out of her eyes (when did she get cut on the forehead?) and stared aghast at her own red jacket.

She clenched her fists and rose shakily to her feet, painfully extending her arm in front of her. She shut her eyes and called upon She-Ra. She didn't answer. Adora tried again, looking deeper within herself to pull She-Ra to the present, when a splitting pain shot through her stomach and arm. She cried out and fell to her knees again. The wound on her side was still bleeding, but the pain had been replaced with numbness. Pins prickled from the

wound, up her stomach and down to her fingertips. Something felt very wrong.

An explosion drew Adora's attention through her ringing ears. While the cannon had been focused on her, Bow had apparently gotten an angle to destroy it with a well placed explosive arrow. The more pressing concern now was the pair of bots which had survived the blast and were returning fire.

Adora retrieved her staff from her belt. She could still fight, She-Ra or not.

Adora used the staff to heave herself to her feet. She took a breath and charged at the bots, but the numbness betrayed her. It shot down her leg and she stumbled, alerting the bots to her presence. One raised its gun-arm and she dove forwards, a blast of superheated plasma coming close enough to singe her jacket. She swept the bot's feet as she recovered from the roll, knocking it to the ground. In a single motion she transitioned the swing into a downward thrust, impaling the bot through its head.

The second bot was on her in an instant. It swung at her before she had time to remove her staff from the other bot's central processing unit. She raised her left arm to parry with her bracer, remembering a split second too late that she didn't have bracers anymore.

White hot pain tore through Adora's forearm as the alien blade sliced through flesh. Adora howled in agony and clutched her arm to her chest. The world spun and her ears rang. Her heart beat loud in her throat, pumping blood onto the grass. The bot loomed over her and raised its sword-arm. Adora lunged for her staff as the blade descended.

Her momentum pulled the staff free and she raised it in a desperate block. But to her surprise, the blade never fell. Adora opened her eyes just in time to watch Catra rip the bot's head off and hurl it halfway across the battlefield.

Before Adora could speak, Catra was on her, terror in her eyes.

"Adora!" she screamed. Adora swiveled her head to look for the threat but saw none. The skirmish seemed to be going more favorably now that the cannon was dealt with. There were still more bots than anticipated, but they seemed to be handling it.

Adora was twisted back around to face Catra. Her eyes looked cloudy with unshed tears. Was she hurt? What happened?

Adora felt Swift Wind call her name more than she heard it. He crashed to a landing and raised his wings to create a rainbow barrier around them.

"No no no no no..." Catra's voice was frantic. She tore Adora's jacket off and tied it tightly around her arm before she could protest. A sharp pain made Adora finally look at her arm. It was bleeding. Heavily.

"Glimmer!" Catra shrieked, voice cracking. "Emergency!"

A heartbeat later and Glimmer was next to them, covered in sweat, robes blackened with soot. "What is it?"

"Adora's hurt, get us back to camp."

"On it."

It took Adora's spinning head a second to register what was happening. "Glimmer, wait, I'm-" They were back in camp.

"I'll meet up with you once things are cleaned up." Catra nodded and Glimmer disappeared as quickly as she had arrived.

"... fine."

Chapter End Notes

> Adora's half-swording! Cuz I'm a nerd and it's a less lethal way to use a sword which is useful for the good guys. Always

funny how the heroes have bladed weapons but don't kill anyone with them.

Injury and Despondance

Chapter Summary

Adora is not fine. Catra patches her up. Painfully.

Chapter Notes

This is the chapter that gave the fic its title. Content warning: Extreme blood, injury, and pain. Catra stitches Adora's arm together while she's still awake and mostly not numbed. I tried to make it as painful as it sounds, so if this is too much for anyone to read, the first half of this chapter can be pretty safely skipped. But the second half is important, and it's just angsty, so don't skip the whole thing.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora's stomach had been left on the battlefield. Her gut clenched and suddenly breakfast was crawling back up her throat. That was odd. She hadn't been teleportation sick in years.

Adora wiped her mouth and shakily stood up. Catra immediately took her by the arm and began leading her towards their tent. "Catra, I'm-"

Catra turned sharply. "Adora, you are *not* fucking fine." To make her point, she held Adora's left arm up. Blood had soaked through the jacket wrapped around it and was starting to drip. Adora suddenly felt light headed.

Catra took a deep breath and quickly let it out. She resumed marching Adora towards the tent. "We need to get you fixed up," she said in a measured tone. "Can you heal?"

Adora took a second to register the question. Her head was still spinning. "No. No, I can't summon She-Ra." Adora tried to run through the events of the battle. "I think I might have hit my head."

"We'll deal with that later. Right now we have bigger problems," Catra said, pushing through the flap of their tent.

She took Adora by the shoulders and pushed her onto their cot. Catra dug through their bags, tossing clothes and supplies aside until she found a first aid kit. She retrieved a bottle of water and sat on the bed next to Adora. Catra draped the sheet over her lap.

"Give me your arm." Adora raised her arm with a wince and grinding teeth. "I'm going to take the jacket off and when I do, we have to get your shirt off quick." Catra took a breath and met Adora's unfocused gaze. "Ready?"

Adora nodded and Catra got to work. She rapidly unwound the bloodied jacket and threw it aside. Adora felt blood immediately begin to pour down her arm. She lifted her shirt at the waist and worked her right arm out of its sleeve. Catra pulled it off her left arm and swore.

"This is bad," Catra mumbled. She tore the unripped sleeve off of Adora's shirt and wrapped it tightly around her arm just above the injury. Adora bit her cheek as Catra tied off the tourniquet. "Keep your arm elevated, I need to stitch it." Adora's mouth grew dry.

Catra began digging through the first aid kit. She tossed a bottle of pills at Adora without looking up. Adora guessed they must be painkillers. That was nice, Horde medkits only gave you a piece of cork to bite on. She awkwardly popped the lid off with one hand and fished out two pills as Catra threaded a wickedly curved needle. Maybe she should take three.

Adora raised the water bottle and swallowed the pills in one gulp. She had just enough time to hope she could keep them down before Catra was pouring antiseptic in the wound. Adora cringed as the stinging liquid slid through the chasm in her arm. It was deep, but at least she couldn't see bone.

Catra raised the needle and took another deep breath. "Ready?"

No. Adora clenched her teeth and nodded. The painkillers hadn't done anything at all yet but she knew they didn't have time to waste. The tourniquet had slowed it a bit, but she was still losing a lot of blood.

Catra took Adora's arm again and dabbed the blood away as gently and as quickly as she could. Adora held her breath.

The needle finally stung into flesh. Adora screwed her eyes shut and clamped her jaw. She wrapped the bedsheet around her hand and clenched her fist so tight she thought she might poke a hole through her palm. She planted her feet firmly on the floor and did her best not to move. Catra pulled the needle through and the string left an agonizing burning beneath Adora's skin. She was really missing that cork about now.

Adora was still reeling from the first puncture, she could barely control herself as Catra pulled the needle through the other side. Fire ripped through Adora's arm as Catra pulled the walls of the wound together. Tears rose to Adora's eyes and she was helpless to stop them from falling. A scream started to rise in her throat but she suppressed it, instead letting out a clenched groan.

Catra gave her no time to recover. The needle fell again and Adora gasped in pain, letting out a small shout this time. She clamped her jaw shut again and focused. She could do this.

A gentle nudge against her right arm prompted Adora's eyes open. Melog had arrived at some point and shrank down to petting size. They rubbed against Adora's arm and purred. The pain in Adora's other arm lessened just a little. She wasn't sure if it was Melog or the painkillers.

Another bite from the needle told her that whatever it was, it needed to work faster. She couldn't stop herself this time. Adora screamed as Catra pulled the needle across and finished the stitch as quickly as she could. Blood continued to surge from the wound in regular gushes, soaking Catra's fur in gore. Melog wrapped themselves entirely around Adora's right arm and purred so loud

she could feel it shaking her arm. Or maybe that was just her trembling.

Adora's mind started to cloud. The needle bit again. Black spots flickered in her vision. She raised her still clenched fist and focused on stiffly petting Melog. The string felt like it was made of barbed wire, scraping and tearing her flesh as it was pulled through. Melog licked her hand and mewed. Their tongue felt so alien. It left a tingling sensation on her skin that she could have sworn she could see glowing through her eyelids. The sensation was almost enough to distract Adora from the next stitch. Almost.

She ground her teeth and let out another half scream as the walls of her arm were forced back together. The suture came together at an agonizingly slow pace. Catra worked as fast as she was able, but to Adora each stitch lasted an eternity.

"Almost there," she heard Catra say. She sounded distant, like Adora was underwater, but even so the distress in her voice was clear.

The next sting was not as sharp. The blaze in Adora's arm began to dull. Her muscles relaxed involuntarily and her eyes drooped. She almost didn't feel the string follow the needle. She barely noticed the final stitch. Adora felt her flesh knit back together, but the pain registered as if she was merely observing.

"Done!" Catra gasped with relief obvious to even Adora's clouded senses. Catra wiped her bloody hands on the sheet and caught her breath. She extended a claw and cut the string where it protruded from Adora's skin. She released Adora's arm to dig through the medkit. Adora's arm dropped limp as soon as Catra released it. It was still slick with blood and would have left a lovely stain on her pants were they not already painted in gore.

"Damn it, keep your arm up," Catra muttered, retrieving a strip of gauze and a wet rag. Adora's head felt light. Her thoughts were hazy, but she didn't hurt anymore. The pain was more of a distant ache now. She didn't feel Catra lift her arm into position.

Pressure Adora had forgotten was even there released as Catra untied the tourniquet. She ran the rag over Adora's bloodied arm, dabbing with extraordinary care around the stitches. Satisfied that most of the blood was gone, she unwound the gauze and began to gingerly wrap it around Adora's arm.

Adora stared in awe at her girlfriend. Her fur matted with blood, her adorably determined face scrunched in concentration, her short dark hair ruffled in a sweaty mess. "Gosh you're pretty," Adora slurred through a slacked jaw.

Catra cocked an eyebrow, not looking up from her work. "What?"

"I said y'er really pretty," Adora repeated, grinning stupidly and leaning forward a little.

"Riiight..." Catra pulled away from the kiss. Adora fell forward instead and landed giggling on Catra's chest. Her fur was so soft. She was like a big fluffy pillow that breathed. Adora was suddenly very sleepy.

She made out the faint sound of a familiar *fwoosh*. "How is she?"

"I just finished stitching up her arm. She'll live, but she lost a lot of blood. I need to check her other injuries too; I think she might have a concussion and I'm not sure if that blood on her stomach is from her arm or not."

Adora raised her head from Catra's shoulder and squinted through groggy eyes. "Hiii Glimmerrrr," she moaned. Moving her head shifted her weight and she started to fall forward. Catra hastily caught her before she hit the bed.

"Do you know what's wrong with her?" Catra grunted as she forced Adora back upright.

"Did you give her any painkillers?" Catra nodded. "They can make you a little loopy if you're not used to them," Glimmer explained.

Adora's entire body felt so relaxed. Her limp muscles flopped her backwards onto the bed.

"And sleepy," she heard Glimmer distantly say. Adora shut her eyes and collapsed.

-

It was dark when Adora woke. She was situated atop a veritable throne of pillows, her left arm propped up, wrapped in gauze. The tent looked like the scene of a murder. A pile of bloodied and torn clothes and sheets lay piled in the corner. Gore was still soaked into the ground and the air reeked of rubbing alcohol. At some point somebody had changed her pants and removed her bra. She wore a loose fitting sleeveless shirt, the night air chilly on her bare skin.

Melog was draped across her lap, much larger than last she saw them. Their eyes were closed and they looked like they were sleeping, although Adora wasn't sure if they actually slept.

"Hey, Adora," Catra said in a hollow voice. She sat on the end of the bed, resting her chin on her knees and staring out the gap at the bottom of the tent flap. A light drizzle tapped at the roof of the tent.

Adora grunted as she shifted around a little. "How did you know I was awake?" she croaked. Her throat was parched.

Catra turned around and handed Adora a water bottle which she accepted gratefully. It was warm but she drank greedily. "Melog told me."

Adora eyed the gently glowing creature draped across her lap. They moved a little as Adora squirmed her legs under them. Her legs hurt. Her entire body hurt, actually. And not just her various wounds, all her muscles were throbbing. She usually felt a slight ache after transforming, but this was much more than that. It was like She-Ra had pulled every muscle in her body.

Adora gasped as she finished the water in one gulp. She tried to set it beside the bed but it slipped out of her sweaty fingers. "What happened?"

"There was a total of twenty nine bots. Three of the clones were killed, the rest captured. They're being held in Tyrsdale for the time being."

That was a lot more than they had anticipated at the briefing. Adora began to remember more of the battle. "Was anyone else hurt?"

"Lots of minor burns and lacerations, a few broken bones, one woman lost a finger, but nothing life threatening. Bow's got a pretty nasty plasma burn on his leg, and Glimmer's back is sore from carrying the mission." Adora laughed at that one.

"Ow, fuck," she gasped, reaching her good arm to clutch her chest. Her chest burned when she applied even light pressure. "I think I broke a rib."

Catra scoffed and turned her back to Adora. "Gee, you think that was from dropping a hundred feet onto a squad of bots, or from the point blank anti-aircraft shell?"

Definitely the anti-aircraft shell, Adora thought. That probably wasn't the best thing to say though. "Sorry," she mumbled instead.

Catra turned and glared at her. "Sorry? *SORRY?!*" Tears began to rise. "You nearly fucking died! I was terrified! I-" Catra choked on her words. Melog gently mewed and set their tail on her leg. She nodded her head and took a deep breath (she was getting good at those).

"Come on, I want to check you for a concussion." Catra scooted closer and leaned over Melog. "How many fingers?" she asked, raising a finger and moving it slowly back and forth in front of Adora's eyes.

"One," Adora replied, tracking the finger with ease. Catra's fur looked freshly scrubbed, but there was still blood dried under her claws that Adora knew would take days to get out.

"Nausea or headache?" Adora shook her head. Catra leaned back with a sigh. "Well at least that's one less thing to worry about. How are your ribs feeling?"

"Only hurts when I laugh." Adora winced. "Or when I breathe..." she muttered.

They sat in silence for a moment. Adora's eyes drifted to her left arm. The bandages were slightly red, though that was likely due to blood that was still on her arm when they were applied. She was relieved to find she could still move her fingers, if painfully.

"Were there... any other injuries?" Adora asked cautiously.

Catra sighed heavily. "A lot of minor cuts and burns for starters. You just discovered the rib, and your arm is obviously fucked, but thankfully not infected. Can't say the same for that cut on your stomach though."

Adora looked down in confusion. She lifted her shirt and found her stomach wrapped in gauze. She couldn't see any blood on the wrappings but she remembered where the wound was.

"The cut is shallow, but there's some sort of weird magical infection," Catra continued. "Or maybe poison, but it hasn't necrotized so probably not. It kinda glowed green and wouldn't clean up. Glimmer said they could figure it out in Mystacor."

Adora lowered her shirt and stared at the sheets. She remembered how the blade had cut through She-Ra's indestructible skin, how it left a wound in the exact shape as from the Heart. "It's Prime," she whispered.

"What?!" Catra's ears flattened and her tail puffed up. Melog shifted in hue and began to shimmer a little.

"No! No, I mean-" That didn't come out right. Adora sighed and cringed as her rib bothered her. "At the Heart, when Prime sent the anti-She-Ra monster to stop me, it hit me at that spot. That's where the infection started."

Catra relaxed slightly and Melog returned to a blue, darker than before. Realization played across her face. "So, the infection..."

"It's still there," Adora finished. Catra's brow furrowed in thought. "There's more," Adora said, her voice growing hoarse.

"I was injured while I was still She-Ra." Catra's eyes went wide. "A clone got me with a sword and it went right through." Adora looked up at Catra's eyes, searching for answers. "Normally I'm bulletproof as She-Ra, but now..."

They both were silent. Adora didn't have to ask what Catra was thinking because she was thinking the same thing: She-Ra isn't invincible anymore. She couldn't charge recklessly into battle anymore. They got lucky that it was a relatively minor injury this time. Adora was at far greater risk today than any of them had realized. Things could have gone very differently.

Catra pulled her knees to her chest and wrapped her tail around her ankles. Adora had to say something.

"Catra, I-"

"Rest," Catra cut her off, voice low. "The others are staying in Tyrsdale with the wounded. They'll be here in the morning to pack up camp."

"Catra, wait-"

"I need some air. Try to get some sleep."

Catra was out the tent before Adora could stop her. She tried to stand and follow her, but if the pain splitting through her chest hadn't stopped her, Melog sat on her legs would have. They looked Adora in the eye and gave a mew while slowly blinking.

Adora couldn't understand them, but she guessed the meaning: *"Give her space."*

Melog's mane returned to its calm light blue. Catra would be alright. She was right, Adora needed to rest. Adora eased back into her pillow throne, making herself as comfortable as was possible. Melog began to purr and tucked their head into their stomach. Adora rested her head on the pillows and realized how exhausted she was. She shut her eyes and swiftly fell into a dreamless sleep.

Chapter End Notes

> The Horde didn't have painkillers so neither of them knew that they take a minute to kick in. Or that they can make you high. Also, I don't know anything about battlefield surgery or medical care, so I apologize for how painfully inaccurate that probably was.

Interlude

Chapter Summary

> As the gang heads for Mystacor to get help for Adora, she has trouble letting herself be taken care of.

Chapter Notes

> Content warning for general pain but nothing graphic, just an emotional conversation with Bow. The worst of it is over, now we're in for a long and angsty ride.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Hey! Are you guys-"

Adora woke with a start and made the mistake of instinctively reaching for her knife. It was nowhere to be found but her bad arm still groped for it beneath the pillow. She was hit in unison by a wave of pain from her broken rib and her injured arm. She grunted through her teeth and painfully raised her head.

"I, uh. I'll come back in a bit." Glimmer disappeared in a shower of sparkles. Adora sighed and let her head fall back against her pillow. It was damp with sweat.

"Let me see," Catra said, reaching across Adora's chest. How long had she been there? Last Adora remembered, Catra was running off into the night. Catra gently unwrapped her arm and checked the stitches. Satisfied, she wound the gauze back and released her arm.

Catra stretched her arms above her head and her legs across Melog (and made a squeaky little yawn that was just about the most adorable thing Adora had ever seen in her entire god damn life) and stood up. Melog shrank down to their regular size and followed. Adora noticed sunlight seeping in through the flap of the

tent. It was late. Adora had somehow slept through Catra climbing into bed with her and slept straight into mid-morning.

Adora swung her legs over the edge of the bed and immediately doubled over in pain. Bending over then put more pressure on her ribs, making it even worse. Catra was next to her in an instant, a hand on Adora's good shoulder.

"Easy," Catra said softly. "Take a few minutes to wake up, I'll help clean up the camp."

Adora gritted her teeth and forced a smile. She nodded and Catra reluctantly pulled away. Catra gave Melog a look before she left.

Adora steadied her breathing and adjusted to the ache in her ribs. Her left arm turned useless with pain whenever she tried to move it. Her legs were asleep and her entire body ached. The cut on her side radiated pulses of pain in time with her heartbeat, leaving a terrifying numbness between them. It felt cold.

Melog rubbed against her shin and Adora came back to the present. The prickly sensation in her legs had dissipated. Adora slowly stood up, testing her weight. Melog grew to meet her height and Adora gratefully rested her good arm on them. After a moment Adora painfully stood on her own. Her ribs screamed at her for every second she was on her feet. The chilling numbness from the wound on her stomach seeped down into her leg a little, making it hard to stand on.

Now that she had regained at least partial motor control, Adora began on her regular morning checklist. She stumbled towards her pack and started to reach down. Pain shot through her chest as she bent over. Melog ran to her side but she pushed them away. She had always taken care of herself and always would. She retrieved a bottle of warm water and drank it in one long gulp.

Next she dug out a fresh set of clothes. Pants first, she'll deal with her arm when she got there. Adora kicked her current pants

aside, an unfamiliar pair that was a little too big and strikingly pink, and bent over to pull on the fresh pair.

Melog growled and gently tugged at the pants. Adora shoved them off and took the pants with both arms. She could take care of herself. Adora raised her right leg first. She bit her cheek as pain erupted through her chest. Suddenly her head started to spin. Adora slammed her foot back down too hard and caught her balance.

She couldn't do anything in such pain. Maybe she could draw on She-Ra to lessen the burden. It had been a bit since the battle, surely her head had cleared enough to focus by now.

Adora squared her feet and took as deep of a breath as she could through her broken rib. She extended her right arm in front of her and shut her eyes. If she could heal herself with She-Ra, she would be fine. Magic flickered in her palm for a fraction of a second. But as soon as it arrived, the creeping numbness in her stomach erupted upwards. It shot through her arm and down her leg.

Adora's knee buckled beneath her and she tumbled downwards. Melog rushed to cushion her fall, but Adora still landed face down. This time she couldn't suppress a scream as she landed on her ribs.

And so Catra and Glimmer found her, laying across Melog, pants halfway around her ankles, nearly blacked out in pain.

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Catra refused to let Glimmer teleport them to Mystacor. In Adora's condition, the jarring landing that often came with Glimmer's teleports would not be healthy. She also seemed worried that Glimmer would somehow leave the stitches behind. Adora tried to reassure her that she would be fine, Glimmer had been teleporting her around for years, but Catra would hear none of it.

Glimmer yielded surprisingly quickly. Tyrsdale was gracious enough to lend them a cart which Swift Wind pulled along so Adora and Bow could rest along the way. Neither of them were in any condition to walk to Mystacor, what with Bow's leg and Adora's everything. The guards headed back to Bright Moon with their prisoners while the Best Friends Squad turned towards Mystacor.

Despite the frankly ludicrous amount of pillows supplied to cushion her, the road was still painfully bumpy on Adora's tender body. She and Bow rested in the cart, while Catra, Glimmer, and Melog took point to keep an eye out for trouble. Can't be too careful considering how many clones were still unaccounted for and how many space-bandits had been popping up. Adora also suspected that Catra wanted to avoid a long and emotional conversation.

Being stuck in a cart with Bow, Adora did not have such a luxury.

"Soooo," he started, "how ya holdin' up?"

"I'm alright, just pretty sore," Adora lied. In truth, her ribs made her cringe with every breath, her arm threatened to cripple her with pain every time she so much as thought about moving it, every muscle in her body ached, and that freezing numbness had spread far beyond the cut on her stomach. "How about you? That burn looks pretty bad."

"'Cuz it is," Bow answered nonchalantly. "I cannot wait to get to Mystacor. I'm going to lather my leg in every healing salve they have and pass out for a *week*." He threw his head back and dramatically sighed to the heavens.

"Why don't you have Glimmer teleport you ahead? We're only going the slow way for me." *You shouldn't have to suffer for my weakness.*

"Hey," Bow said, raising an elbow to jab her in the ribs then thinking better of it, "we're the Best Friends Squad." He offered

one of his trademark reassuring smiles. "We stick together."

Adora returned the smile as best she could. For a while, only the steady clop of Swift Wind's hooves and the rumbling of the cart interrupted her thoughts.

"So," Bow said again, very softly, "you doing okay?"

"Yeah, like I said, mostly just sore," Adora replied. She knew where this was going.

"No, I can see that," Bow said, gesturing to her bandaged arm. "What I mean is: how are you feeling?"

Yep. There it is. Good old Bow, always so bafflingly open with emotions. Normally it was quite refreshing, having someone so open to talk to. But this time it felt somehow different, Adora felt more vulnerable for some reason. Like she was going to get in trouble for talking about or even acknowledging it, whatever "it" was. But she was stuck on a cart with Bow for the next couple days and there was no getting out of this one.

"I..." Adora took a deep breath, deeper than her ribs allowed. She drank the pain. "I couldn't put my hair up this morning." Bow gave her a quizzical look and Adora laughed despite herself.

"I couldn't make my own hair," she repeated, shaking her head. "My right arm was half numb, and my left was, well." Adora gave a half shrug, lifting her injured arm as much as she dared (which was not at all). "Catra had to tie it up for me." She stared blankly ahead. "If I can't even take care of myself, how am I supposed to protect anyone?" she whispered.

"Why do you feel like you need to protect anyone?" Bow gently asked.

"Because I'm She-Ra!" Adora shouted, incredulous. "That's my job! What good is all this power if I can't use it to help?" *What good am I if I can't use it to help?*

Adora sighed painfully and sagged back into the pillows. She felt Bow's eyes on her and knew she had to say it. "I... I just feel so. Worthless." She mumbled the words, barely loud enough to hear herself.

"Your job doesn't define who you are, Adora. Your worth isn't determined by how useful you are, only you can decide that." Bow locked eyes with her, intensely but comfortingly. "You don't have to prove to any us that you're worthy of love; we'll love you regardless."

"I know," Adora snapped back, harsher than she intended. She'd heard it before. From Mara, from Catra. "I know. But I can't help it. Some part of my mind is always telling me that I *can* be better so I *should* be better." Adora raised her right hand and stared forlornly at her outstretched palm. "Now I'm not even sure I can be better."

"We don't want you to be better," Bow said as softly as he could. "We want you to be *you*. All of you. Whatever your faults and problems, we want to be with you and we want to help you."

A lump formed in Adora's throat. "But you shouldn't have to deal with my problems," she choked out. Damn it. Now she was crying.

"But we *want* to, Adora. We *want* to deal with your problems because we love you and we want to help you." Bow scooted over and set his hand lightly on Adora's shoulder. She had a feeling that if it weren't for her numerous injuries, he would have gone for a hug.

"Have you talked to Catra about this?" Bow asked after a moment. Adora shook her head. "You should try. Glimmer said she was really worried about you."

"What?"

"Last night after the battle, Catra came to see Glimmer. They just talked for a couple hours."

Adora's chest swelled unconsciously with pride. "Catra went to her friends for help?" Bow grinned and nodded. Adora's smile slowly faded. "Catra went through so much and she has so much to deal with. She's come so far and I'm so proud of her. I don't want to pile my problems on top of her own."

"By not working on it, you're placing an even bigger burden on her." Adora looked up at Bow. "She was terrified yesterday, Adora. Glimmer said she hadn't seen her that scared since we rescued her." Adora's heart shattered as Bow spoke. "If you talk to her about what's going on, she can help you. And by helping yourself, you'll be helping Catra too."

A knot twisted in Adora's stomach. She sat and stared at the road retreating in their wake. She was silent for what felt like hours.

"Thanks, Bow," she finally whispered.

Chapter End Notes

Extra chapter today because this one's short and didn't need much proofreading and I just finished a rewatch of the show and need to channel all this energy somewhere.

Open Wounds

Chapter Summary

> The gang arrives in Mystacor and Castaspella inspects Adora's wounds. They're not good.

Chapter Notes

> Content warning: Pain and semi-graphic depictions of wounds, this time as Castaspella inspects Adora's injuries. Also another disclaimer that I don't know anything about medical stuff, so I apologize for the likely medically unsound treatment.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It was growing dark on the second day of their travels when cliffs marking the entrance to Mystacor dropped away before them. An island materialized out of the clouds and floated surprisingly gently into the cliffside. The fog parted and revealed a small throng of people crowded onto it. Glimmer must have teleported ahead to warn them. They were garbed mostly in white and green robes. Several carried satchels visibly bursting with herbs and potions, and they bore two stretchers. Adora managed to twist around in time to spot Glimmer's Aunt, Castaspella, practically sprinting towards them, holding the hem of her dress as to not trip.

"Glimmer, darling!" she shouted, immediately scooping Glimmer up into a crushing spin of a hug. She just as quickly set her down and hurried over to the cart. She took one stern look at Bow and a longer, very concerned look at Adora.

Before Adora could get a greeting out, Castaspella was on a veritable rant. "Oh goodness, Bow, darling, that looks terrible. And Adora! My word! You need medical attention immediately. Stretcher!"

The stretchers were rushed over to the cart. The medics moved Bow easily onto the stretcher, but hesitated with Adora. They exchanged a few quick words and gently reached around her back and legs. On the count of three and with a small spell of some sort, Adora was swiftly lifted onto the stretcher. The impact was surprisingly light but still enough to make her gasp.

"Oh you poor thing!" Castaspella continued before Adora, or anyone for that matter, could say anything. "Glimmer, darling, why on Etheria didn't you teleport her straight here? These wounds have only gotten worse with time!"

"Sorry, Aunt Casta," Glimmer was finally able to say. "I was worried about teleporting her so far with her ribs, I wasn't sure she would be able to take the landing."

Adora was about to add something, but again before she could open her mouth, her stretcher was being whisked away. It floated of its own accord and was remarkably, and very comfortably, stable. Even as it drifted onto the island, Adora felt not a bump. If it wasn't for her eyes, she wouldn't have even noticed she was moving.

She rolled her head to the right to get a view of Bow. She could barely see past the swarm of doctors surrounding her, but she managed to glimpse him talking with Glimmer and one of the medics. She couldn't hear anything he said over the frenzy of orders Castaspella was shouting at the assorted doctors. Swift Wind trailed behind, an apprehensive look cast on his face, but the crowd was too thick to approach Adora.

Adora looked to her left and felt worry set in her stomach. Where was Catra? She couldn't see her anywhere past the blizzard of white and green robes. Why was she so nervous? She was with the best doctors in Etheria, she had been through worse medical checkups. But some core part of her needed to know Catra was with her.

"Catra?" Adora said as loudly as her ribs allowed. "Catra!" she shouted painfully this time.

"Hey," came a soft whisper beside the stretcher. Two of the doctors were forced aside by Melog's massive bulk. Their mane was purple and beginning to shimmer slightly. Catra reached down and set a comforting hand on Adora's wrist.

"Careful, do not touch the patient!" Castaspella shouted from across Adora. Catra's fur ruffled and her hand shot back, snapping to attention at her waist. Melog shifted to a bloody crimson as they darted beneath the stretcher to stand between Adora and Castaspella.

"No, it's okay," Adora interjected before things got out of hand. "Catra's my girlfriend, she can stay." Adora looked back at Catra. She smiled faintly but her tail was still fluffed and Melog was still red.

"I understand that, honey, but..." Castaspella glanced at Catra and lowered her voice conspiratorially. "Are you sure it's a good idea to have *her* around right now?" Adora heard Catra draw in a sharp breath. A threatening growl rumbled from Melog as they forced Castaspella back.

It took Adora a second to understand the question, but the burning in her chest was swiftly replaced with a burning in her heart.

"*Yes,*" Adora said in a voice stern as steel. She reached out with her bad arm and clumsily took Catra by the hand, pulling her closer to the stretcher, excruciating pain be damned. "Catra stays." *And if I hear you say another bad thing about her, I will beat that halo off your head,* she almost said. Instead, Adora bit her tongue and squeezed Catra's hand tighter, glaring at Castaspella. Castaspella still had to heal her first.

Castaspella stiffened and took a step back. That had at least shut her up. She was silent for the remainder of the trip, wherever she

was taking them. Adora didn't release her grip on Catra's hand the entire way.

Swift Wind was left at the door, stamping his hooves anxiously, too big to fit inside. Adora couldn't hear his voice, but she could feel his worry through their bond. Adora squeezed Catra's hand as a response, knowing he would feel that too.

Eventually the arched ceilings of Mystacor's labyrinthine halls gave way to a brightly lit dome. It smelled strongly of disinfectant and cleaning supplies. The stretcher floated to a stop in the exact center, apparently locking on to some sort of magical magnet in the floor.

The medics fanned out in a frenzy of activity, pulling over various rolling tables stuffed with alembics and herbs. They slowly filtered out of the room as Castaspella waved them away.

Adora watched the healers leave with slight alarm. "Are you a doctor?"

"I am trained in healing magic, if that's what you're asking," Castaspella replied without looking up from a hoard of medical supplies. "Everyone had to learn at least some degree of healing during the war," she added with a glance over Adora's shoulder. Adora felt a growl faintly rumble from behind her, though from Catra or Melog she wasn't sure.

"Alright, let's get a look at you," Castaspella said, pulling on a pair of surgical gloves. She bent over to remove Adora's shirt when a roar came from Melog.

Adora rolled her head and gave Catra as close to a reassuring smile as she could muster. "It's okay," she whispered, squeezing her hand. Catra glanced at Castaspella and nodded to Adora. She returned the gentle squeeze and reluctantly backed away.

Castaspella quickly got to work. She waved her hand and Adora's oversized shirt promptly removed itself. Adora blushed furiously

and averted her eyes from Castaspella's as a towel was mercifully draped across her chest.

Castaspella spun her finger and formed a glowing green magical circle in her palm. The magical glow felt strangely warm across Adora's aching muscles. It almost tickled beneath her skin. She started at Adora's head.

"Minor scratch, no concussion..." At least it was confirmed she didn't have a concussion. The spell trailed down Adora's chest. "Four fractured ribs, three bruised..." Oof, that explained a lot.

"Two minor lacerations on the abdomen..." The spell changed slightly in hue. "Minor burn along the spine, significant bruising." Adora wasn't sure how Castaspella could see her back without turning her over.

The tickling disappeared entirely when the spell reached her stomach. Castaspella waved the bandages aside and frowned. Adora risked a glance down.

The wound was exactly the same size as before, a perfect indentation of the creature's serrated limb. The cut was shallow, but had not begun to heal at all. Crusted blood had formed up inside where Catra couldn't clean it off with a rag. An all too familiar green glow faintly emanated from the walls of the wound, pulsing in time with Adora's heart.

"Unknown magical infection, but otherwise shallow laceration," Castaspella muttered to herself as she continued along Adora. The bandages around Adora's left arm unwound themselves and Castaspella's brow worried itself further. "Severe laceration on left forearm, already stitched but infected..." She paused for a moment and met Adora's eyes.

"I'll start with your arm, I need to replace the stitches. Here, drink this." A vial of bright red liquid floated into Adora's good hand. "For the pain," Castaspella explained when Adora eyed the bottle suspiciously.

"Will it make me, uh, loopy?" Adora asked, trying to recall what Glimmer had said about painkillers. She didn't remember much about the side effects from last time, but what she could remember she didn't like.

Castaspella quirked an eyebrow. "Yes, numbing potions can cloud your head a little. Why?"

Catra chuckled coarsely from against the wall. "Let's just say she has a low tolerance." She sounded a little calmer to Adora. At least that made one of them.

"Ah, well, I could put you to sleep if you would prefer."

"Can't you just do it while I'm awake? I can handle the pain."

"Absolutely not," Castaspella said in a stern motherly voice. "Adora, I am about to put stitches in your arm, under no circumstances will you be awake and unnumbed for that."

Adora sighed, knowing that if Castaspella was anything like Glimmer, there was no use in arguing. "Alright, knock me out."

Castaspella twisted her fingers and formed a bright magenta arcane sigil in her hand. Adora took one look at it and instantly felt her body go limp. She tried to move, but her eyes willed themselves shut as her mind slipped horrifically fast into darkness.

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Adora shouted herself awake. She sat bolt upright, ribs screaming in protest. Her eyes darted around the room frantically. She tried to raise her fists into a guard position but only her right arm responded.

"Hey! Hey, Adora!" Adora's eyes finally settled on Catra's worry stricken face. Her mismatched yellow and blue eyes and the soft touch of her fur against Adora's arm soothed her. She leaned back into the pillows with a long sigh. She found it didn't hurt quite as

much as she had become used to these last couple days. Fuck, it still hurt though.

Castaspella practically kicked the door open. "What is it?! Are you okay?" She hurried to Adora's side and placed the back of her hand against Adora's forehead.

"Yeah, I'm fine," Adora said, catching her breath. "Just, uh, please never use a sleep spell on me again." It had happened far too quickly for Adora's comfort. With a drug she at least had to swallow it herself and had a few seconds' warning before she passed out. The sleep spell was nearly instantaneous and required merely a passing glance. Adora knew she wasn't in any danger, but her instincts overpowered her reason.

"Oh, yes, of course," Castaspella stammered, guilt playing through her eyes. She flattened her dress and stood up straight. "I suppose I can take this opportunity to go over your injuries," she said hesitantly. When Adora just stared at her and Catra settled into a more comfortable position on the bed, she cleared her throat.

"Well, for starters, four of your ribs are fractured and three are bruised. You'll have to go easy on them for a few weeks, but it shouldn't require any additional treatment. I've already amplified the healing process as much as I can." She began to pace across the room.

"Your arm was much worse off. The cut was very deep, almost to the bone, but it fortunately missed anything critical. It had also become infected, likely during your journey here. However," she paused, glancing at Catra, "it is good that it was stitched up so quickly. The blood loss would have been severe otherwise." She returned to Adora. "I've prescribed you some antibiotics for the infection and I'll have to check the stitches every now and then." Adora nodded.

Castaspella took a breath. "The wound on your abdomen is what concerns me the most. The cut itself is shallow, but there's some

sort of magical infection that is unlike anything I have ever seen before." She resumed her pacing. "It hasn't begun to heal at all on its own. I tried all the healing spells and remedies I know, but nothing had any effect on it." She came abruptly to a halt. "I've sent the case to the healers' class, they'll be able to come up with something better than I."

Adora nodded her head slowly. "The infection, it's-"

"From the Heart, I know." Adora looked at Castaspella in surprise. "Catra explained it to me," she said. "Prime must have augmented the anti-She-Ra magic of the First Ones to be more permanent." She paused and smiled warmly at Adora. "Don't worry, dear, I'm sure the healers will come up with something. They always have. Until then, you just need to stay off your feet and take it easy."

Adora's stomach twisted. "How long?" she asked shakily.

Castaspella cocked her head for a moment. "At least four weeks for your arm to heal."

Adora nearly choked on her tongue. "Four *weeks?!*"

"I'm sorry, but short of She-Ra, magic can only expedite the healing process so much," she explained. "You'll need a lot of rest if you want to recover properly."

"But, I-" Adora sputtered. She couldn't spend *four weeks* doing *nothing*. She would go insane.

"Don't worry," Catra interrupted. "I can keep her in bed," she said, lowering her voice. "Trust me." Adora blushed a little when Catra's eyes met hers.

"And none of that either," Castaspella said when she realized what was going on (it took her until Catra began tracing a claw around Adora's collarbone). She directed her attention at Adora with a stern look. "You need to rest. No strenuous activity or exercise, and certainly no She-Ra until we can figure out how to clean up that infection."

Adora opened her mouth but was silenced by Castaspella's death stare. She clamped her mouth shut and lowered her eyes.

Castaspella took a breath and relaxed her posture. "It's late, you should get some sleep. I'll be along in the morning." With that, she left, shutting the door quietly behind her.

"Finally," Catra sighed as soon as Castaspella was out of the room. "I thought she'd never shut up." She stood with a stretch, sauntering across the room to a small table stuffed with sweets. "I had Glimmer bring us some snacks, you want any? These jelly tarts are *amazing*."

Adora didn't respond. Catra took a bite from the jelly tart in her hand and set it down. She sat on the edge of the bed and ran her claws through Adora's untied hair. "You okay?"

Catra's voice startled Adora back to the present. She smiled weakly. "Yeah, just tired," Adora lied. Catra nodded and gave her a kiss on the forehead.

Adora sank back into the pillows, Catra wrapped around her good arm, and shut her eyes.

Chapter End Notes

> Guess Castaspella's a doctor now. And don't worry, she's just being over protective. She'll warm up to Catra when she realizes how much she loves Adora. I would like to call her Casta for the sake of how wordy Castaspella is, but Casta looks way too much like Catra when I'm proof reading, so we're stuck with Castaspella.

Old Wounds

Chapter Summary

> Adora can't sleep and she can't avoid an emotional conversation with Catra any longer.

Chapter Notes

> The longer this story goes on, the longer the chapters seem to get.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora's room was exactly fourteen and a half paces wide by nineteen paces long. She had hardly been allowed to leave it for three days and she was going to go *insane*. Castaspella had ordered that she get nothing but bed rest to let her body work on healing itself. Adora was allowed to go on a walk around the building, but only when someone (always Catra) was with her. The rest of the time she was stuck in her room.

The floor was smooth, purple with lavender patterns, and never felt cold underfoot. The ceiling was an intricate web of blue and silver threads set upon pink, winding across each other in nonsensical patterns. The pattern shifted every time Adora blinked and it was slowly driving her mad.

A wardrobe with drawers bigger inside than out sat in the left corner farthest from the door. Melog had made a nest of blankets atop it. A dark wooden dining table and three chairs were tucked into the right corner closest to the door, a desk diagonally opposite. Next to it, a small side room held the bathroom and shower. The only light source was a pair of lanterns by the door, but the entire room was always perfectly lit. A switch by the bed allowed the lights to be dimmed as low as desired.

A pair of east facing windows flanked the bed in the center of the room, which despite overlooking a thousand foot drop, Swift Wind

used them to visit regularly. Adora also enjoyed the sunlight waking her through the windows every morning - she still felt uncomfortable sleeping in very late, despite being directly ordered to by every doctor in Mystacor.

The bed was slightly inlaid into the wall, decadent pink sheets rising above. It was comfortably rigid to allow for easy standing, but still draped in luxuriously soft sheets. As many pillows as could fit were stuffed onto the end. It was also clearly designed for one person, but that didn't stop Catra from squeezing in. It restricted Adora's ability to best position her wounded body, but there was nowhere in the universe more comfortable than a bed with Catra in it. Catra had her own room down the hall, but Adora was pretty sure the door had never been opened.

Come to think of it, Catra had hardly left Adora's side the last three days. And yet, except for when the confines of the bed forced them together, she seemed very reluctant to be physically near to Adora. Catra was normally as touch starved as Adora, but they had scarcely held hands outside of bed. It could have been just because Catra was afraid of aggravating her injuries, but Adora suspected there was more to it than that. Something had been bugging Catra since the battle.

Despite being physically distant, she hovered around Adora wherever she went, hardly letting her out of her sight except to use the bathroom. It was as if she was afraid Adora would disappear as soon as she wasn't looking. On the few occasions when Catra left to get them something, usually food, she had Melog watch her instead. Adora was more concerned about her than anything else at this point.

Three excruciatingly long days of absolutely nothing had given Adora plenty of time to think about it. She knew they had to talk about the battle eventually. She had gone over a million different ways to talk to Catra about what happened, like Bow had suggested, but nothing sounded right. She just couldn't imagine how to do it without being a burden.

-

Adora couldn't sleep. It must have been nearly midnight. Catra had passed out an hour and a half ago, but Adora was restless. She was running mental circles trying to figure out how to talk to Catra. Her head was stuck in a loop and the air was too stuffy and the blankets were too warm but the bed was too cold and-

She needed a breather. Some fresh air, the wind in her face. Fucking *something*.

Adora looked down at Catra. She was out cold, and Adora could tell by the way her mouth hung open that she wasn't faking. A glance at the wardrobe told her Melog was also asleep, assuming they actually slept. She was pretty sure.

Adora gently unwound Catra's arm from her waste and slid out of bed. Standing put pressure on her ribs and she struggled for a moment to suppress a wheeze. Catra's arm curled into her chest as her whole body tucked itself in closer, tail wrapping around herself. Adora suppressed an undignified sound that would get her caught and pulled the blanket over Catra's shoulders.

Adora cautiously slipped on her jacket, wincing as she held her arm aloft, the sleeve only barely fitting over the cast. She grabbed her shoes, put her hair up, and with one last cursory glance at Melog's apparently sleeping form, made her escape. She closed the door as softly as possible and tiptoed down the hall. Only after the door to her room disappeared around the bend did she stop to put her shoes on. Her ribs chastised her as she propped her leg up on the wall. Maybe this wasn't the best idea.

But she needed air. She couldn't be inside any longer. Clinging to the walls more out of paranoia than necessity, Adora made her way outside. Her eyes adjusted poorly to the night; the invisibility field around the city seemed to make it unnaturally dark. She finally managed to stumble across her destination.

"Swift Wind!" Adora whisper-yelled. "Swifty! Are you there?" She knew he was. Even through Prime's poison, she could feel his presence. A rustling confirmed her sixth sense.

"Ughhh, what?" Swift Wind stumbled his way out of the stables, eyes still half-lidded. "Adora?" he mumbled, rubbing his eyes with a wing. "What are you doing here? It's the middle of the night!"

"I-uh," Adora hadn't actually thought this far ahead. "I need to go for a ride." Swift Wind raised an eyebrow (wait, do horses have eyebrows?). "Please, Swifty, I've been stuck inside for *days* and I'm going to go insane! I just need some fresh air on my face."

Swift Wind squinted at her. "There's a reason they've got you cooped up, you know."

"I know!" Adora cut him off. "I know, I need to rest, my body needs to heal, yadda yadda yadda. But I need to do *something*." She gave him her best puppy dog eyes. "Please?"

Swift Wind stamped his hooves nervously. "I get it, Adora, but I'm really not sure this is a good idea. If you're so certain about this, why not ask Castaspella tomorrow? I'm sure she'll understand."

Adora rolled her eyes. "Except she won't! She hardly lets me leave the room on my own! Besides, I can't sleep right now and a little bit of riding will help me decompress."

"I-ehh-well-" Swift Wind stuttered.

"Hey, Adora," a cool voice called from behind. Shit! How did she know?

"Oh thank goodness, Catra!" Swift Wind practically collapsed in relief.

"Whatcha doin'?" Catra asked, sauntering towards them.

"Catra! Hi, I was, just, uhm-" Adora sighed. There was no use, she'd been caught. "How did you know?"

In response, Melog materialized out of Catra's shadow and mewed at her. Adora glared at the mischievous little space cat. She knew it! They didn't sleep after all! Or maybe she just wasn't as stealthy as she believed.

"Go to bed, Swift Wind, I'll take it from here," Catra said, chuckling a little at Adora's reaction.

"Yes! Thank you!" Without another word Swift Wind was back in the stables and already snoring by the time he laid down.

"Come on," Catra said, extending her hand to Adora. She took it and let her girlfriend lead her across the field. The sky shimmered faintly beneath the ever present glow of the immense spell that kept Mystacor hidden from the rest of Etheria. The light of the moons distorted slightly as they shone through the barrier, the stars twinkled faintly between the shimmers of magic.

The grassy field sloped to an end at a small sandy beach, beyond which lay naught but clouds. Catra eased Adora into a sitting position and swung her legs over the edge of the grass.

"So, wanna explain what that was about?" Catra asked. Any trace of previous humor at the situation had vanished.

Adora sighed. Guess it would be now. "I couldn't sleep, I just needed to clear my head. I thought a ride with Swift Wind would help me think."

"About what?" Adora sucked in a breath. A sharp pain split her chest. No avoiding it now.

"About... how to talk to you. About what happened at the battle." Catra sat up straighter. She met Adora's eyes and silently urged her on. Here goes.

"Catra, I'm sorry." Adora blurted out. "I'm sorry I got hurt and scared you, I- I didn't know She-Ra could get hurt like that."

"I'm not worried about She-Ra," Catra scoffed. "I'm worried about you, Adora." Catra stared sternly at Adora. "Would you still be sorry if you hadn't gotten hurt?"

"What?"

"If you hadn't gotten hurt, would you still be sorry?" Catra repeated. When Adora didn't reply, she continued, "I'm not upset that you got hurt, I'm upset that you put yourself in that position to begin with. That plan was needlessly dangerous for you and you know it. I can think of three different ways off the top of my head to approach that that didn't involve turning you into a human firing range."

Catra shook her head. "And then you charged headfirst into battle, after taking a point blank fucking cannon, injured and without She-Ra!" Tears began to form in her eyes. "Were you *trying* to get yourself killed?!"

Adora stammered before Catra's anger. "No! But, somebody could have gotten hurt, I-"

"Somebody did get hurt!" Catra roared. "You did!" Adora shut her mouth.

Catra smoothed her tail and sighed. "We can take care of ourselves, Adora. You don't always have to take all the heat for us. Even if you can take it, that doesn't mean you should." Catra jabbed lightly at the bandages beneath Adora's sleeve. "This is what it leads to."

Adora felt tears rise in her eyes. "I know." Catra crossed her arms. "Really, I know. I know you can take care of yourself and I know I don't have to take the punishment like that, but..." Adora paused. Her breath was shaky. Catra's face softened. She put her hand on Adora's shoulder and gently squeezed.

"I just can't help it. Whenever I try to let somebody else take care of things, my brain screams at me until I'm forced into action."

"Is that why you can't sleep?" Catra asked softly.

Adora opened her mouth but felt a sob coming. She bit her tongue and tore her eyes away from Catra's.

Catra scooted closer and rubbed her hand lightly across Adora's back. "Hey, talk to me."

Adora shook her head and failed to suppress a sob. "I- I don't, I don't want to be-" she stumbled for an excuse to stop talking.

"Hey." Catra took her by the chin and gently turned her face. "You look out for me, and I look out for you, remember?" Fresh tears welled up in Adora's eyes as she nodded. Catra gave her an impossibly kind smile. "Tell me what's wrong."

Adora looked away again. "I. I feel so *useless* like this. Stuck in bed, being taken care of. I need to *do* something. Or else somebody..." *Will get hurt. Will hate me. Will realize how worthless I am.* She was cut off by a barely suppressed sob.

"You're still trying to keep our scores up..." Catra mused, concluding Adora's thought. Adora said nothing as tears fell helplessly down her cheeks.

Adora couldn't hold her emotions back anymore. "I'm so sorry," she choked out. She looked at Catra but couldn't see her through clouded eyes. "I'm so so so sorry."

"Hey, come here," Catra whispered, pulling Adora in against her chest. Adora let herself rest on her good shoulder as much as she could and buried her face in Catra's scruffy neck fur. She sniffed back a sob but tears fell regardless. "It's okay, you're okay now."

Adora tried to pull away but Catra's hands gently held her in place. "No! No, it's not okay! I could have died! I don't want to die, but I can't help it, I don't know how to sto-o-o-op..." Her last word descended into a cascade of sobs.

"Shh, you're okay now," Catra whispered. She began to gently purr against Adora's scalp. Tucked into her neck like that, Adora's entire head felt like it was being rocked by Catra's purr. Almost immediately her breathing began to even out. Her heartbeat calmed and the blood rushing through her ears quieted.

The barrier overhead was almost audible in the still calm of the night. Its gentle hum made up for the absence of crickets and frogs on the magical island. The winds blew powerfully so high up, even through the barrier. It chilled Adora through her jacket and she clung closer to Catra.

For the first time since she arrived, Adora began to feel sleepy. Not tired, exhausted to the point of collapse, but comfortably sleepy, ready to curl up and go to bed. So sleepy was she that she hardly noticed when Catra slowly stood them up. Adora had to lean over to remain resting on Catra's shoulder. Melog walked along her other side, helping support her ribs, which had quieted in their aching. Catra purred the whole way back to their room (probably because she thought it was the only thing keeping Adora agreeable and didn't want to risk losing a chance at letting her sleep). They limped through the dark halls, Adora barely aware of anything but Catra's purring.

Adora heard the door shut behind them and soon found herself on the bed, still tucked into Catra's collarbone. Catra pulled the blanket up over their shoulders and gently undid Adora's ponytail.

It caught Adora off guard this time. She couldn't stop the tears as she began to weep into Catra's shoulder. Tears and snot ruined her perfectly lovely fur. Mortified, Adora tried to pull away but Catra's claws pulled her in tighter.

Catra tucked Adora into her chest as she purred even louder, as if it would make the pain go away. Adora was sobbing now, hyperventilating a little between breaths. Catra rested one hand on the base of Adora's neck and the other on her back beneath her shirt and rubbed her thumbs in little circles. Her tail coiled

around Adora's leg under the blanket. Adora wrapped her arms around Catra, left arm on top, and held her tight.

Adora couldn't stop crying. She thought she was done, but wrapped up in Catra's arms, her purring the only thing she could hear, she felt so warm and so *safe*. Safer than she'd ever felt in her life. A lifetime of hardship was let out in a single cathartic release. Adora cried until she was out of tears, then she kept heaving without them. Catra's purr remained steady throughout the whole ordeal, her thumbs never faltering in rhythm.

Eventually Adora's breathing began to even out. Catra's purring grounded her and she relaxed fully into Catra's arms. She was still wearing her jacket and boots, but being so completely enveloped in Catra, Adora had never felt more comfortable. All she could see was Catra's scruffy fur, all she could hear was Catra's comforting purring, all she could feel was Catra's gently massaging hands. Even her head was filled with Catra, as her scent and her intoxicating purr rumbled around her brain, lulling her thoughts.

"I love you," Adora mumbled into Catra's chest. "I love you," she said again because no words could ever express how much she meant it. Catra purred louder in response and Adora let herself fall away into Catra's loving embrace.

-

Adora was still swaddled in Catra when she woke. She had never slept so soundly in her life. Her legs were cramped and her right arm was numb from laying under Catra all night, but Adora felt good. Lighter. Like she had released an enormous weight she didn't realize she had been carrying.

Catra was already awake, staring at nothing. She hadn't moved a muscle.

"Hey," Adora whispered with a smile and what she knew must have been one of those "dopey looks" Catra always teased her about. She leaned up to meet Catra's lips.

"Good afternoon," Catra whispered into Adora's kiss.

As they pulled away, they untangled their limbs from each other and stretched. Catra was right, based on the sun it must have been past noon. Castaspella would be here soon for her daily checkup. Adora's stomach growled audibly. She slowly rolled her legs off the bed and winced. The night had not been kind on her ribs. She carefully rose to her feet and wolfed down the few remaining jelly tarts. She'd have to ask Glimmer to send a proper feast up here later.

"So, I was thinking..." Catra started nervously. Adora swallowed her jelly tart in one bite and looked at Catra. "About last night." Adora's stomach twisted. Anxiety crept into her chest. She feigned a full mouth and nodded.

Catra sighed. "I can't help you," she said. Adora's chest seized. "I mean, I can be there for you, and hold you while you cry and tell you everything will be okay, but. I can't give you the help you really need. This shit is way out of my league to handle. But..." her voice trailed off as she looked at the floor. Melog mewed from atop the dresser and she sighed again. "But I think Perfuma might be able to help."

The phantom grip released Adora's chest as Catra continued. "I know she's not a professional therapist or whatever, but she's... better with this kind of stuff than I am. She's been very, uh, helpful for me and I don't know anyone else who can deal with emotional baggage like last night." Catra looked back at Adora, desperate for a reaction.

Feeling suddenly very on the spot, Adora stuttered, "Uh, okay. Sure." She gave her best shot at a reassuring smile.

"You're alright with this?" Catra asked with a hint of suspicion.

"Yeah." In all honesty, she was *not* looking forward to rehashing last night with Perfuma, but Catra was actually reaching out to her friends for help and damned if Adora wouldn't encourage that.

"Okay. I'll call her later." Who knows. It might even help.

Chapter End Notes

Delicious. Finally, some good fucking cuddling. Gotta build up to those fluffy moments. It's like painting - you need dark for your highlights to show.
I also wanted to thank everyone who's been leaving comments; I may not reply to them because I'm shy, but I read all of them and each one legitimately makes my day.

One Bite at a Time

Chapter Summary

> Adora takes the first step towards recovery and meets with Perfuma.

Chapter Notes

> Taking a bit of a break from Adora's physical health for the next few chapters while we focus on her mental health. We'll get back round to the infection in a bit, but while Castaspella works on finding a cure, Adora goes to therapy.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The meeting was scheduled for a little after noon. The session slot was thirty minutes long, but it's not like Perfuma was charging them. The time limit made Adora feel a lot better going into it though. It was reassuring to have a time limit to fall back on in case things got uncomfortable. Worst case scenario, she would only have to bite her tongue for thirty minutes.

Perfuma had chosen the library for their meeting, specifically a small study room in the back. She said in her message that she wanted it to be somewhere quiet and out of the way.

Quiet it certainly was, but not so out of the way. A steady buzz of sorcerers, scholars, and assorted smart people populated Mystacor's grand library. At any moment you could find one floating a hundred feet to the top shelf, one piling crumbling scrolls by the dozen onto a cart, and at least ten in some corner quite literally buried under a mound of books.

Thankfully, despite its popularity, the library's sheer size made it easy to avoid company (made it easy to get lost too). Anyone you did happen to stumble upon would rarely spare you a passing glance, so absorbed in their studies were they.

Adora and Catra followed Melog through the labyrinth of shelves. Apparently they could navigate just about anywhere, which was good because neither of them had any idea where they were going. Adora unconsciously fidgeted with her jacket sleeve as she walked. Catra walked close but refrained from touching her.

Eventually Melog came to a stop and mewed. The door to a small study room lay propped halfway open. A pink flower rested on the inner handle. Perfuma must already be waiting.

Adora took a deep breath. She shook the nerves out of her hand.

"Are you sure you don't want me to go in with you?" Catra asked. Adora had never seen Catra act so concerned before. Normally when Adora said she would be fine, Catra left it at that, but this was the third time she'd asked since they left their room. It was actually really sweet.

"No, I need to do this alone," Adora restated. She wouldn't be able to talk well if Catra was in the room. She probably wouldn't be able to talk well at all, actually, but that was beside the point. She knew there were things she wasn't ready to say in front of Catra.

Catra frowned but nodded. She understood. She beckoned Melog and found a chair nearby to lounge in.

Here we go.

Adora approached the open door. She hesitated. She heard someone move inside. Perfuma had heard her. No turning back now.

Adora knocked on the wall and stepped half a foot in. "Perfuma?" she called meekly.

"Adora! Oh, I'm so glad you could make it!" Perfuma looked up from a book and met Adora's eyes. She looked her usual uncannily cheery self. "Come in, sit down," she said, gesturing to a chair across from her.

Adora gently shut the door behind her and made her way to the table. A few flowers sprouted from the end touching the wall, but it was otherwise barren. Adora pulled up a desk chair of moderate size and extreme cushioning.

Adora stared at the table. "Just a moment," Perfuma said. She reached under the table and stashed her book in her bag. Adora looked anywhere else while she ruffled around her bag.

The room was small and cozy, a perfectly sized study nook for the aspiring sorcerer. A third chair was stashed in the corner farthest from the door and a stained glass window sat above the table. A dimmer switch like in the guest room allowed for light to be let in or sealed out entirely. It was currently about halfway between.

"Okay," Perfuma said, sitting back up straight and placing her hands on the desk. She beamed at Adora. Adora fidgeted in her chair, suddenly struggling to find a comfortable position.

"Before we get started, I just want to say that nothing that is said in this room will ever leave it unless you want it to." Perfuma's tone was all business. "I will not repeat anything you say to anyone else unless you specifically ask me to. Nobody outside this room will hear a word of what we talk about if you so wish."

Adora nodded her head and glanced nervously around the room, eyes settling on the door. "In fact, the librarian tells me that these rooms are magically sealed to stop sound, to make a quiet studying space," Perfuma added. "Nobody could eavesdrop on us if they tried."

That was... actually quite reassuring. Knowing the room was totally sealed took an unexpected weight off Adora's chest. She knew how good Catra's hearing was.

"So how'd I do?" Perfuma asked in a dramatically different tone of voice.

Adora blinked at her. "What?"

"Well, I've given some advice to people before, but I'm studying to become a proper therapist now. You're my first official patient!" Perfuma looked like she was about to burst with excitement. "How was my intro speech?"

"Uh. I don't know. Fine, I guess? I've never done anything like this before."

Perfuma nodded her head sagely and was lost in thought for a second. She blinked her face back to her usual pleasant smile.

"So, how are you?"

Fine, Adora caught herself almost saying. "I'm, uh, not the best," Adora managed to say instead. "Obviously." She looked down and picked at her fingernails.

"Is there anything in particular that's bothering you?" Perfuma asked. It was a nonspecific question that allowed for Adora to give as much or as little information as she wanted.

She gave a little bit. "I've been really restless," she said, risking a glance at Perfuma. She was listening attentively to Adora's every word.

"Like, ever since I've been, uh," Adora tripped on her words, "injured, I've been just so... bored. Everyone tells me I need to rest, and I know I do, but I can't just sit around and do *nothing*, you know? I always feel like there's something I should be doing, but there isn't. There's nothing I *can* be doing."

Adora realized she was beginning to ramble and stopped. Perfuma still smiled at her. After waiting a second to make sure she was finished speaking, Perfuma asked, "Do you have any hobbies?"

Adora stared blankly at her. "Any what?"

Perfuma chuckled a little. "Hobbies! You know, things you do for fun in your free time?"

"Oh, pshh, yeah, hobbies," Adora sputtered. "I got lots of those." She did not know what those were.

Perfuma's face did not betray a trace of disappointment or frustration. "What do you like to do in your free time?" she restated, mercifully skipping over the "hobby" confusion.

"Oh, well, I... uh..." Wait. What *did* she like to do? Fighting? Yeah, she liked sparring, punching things. But she couldn't say that. "I like... exercising?"

Perfuma frowned just a little. "Exercise is great, but it's also necessary, like eating or sleeping. I was thinking something purely recreational."

Shit. Okay, not exercise. What did she like to do? "I like to..." Think think think. Catra! She liked to cuddle with Catra. "To spend time with Catra?"

Perfuma smiled sweetly. "That's very sweet, but not exactly an activity. And Catra won't always be there when you have free time. Is there anything you like to do when you have time alone?"

Alone? Adora remembered how relaxing scouting missions with Swift Wind were. Just her, Swifty, and the air against her face. It was a nice way to get away from the war room. She couldn't say it like that though. "I like to go riding with Swift Wind."

"That's a good one," Yes! "but not very conducive to your current condition." Shit!

Adora squirmed in her chair. Her face felt like it was going to jump off her head and book it for the door like she was about ready to. Perfuma seemed to take notice.

"Well, let's brainstorm!" she declared, sounding very excited. "Let's see, Catra has taken up reading recently. What do you think about that?"

Adora thought about it for a moment. She was never any good at reading long texts in the Horde. She always got distracted and had to rely on Catra for the answers. It was embarrassing since she was supposed to be the star pupil, but Catra never seemed to mind quietly sneaking her the answers in a tight corner. Looking back, that made a lot more sense now. But she doubted she could sit still long enough to read a book, let alone for fun.

"No, I can't really, like, focus long enough to read," Adora said, cheeks reddening as she spoke. That came out bad. It sounded like she was stupid.

Perfuma nodded her head. "Okay, what about drawing?" she asked, thankfully moving on. She paused for a second. "Have you done any drawing before?"

"No, in the Horde we mostly had, uh, battle plans and maps. And after that I was so busy with the war..."

Perfuma's face lit up. "Of course! Cartography!"

Oh great, another word Adora didn't recognize. "Car- uh, what?"

Perfuma chuckled. "Cartography," she said a little slower. It was a big word, surely nobody knew what it was. "It's the art of making maps." Oh. Ohhhhh. Huh. "I think it would be a great fit for you!"

Adora considered. "Yeah, maybe. I like looking at maps, planning out, uh," shit, she's gotten militaristic again, "things." Good one, Adora.

Perfuma still beamed at her. "That's exactly why I think it will be perfect! It's something you're already familiar with that can serve as a creative outlet."

Adora fiddled with her sleeve. "Maybe," she mumbled. "But I've never, like, drawn anything before. I don't know if I'll be any good at it."

"That's the beauty of it! You don't have to be good at it, it's just for fun." Perfuma smiled but Adora still wasn't sure. It would probably just be more frustrating than anything else. She wasn't good with creative stuff. "Besides, I think you'll get the hang of it pretty quickly."

Adora was still unsure, but the idea had certainly taken root in her brain. She had a pretty good eye for terrain and battlefield layouts, she might be able to translate some of that to paper. It probably wouldn't be very pretty, but maps are supposed to be useful, not artistic, anyway.

"I could try," she said after a moment of thought. "But I don't know where to start." She could map out the courtyard? Or maybe parts of the Fright Zone, she remembered some areas pretty well.

"Well, we are in a library," Perfuma replied. "I'm sure they have plenty of maps and probably even a book or two about cartography in here somewhere. You could start by copying some maps from a book to get the feel of it. I bet the librarian would be able to point you in the right direction."

"Uh, okay, sure," Adora stumbled out. "I can ask them later." Her cheeks grew hot even thinking about creative stuff. She felt even more awkward beneath Perfuma's unwavering smile and attentive eyes. Trying to look at anything else, Adora stared out the window.

"So, would you like to meet again at the same time next week?" Perfuma finally asked after an uncomfortably long pause.

"Wait, was that it?" Adora accidentally said out loud. Surely it hadn't been thirty minutes already. And they hadn't even talked about anything emotional.

Perfuma shrugged. "Well, this seems like a good place to stop for today. Unless there's more you want to talk about?"

"No, no, it's fine, I just," Adora hesitated, "I just thought there would be more, you know, emotional stuff."

"We don't have to talk about anything like that until you're ready," Perfuma said. "Simpler things like this can be just as helpful as big emotional conversations."

Adora relaxed a little. "Okay."

"I'll see you next week then?"

"Yeah, see you then." That wasn't so bad.

-

Catra was on her in an instant, materializing from between the shelves with Melog on her heels.

"How'd it go?" she asked with just a hint of concern in her voice.

"It was good. Not as bad as I thought it would be." Catra visibly relaxed as she smiled warmly. "We'll have another meeting next week at the same time." Catra nodded as they followed Melog through the library. "She also said I should start a hobby."

Catra cocked her head a little. "Do you have anything in mind?"

"Yeah, Perfuma said I should start car..." Shit, what was it? "Car-to-, uh. Map making. She said I should try map making."

Catra giggled in that squeaky way that used to distract Adora so much. It still does, but now when she stares dumbly at Catra it's sweet instead of embarrassing. "Cartography, dumbass."

Adora came back to the present, cheeks reddened. "How come you knew what it was called?" she mumbled.

"It was covered in Force Captain orientation."

"*You* went to Force Captain orientation?"

Catra grinned. "No, but Scorpia did and she eventually told me everything." Adora laughed with Catra as they rounded the corner, arriving surprisingly quickly at the entrance.

"So do you have a plan to get started?" Catra asked.

"Yeah, Perfuma said I should ask the librarian for some maps. I'll probably do that later though." Adora wasn't in the mood to talk to a stranger about something she was kind of uncomfortable trying. She needed to take a breather first.

"Good, I want to show you something." Without another word, Catra took Adora by the hand and led her out of the library. She guided her down the hall and up flights of stairs with a certainty in her stride that told Adora she'd memorized the route.

Melog had vanished at some point, although for all Adora knew they could still be right next to her. Catra must have something special in mind if Melog had decided to make themself scarce.

Catra led her continually up flights of stairs, past lanterns that glowed without flame, past murals that animated themselves, past tinted windows revealing an ever more distant blanket of clouds. Adora was caught off guard when Catra made a sudden turn in an otherwise empty hallway, walking straight into the wall.

Adora was only halfway surprised when the wall flickered and parted like water. She was getting used to weird shit like this in Mystacor. The tunnel was dimly lit by purple runes set into walls barely far enough apart for one person to fit. It twisted gently left, sloping slightly downward as it went.

What appeared a dead end was obviously not as Catra pulled Adora through the wall. Adora's eyes took a second to adjust to the light. The air was cool and fresh, a light breeze brushing her hair.

They were on a terrace jutting from side of one of Mystacor's many spires. It must have been cloaked from the outside too, since it overlooked the entrance courtyard but Adora had never

seen it before. A single tree dominated the majority of the space, sprouting from the center of the small grassy nook. Its branches spread out across the entire area, providing a comfortable shade. The leaves were shifting hues of pink and purple and a constant trickle of glittering dust fell from the branches. The base of its trunk was unmuddied and twisted into ideal sitting shapes.

Adora felt Catra's eyes. Where she expected to find smug satisfaction or playful teasing, she found a quiet concern. Catra stared at her expectantly, hoping Adora would like her surprise. Insecurity that would have been visible only when Catra slipped was now openly displayed to her. Even after over six months together, it was never any less amazing.

"It's beautiful," Adora breathed, forgetting briefly about the terrace. Catra's eyes relaxed and she smiled warmly. She sauntered towards Adora as her expression shifted, still equally emotional, but different. It was that fiercely intense look that made Adora's mouth dry and her heart skip a beat.

Catra wrapped her arms around Adora's neck and kissed her. Adora leaned into the kiss and felt Catra lean into her. Maybe a little too much, because Adora stumbled backwards under Catra's weight. They landed giggling at the base of the tree.

The mood was killed when Adora's ribs were pinned between Catra and the tree. She gasped, though it wasn't as painful as it might have been a week ago. More concerning was the brief numbness that shot through her chest and down her right arm. The infection hadn't improved at all.

"Sorry!" Catra said with a touching amount of shock. She stood up and started to back away but Adora pulled her back down. Poorly, since her right arm partially numb and her left arm was still mostly useless, but Catra took the hint. She tucked Adora's hand into her chest as she leaned against the tree and slipped her legs beneath Adora. Adora allowed herself to fall against Catra's chest.

The gentle rise and fall of Catra's breath and the rumbling of her purr consumed Adora. The breeze tickled her face and the high air cooled her throat. Muscles she hadn't realized were tensed relaxed and her eyes floated half shut.

"I found this place a couple days ago," Catra purred, pulling Adora back to the present. "Usually after a session with Perfuma I feel kinda... wound up, so I go somewhere quiet to be alone. I thought you might need that too."

Adora turned her head and placed a gentle kiss into Catra's collarbone. "Thank you," she whispered.

The aching in Adora's chest slowly faded. Catra washed her pain away and soothed her muscles. She quieted Adora's mind like nothing else could. She made Adora feel *safe*. No more fighting, no more war, no more...

Adora stopped the thought. She still had work to do. Mostly on herself at the moment, but work nonetheless.

But that could wait a bit.

Chapter End Notes

> Adora's definitely in the "good grade in therapy" mindset. Somewhere in that BLM charity stream Noelle and Molly did ages ago, one of them mentioned that Adora's hobby would be map making. I don't remember any of the context, but I love that idea so I'm rolling with it. It makes sense: it's something she's somewhat familiar with, it makes something useful so it doesn't feel like a waste of time, and it helps her feel secure by knowing where everything is. Perfect hobby for Adora.

Quiet Places

Chapter Summary

> The weeks of Adora's recovery pass. Her new hobby keeps her occupied, but Castaspella's treatments continue to bear no fruit. Meanwhile, Catra goes exploring.

Chapter Notes

> Also known as The First Catra Chapter. Content warnings include PTSD, general anxiety, and references to past child abuse.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora was certainly not lacking for company during her recovery. It didn't *annoy* Catra. It was good for their friends to visit. Glimmer stayed every night, too busy with "queen stuff" to stick around during the day. Bow, having made good on his promise to sleep for a week, spent most of his time in his room, working on new models for the Best Friends Squad. He didn't seem to need the rest, but Catra suspected Glimmer asked him to keep an eye on Adora for her.

It didn't make Catra *jealous*. Adora could spend time with people other than her, and Catra knew she would always come back to her before dark. Maybe the battle just put her in a protective mood. Possessive, more like. But when she found Adora, not She-Ra, laying in a pool of her own blood beneath the blade of a Horde bot, Catra thought she had lost her. When she stitched Adora's arm together while she screamed in her ear, she thought she would lose her still.

But Adora's fine now. Her mundane wounds were healing well and Castaspella had every healer in Mystacor working on curing the infection. She was even seeing Perfuma once a week. But Catra couldn't let herself relax. She couldn't tear her eyes away from Adora whenever they were together.

Every day, about an hour after lunch, Castaspella would visit with a new potion or spell. Every day she promised, "this one will work, dear, I'm sure of it." Catra wasn't sure who she was trying to convince anymore. Every day the infection only got worse. Castaspella refused to admit it, but she was running out of ideas. Catra could tell she was getting desperate.

It didn't make Catra *angry*. She was working on that. She still came off as abrasive and hostile at times, but she had control of her anger now. She didn't shout or threaten or accuse. She was even beginning to get a handle on her passive aggressive comments. But something about Castaspella set her off. Maybe it was the barely concealed distrust in every look she directed at Catra. Maybe it was because she couldn't fix Adora. Maybe it was because she reminded Catra too much of someone else.

It *overwhelmed* Catra. That's what it was. All the people, the unfamiliar environment, the fresh panic from the battle, the *magic* - it was overwhelming her.

Being overwhelmed by her new life was nothing new to Catra. But normally when she needed to take a quiet minute to herself, she had a list of secluded places to breathe. But it took her nearly a month to fill out her list in Bright Moon Castle, and she had hardly been in Mystacor for two weeks. With all the time she spent watching Adora, she hadn't gotten the opportunity to search out many hiding spots.

But Adora was asleep now, a side effect of today's treatment. Something to do with a spell that tried to increase her body's natural healing capabilities, Catra wasn't listening very closely. It took all she had to keep her composure at Adora's side throughout the treatment as arcane lightning arced across her body and forced her muscles to contract in unnatural ways. Catra was glad it exhausted Adora enough for a nap. She needed some alone time.

She left Melog with Adora and wandered the halls. If there was one thing about Mystacor she liked, which was certainly a big if, it

was the city's ability to hide places. She hadn't been unaware of this feature until she accidentally discovered a secluded balcony hidden by an illusion last week. She took Melog out the next day and sure enough, Mystacor was littered with illusions. There wasn't a room or hallway in the city that didn't have a hidden compartment or secret door.

After that discovery, Catra decided to look for them alone. She wanted to test her ability to spot illusions. Never know when that skill could be useful. And besides, it was *fun*. Catra could hardly remember the last time she had fun on her own. Normally hiding spot hunting carried with it a certain measure of guilt and shame, but in Mystacor the spots seemed to be challenging Catra, daring her to come and find them.

And the reward was all the sweeter when she did find them. Hiding spots always ran the risk of being discovered. A disused closet could still be stumbled into, a perch in the rafters accidentally glanced. That was still a possibility in Mystacor, but significantly less of one when the spots were invisible to the naked eye. Someone had to be actively secret hunting to even hope to find most of them.

It was an extra measure of security that Catra greatly appreciated in Mystacor. It was bad enough that her first proper visit to the place had been under such dramatic circumstances, but every brick and stone in the city oozed with *magic*. Not magic. Magic was something Catra had become accustomed to, living in Bright Moon and sleeping with She-Ra. It was a natural part of the world, the essence of life itself. Mystacor didn't have a drop of magic in it. It reeked of *sorcery*.

Sorcery had a stench that only Catra's nose could pick up, an electric hum in the air that set her hair on end. A smell she became far too familiar with as a cadet. In the Fright Zone, it meant danger. *She* was coming, Catra had to straighten up or hide. It meant punishment, it meant fear. It meant pain.

Catra had fought the instinct to run and hide every second she had been in Mystacor. She had to, for Adora's sake. But given enough time or a bad trigger, it overwhelmed her control and she had to get away from everyone. So she wandered the halls.

Which led her to this secluded door beneath a stairwell. There was something in the room, Catra could smell it. Not literally, but her senses picked up on something that put her on edge. There was nothing in the room she could see that would elicit such a reaction from her body, so there must be something in there she couldn't see.

She wasn't entirely sure what the room was used for before its abandonment, although it was hard to say it was even abandoned. The back wall was lined with a desolate wine rack and a smattering of empty barrels and trunks filled the small space of the floor, but there was not a speck of dust on any of it. Dust was a problem the sorcerers had solved long ago. Every surface in Mystacor was magically cleaned of dust, leaving the entire city far too clean. Catra never thought she would miss dust this much, but the complete lack of it gave things an uncanny, artificial feeling. It reminded her a bit too much of the terrifying perfection of the Galactic Horde.

The emptiness of the containers and the seclusion of the room was what told Catra it was abandoned. The door was not magically cloaked, but hidden pretty damn well by normal standards. There was no handle or hinges, and its sides perfectly melded with the surrounding brickwork. Its location, in the base of a stairwell, was also not somewhere one would think to find a cellar. Catra had only found it because she was looking for secrets.

And for that reason she was damn certain that it had to be more than some old wine cellar. She had tried every surface in the room to no avail. This was no amateur illusion that could be stumbled into, this secret required the deliberate turning of a knob. Now if she could only find the damn thing.

The wine rack had to be the key. None of the miscellaneous barrels or chests were permanent enough to be a part of the illusion. Perhaps there was some sort of combination. There were six rows of slots, sixteen across, there was no way Catra could try every combination. There was also no dust to leave prints to mark frequent use, and even if there had been, they would have likely been cloaked as well.

Catra shut her eyes and closed her nose. Her senses misdirected her. She outstretched a hand and let her instincts guide her. She slowly scanned the top row. Her fur prickled. She reached forward and pressed a claw into the wall behind the rack.

Click.

Catra grinned and scanned the remaining rows.

Click. Click. Click. Click. Cli-chunk!

Catra opened her eyes. Nothing in the room was visibly changed, but that was hardly a surprise. She sniffed the air. A fresh draft from the right wall, a hint of lavender. She approached and cautiously inspected the wall. A smile split her lips as her hand passed through the ancient bricks.

Catra stepped through the opened portal. The first thing to confront her was the dramatic change in the air. It was significantly warmer than the halls outside, and filled with such an overwhelming mix of floral scents that Catra could scarcely make them out.

The second thing to assault her was a full body revulsion at the sorcery thick in the air. Catra could almost see the ley lines crackling, permeating the walls and penetrating her skin. Her muscles locked and her breath caught. She stood stark still and centered herself.

In, one, two, three.

Out, one, two, three.

Catra continued forward. She had not come this far to be foiled by her own unruly body. Something hidden this well had to be worth exploring, if only to sate her curiosity.

The tunnel began narrow at first, but soon doubled in width to allow two people abreast. The walls were brickwork at first, matching the room above, but they abruptly transitioned to carved stone. The tunnel appeared to be straight and flat while walking it, but a glance backwards revealed it was in fact steeply sloped and winding. Gentle magenta orbs of light guided the way along the ceiling.

The air grew thicker and hotter the deeper Catra went. The air was so moist it dampened her fur, the floral scents so strong it completely nullified her sense of smell. The tingling running across her skin increased in potency, but it only spurred her onward.

Without warning, the tunnel gave way to a small rocky chamber. A raised pool dominated a third of the space, several streams of water feeding into it from the walls and ceiling. A wide array of flowers and what Catra guessed to be pomanders decorated the rim of the pool. The water itself steamed and nearly bubbled, a dense cloud of steam pouring over its edges.

"Catra?"

Catra's chest seized. Her breath caught in her throat. Her eyes went wide in terror.

"Catra! Wretched child!"

Catra's ears flattened against her skull. She pulled in on herself despite her best efforts not to. She had to stand at attention but she couldn't control her body.

"Insolent whelp! You dare intrude upon my sanctum! Adora will not save you this time, mongrel. Your punishment will-"

"Catra?" Castaspella called again, confusion and concern written across her face.

Catra's eyes darted around the room. They locked on Castaspella, garbed in only a simple bath robe, hair wound up in a towel. She sat up straight in her chair and was setting aside an extraordinarily fancy looking drink.

On instinct, Catra drew back her fangs and hissed. She scrambled onto all fours and bolted back up the tunnel in a blur of wet fur and barely contained panic. She bounded off the walls, shot into the hall, and disappeared.

Castaspella stumbled out after her, still barefoot and dressed in a robe, but Catra was long hidden from her. Evading detection, especially from magical senses, was a survival skill Catra had learned before she could talk.

She continued around three more bends and dashed into an empty room. She held her breath and waited. Her heart beat out her throat and her tail refused to stop lashing.

In, one, two, three.

Out, one, two, three.

Catra smoothed her tail. Cautiously, she peeked out the doorframe. The hallway was deserted. Her smell was still overwhelmed by the floral barrage, but her hearing detected nothing. Satisfied she had escaped, Catra slinked into the hall and headed in the direction of Adora's room.

-

Adora woke maybe an hour after Castaspella's visit. She felt like shit. Whatever the spell did, it didn't seem to be helping. Even without unwrapping the wound, she could see the telltale glow of the infection beneath, so that clearly hadn't worked. Her legs ached instead, the spell having twisted and stretched the muscles into unnatural positions. It was mild, would probably only last a day or two, but irritating nonetheless.

Catra was gone, though Adora was not especially concerned. She looked on edge during the treatment earlier. It could have been the way Adora's unnatural spasms reminded her of worse times, or maybe just the overwhelming magical aura from the spell. Adora knew how sensitive she could be to magic. Or maybe stress had just built up over the last few days. Regardless, Adora wasn't surprised that she had run off to get some air. Melog was still there, and they appeared completely calm, so Catra was probably fine.

Adora was too sore to sleep anymore. Or too antsy maybe. Either way, she couldn't sit in bed any longer. She slid into the desk chair and pulled out her maps. Melog wrapped themselves contentedly around her ankles.

The librarian had indeed been able to provide her with ample cartography supplies. There was nothing specifically about making maps, unfortunately, but there was an abundance of atlases for Adora to copy from. She had copied half a dozen maps or pieces of maps, ranging from city layouts to kingdoms, and she even took a crack at the whole continent. She quickly ran out of room on that one, there was a lot more detail than she anticipated. She'd have to remember to ask how big the library can make paper.

Adora had practiced enough, she wanted to try something of her own. Her muscles were hardly in an agreeable state to wander Mystacor to map it out, and besides, there were already dozens of maps of Mystacor in the library, all infinitely more intricate than she could ever hope to make. One of them even tracked people in real time. No, she wanted to draw something from memory that was unique to her.

The choice was obvious. Adora unrolled a medium sized piece of parchment and clamped the ends down. Drafting pencil and ruler in hand, she got to work.

Working from memory proved challenging. It often involved sketching what she thought something looked like, then taking a

step back to get a better view. She would erase and adjust until it was as close as she could tell, then move on. She started in the barracks, where she knew the best, and worked outward from there. The industrial design of the Fright Zone had her making frequent use of the ruler, but it gradually became less rigid the more she worked outwards.

Melog stirred at her feet. They mewed quietly and stood up. A few minutes later the door timidly opened. Adora couldn't look up to see Catra come it; total concentration was required to keep this line straight. Well, not straight. It was actually a curved line marking the outer wall of the Foundry, but keeping it from wiggling took supreme effort for Adora's untrained hand.

The door was shut very softly and Melog padded over to meet Catra.

"Hey," Adora called without looking up.

"Hey," Catra replied quietly.

That didn't sound good. Adora finished the line and set her pencil down. She turned in her chair to face Catra.

She looked tired. Not physically tired, but emotionally spent. Adora could tell by the way her tail drooped ever so slightly, the minute angle of her ears. But Melog remained calm, and they hadn't shown any signs of extreme distress while Catra was away, so it couldn't be too bad.

"Out for some air?" Adora ventured. She would be able to help better if she knew what was bugging Catra, but she knew better than to ask directly.

"Exploring." Hiding spot hunting. Overwhelmed, then.

"Find anything interesting?"

"Hm." Found someone likely. Surprise social interactions could be quite draining on Catra, especially if she was feeling overwhelmed

and looking for a quiet place for herself.

Catra must have heard the gears churning in Adora's head because she took a sudden interest in the map.

"Whatcha workin' on?" she asked, but Adora knew she had instantly recognized the map.

"I'm trying to draw the Fright Zone from memory. Wanted to try something other than copying."

Catra sauntered over to the desk and threw her arms across Adora's shoulders, chin planted squarely on her hair puff. She cocked her head as she inspected the rough array of lines and notes.

"The Foundry's too big," she declared.

"What, really?"

Catra leaned over Adora's shoulder. "Yeah, the forge is only about three-quarters that size. There's a path leading around here," she trailed a claw around the forge, leaving a slight indent for Adora to trace, "and a belt from the quarry that enters here. But there's not that much room to walk in there."

"Huh, I guess it looked a lot bigger as a kid," Adora mused. "How do you know the Foundry that well?"

"I got pretty familiar with the place when I took over for-" Catra's tail lashed. "When I was in charge." Ah. Shadow Weaver was the problem. Of course she was. There wasn't a problem in either of their lives that couldn't be traced back to that cruel woman.

Catra's claws began to dig into the paper a little. "Well, you explored a lot more of the Fright Zone than I did," Adora said to pull Catra back to the present. "Anything else to add?"

Catra stood up straight and studied the map for a moment. She was facing the map, but Adora could tell she wasn't looking at it.

She snatched a pencil and began marking several spots with an X. Adora's interest was piqued. Catra would mark a seemingly random spot, pause to think, then mark two more.

"These are your hiding spots," Adora realized, finally seeing the pattern. "Wow, I only recognize half of these."

"Couldn't let you know all my spots." Catra placed another mark.

"What! How did you even get in there?"

"I used to be a lot smaller," Catra chuckled. She marked a couple more and surveyed the map. There were nearly thirty X's scattered around the Fright Zone, most clumped around the Barracks, a couple reaching far out towards the edges of the page. Adora recognized maybe two thirds of them. Catra set the pencil down but stayed leaned over Adora's shoulder.

Adora took the hint. "Find anywhere good today?"

She knew Catra was inviting her to ask about it. Nevertheless, Catra's tail lashed again and she stood up sharply. She paced across the room once and collapsed on the bed. Melog hopped up and settled themselves above her head.

"I found one place," she mumbled.

Adora stood up and flopped on the bed with her, bouncing Catra a little with her weight. She propped her head on her good elbow and waited for Catra to continue at her own speed.

Catra sighed. "There was a tunnel, in an abandoned wine cellar. It was hidden with an illusion. It led down into some sort of, like, hot spring."

Adora nodded. "Yeah, there are these really nice hot springs under the city. Glimmer and Bow took me there the first time I was here. I wonder if Castaspella would let me in with my bandages, I'd love to show you."

Catra shook her head. "No, this was just one pool. It was a little cave."

"Ooh, someone's got a private hot spring."

Catra's eyebrows worried and she rolled away. Adora silently cursed herself and scooted closer. She hovered near enough for Catra to feel her, but wasn't actually touching her. "Was anyone there?" Adora asked quietly, piecing things together.

Catra grabbed Adora's arm, hastily at first but releasing it quickly when she remembered the bandages. Adora pulled her in regardless.

"It wasn't that," Catra mumbled into Adora's elbow. "It's just. There was so much *magic* in there. I could practically taste it. It just. It-"

"It reminded of you of her?" Adora finished.

Catra nodded. "It was worse than normal. Like before." Catra's voice was hoarse. "I could *hear* her. Like she was there in the room."

Adora rubbed Catra's shoulder. "What did she say?"

Catra laughed dryly. "Oh, you know. The usual." Her sardonic laughter turned to soft sobs.

Adora pulled her a little closer, not too tightly. Catra turned and buried her face in Adora's chest. Her claws dug into Adora's back as she let herself be fully supported by Adora. Adora grimaced at the weight on her ribs but said nothing. Catra needed this.

"It's okay. She's gone now. She can't hurt us anymore," Adora whispered. She had said it all a hundred times before, Catra was probably sick of hearing it. But she would say it a hundred times again, and a hundred more, as long as Catra needed her to. Catra held onto her and silently cried into her chest.

After a long moment, Catra pulled her head up. Adora instantly released her grip enough for Catra to leave. Tears still flowing, Catra leaned her chin up to Adora's. She ran it affectionately along Adora's cheek, neck, and breast. Scent marking her, making sure she was still there, still hers.

"You okay?" Adora softly asked as Catra pulled away.

Catra sniffled. "Yeah. Thanks."

Adora pulled Catra in close again and rubbed her arm up and down her back. Catra shivered and wove her tail through Adora's fingers, a purr creeping into her breath. By the time Bow came to check on them for dinner, they were both out cold.

Chapter End Notes

> Catra needs cuddles too. She spends a lot of time helping Adora in this story, and I didn't want to make it seem like she magically got better to do that. Both of them have problems but they help each other work through them.

Breathe

Chapter Summary

> Adora struggles with some new exercises Perfuma assigns her.

Chapter Notes

> Oho! A treatment that I have experience in and can confidently write about in an accurate way. If my therapist ever read this I think he'd probably recognize a lot of himself in here. I realize as I'm posting this that deep breathing may not be the best exercise while you have four broken ribs, but it's way too late to change that now. Let's just say Castaspella's healing magic is doing good and move on.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora awkwardly shuffled into the study room. The door sealed with a faint magical hum behind her.

Perfuma greeted her with a smile. "Good afternoon!"

"Hi," Adora mumbled as she sat down.

When Adora said nothing, Perfuma began. "How have you been this week?"

"Fine," Adora answered, honestly for once. It was weird to use that word properly after having misused it so often. "I've been healing well, resting up, working on map stuff, you know."

Perfuma nodded. "How is the cartography going? Did you talk to the librarian?"

"Yeah, they got me all the stuff," Adora said flatly. She didn't quite know why she was biting her tongue. She felt even more awkward

than she had the first time. She thought the second session would be easier.

"So how has it been going?" Perfuma prompted.

"Fine," Adora answered before she could catch herself. She silently cursed and added, "The atlases were really useful, since they had so many different scales of maps."

Perfuma nodded. "Have you drawn any maps?"

"Yeah, I drew a few," Adora started. Perfuma silently urged her on. "I copied one of Bright Moon first, but it looked like it was a few years out of date, so it felt weird. I kept wanting to draw things that weren't on the map and it was messing with the spacing." Adora lost track of herself as she became caught up in recounting her hobby adventures.

"Salineas was more accurate, I think, or maybe I just don't know it as well as Bright Moon. Either way, it went better than Bright Moon, except for the coast, I couldn't space it out very well. There were so many little bumps, it was impossible to get them all right. Then I did the Crimson Waste, to try something a bit less urban, but it was so loosely charted that there wasn't much to go on. It was too empty. I also tried one of the whole continent, but there was so much more detail than I thought there would be, I ran out of room on the paper. I wonder if the library makes any bigger paper, I gotta remember to-"

Adora's brain caught up to her tongue. "Sorry, I'm rambling," she said sheepishly.

Perfuma shook her head and smiled encouragingly. "No, please, keep going. It's good to hear you so passionate about your hobby. Did you draw any others?" she asked when Adora was hesitant to continue.

"Yeah, I did like six or seven total," Adora said, careful keep a handle on herself this time. "The last one I did was of the Fright Zone, from memory this time, instead of copying. It was a lot

harder to size things correctly, but I think I got it pretty well. Catra had to help with some of the sizings on that one."

Perfuma looked positively delighted. "How does it feel, doing something creative?"

Adora shrugged. "I dunno. I've never really done creative stuff before. I don't even really think of this as creative, you know? It's just drawing how a place is."

"But it is drawing, yes?" Adora nodded cautiously. "And drawing is creative, and you are creating something, so I'd call it creative."

"I guess."

Perfuma waited patiently for Adora to add any further comments. Adora coughed and began bouncing her leg.

"I want to teach you something today," Perfuma said when Adora remained silent. "It's something that I think everyone can use, especially anyone dealing with anxiety." Adora assumed that meant her. "It's a technique called diaphragmatic meditative breathing."

"Called what now," Adora deadpanned.

Perfuma chuckled a little. Adora suspected she secretly liked confusing people with all that professional talk. "It's a breathing exercise designed to help you relax," Perfuma explained. Adora must have looked confused. "Let me show you."

"Try breathing with me." Perfuma straightened her posture and Adora mimicked her. "Breathe deeply through your nose and focus on your breathing. The goal is to center yourself in the present. Here, you can use this flower as a visual aid." Perfuma conjured a violet rose and placed it the center of the table. "Ready?"

Adora nodded. She wasn't sure what to expect. "In," Perfuma said, puffing out her stomach in an exaggerated manner. "One,

two, three." The petals of the rose slowly folded upwards and shut. Adora took a breath as demonstrated.

"Hold, one, two, three." Perfuma shut her eyes and kept her stomach puffed. Adora held her breath.

"And out, one, two, three." Perfuma's shoulders sagged and the rose's petals gently unfurled. Adora let out something more like a sigh and kept blowing air when she realized Perfuma was still counting.

Perfuma repeated the pattern a few times. Adora started to get into the rhythm of it. "Good," Perfuma eventually said. "Keep going, count it off in your head." Adora did as instructed.

In, one, two, three. She could feel Perfuma's eyes. She was judging her performance. She had to keep on form. Adora noticed her breath letting itself out.

Shit, out two three, she thought, forcing the rest of the breath out in time with the flower. She determined to focus everything she could on the flower.

It worked better than she thought it would. Adora wasn't sure how long had passed when Perfuma said, "Try to breathe lower in your body." Adora broke rhythm and gave her a quizzical look. "Instead of breathing through your chest," Perfuma placed a hand on her stomach, "try breathing through your stomach." She inhaled, puffing out her stomach and causing her hand to rise with it.

Adora set her hand on her stomach and waited for the flower to reset. She puffed out her stomach, unsure if that was what she was supposed to do or not. It didn't seem much different to her, but Perfuma was the expert.

"Excellent!" Apparently she had done something right. Adora continued breathing until Perfuma spoke again. "Isn't that nice?"

Adora fidgeted under Perfuma's gaze. "I guess? I dunno, I don't feel much different."

Perfuma nodded. "It's a technique designed for practice. The more you work on it, the more relaxing it will become, like exercising a muscle. It will train your body to breathe deeper and slower on its own, which reduces your anxiety even when you're not actively focusing on it." Adora nodded her head. She didn't know what else to do so she just let Perfuma keep talking. "It's also a valuable skill to have, to be able to ground yourself in the moment."

"The Horde taught us something kinda like that," Adora said absentmindedly. Suddenly regretting having opened her mouth, she cleared her throat awkwardly. Perfuma waited patiently for her to continue. Too late to go back now. "They taught us that you have to be able to center yourself in battle, focus on the moment to moment action of staying alive. They, uh, taught you to use pain to focus your mind and keep your adrenaline flowing." Adora gave an awkward half laugh. It sounded a lot worse out loud.

Perfuma nodded her head sadly, but did not seem surprised. "That's why I think this skill is especially valuable to someone who grew up in the Horde. It's a healthier alternative to a habit that's been drilled into you since childhood."

Adora nodded slowly, again at a loss for what to say. Luckily, Perfuma seemed to be wrapping things up.

"I want you to practice breathing like this on your own. Pick a time and do your best to do it every day for five to ten minutes without interruption." She reached into her bag.

"Here," she said, handing Adora a dandelion bud. "I had a sorcerer enchant it to keep a rhythm like the one we used today." Sure enough, the tiny yellow petals were gently moving in and out on a count of three. "It's small enough to go in your pocket so you can use it anywhere you need it."

Five minutes a day of breathing. Adora could handle that. "When should I do it?"

Perfuma shrugged. "It's up to you. I like to do it every day when I wake up and before I go to sleep. Other people like to do it after every meal, others just pick a time that fits their schedule. Whatever works for you, just as long as you do it every day." Adora nodded.

"Well, if there's nothing else you want to talk about today...?" Perfuma prompted, pausing to give Adora a chance to speak.

"No, I don't think so," Adora said, hoping her relief didn't show.

"Then I'll see you next week," Perfuma finished, giving Adora confident smile.

Adora returned the smile as best she could. "Yeah, next week," she said, rising from her chair and pocketing the dandelion.

-

Adora woke before the first light of dawn had the chance to creep through the window. Catra was still asleep, curled partially around Adora.

Adora gave herself thirty seconds to blink the sleep out of her eyes and then got to work. She had a mission to complete: she needed find the optimal time to do the breathing exercises Perfuma assigned her. She had created a list of all the most logical times to try. The first was as soon as she woke up.

Adora was used to sneaking out of bed without waking Catra, but the added pressure of the mission somehow made it frustratingly harder than normal. She didn't dare use the restroom and risk waking Catra, so Adora sat in one of the dining chairs.

She gently set the tiny flower on the table, careful not to damage its enchanted petals. It was sturdier than it looked, probably some

sort of enchantment too. She waited for the rhythm to reset before beginning.

In, one, two, three, as the petals began to curl up.

Hold, one, two, three. She glanced at Catra's still form beneath the blankets, legs curled up unconsciously seeking the warmth Adora had provided. Melog was likewise curled atop the dresser, though Adora was pretty sure now that they didn't actually sleep.

Out, two, three. You know, considering they were a shapeshifter, facing away from her didn't guarantee they couldn't see her.

Shit, In, two, three. Focus. Adora forced her eyes back to the flower.

Hold, one, two, three. She really had to pee.

Out, one, two, three. She just had to not think about it.

In, one, two, three. The more she thought about it, the worse it would become.

Hold, one, two, three. Okay, quick bathroom break, then back to it.

Adora stuffed the flower into her pocket and tiptoed into the bathroom. She washed her hands as quietly as she could, but upon opening the door found Catra's form stirring. Maybe she could still manage to do it?

Adora sat back at the table but her hand froze in her pocket. She petals tickled her palm as she cupped the flower.

Catra yawned in that squeaky sort of way and stretched. "Morning," she mumbled, rubbing her eyes. She raised an eyebrow when she saw Adora at the table. "That hungry already?" she said with a slight smile.

Adora hastily removed her hand from her pocket. "Oh, uh, yeah. I could really use a bagel."

Damn. That's okay, she had other times to try, it didn't have to be first thing in the morning. Probably for the best anyway, she didn't want it to be putting her to sleep every morning.

-

Adora finished lunch early. She often did (she had a habit of forgetting to chew), but she made sure to finish especially early this time. Catra would follow in about fifteen minutes. Plenty of time for breathing.

She walked as fast as she could back to her room and climbed straight onto the bed. She sat up straight against the headboard, directly below the window, and crossed her legs. She set the flower before her lap and waited for it to reset.

In, one, two, three. A quick glance at the door. Nothing.

Hold, one, two, three. She listened for footsteps. Nothing.

Out, one, two, three. She turned her attention back to the flower.

In, one, two, three. She couldn't stop another glance at the door.

Hold, one, two, three. Focus!

Out, one, tw- "HEY ADORA!"

Adora nearly leapt out of the bed. She scrambled to cover the flower. "Hey! Hey Adora!" Swift Wind tapped his horn against the window, managing to work it open.

Adora caught her breath and tucked the flower in her jacket pocket. "Hey, Swifty," she said somewhat shakily. "What's up?"

Swift Wind didn't seem to notice her disarray. "Okay, guess who just visited me? Guess!"

Adora failed to suppress a smile. He was loud and annoying, but like a little kid. She couldn't help but love him. "I dunno, was iiitt..."

"Castaspella!" Swift Wind blurted out before Adora could finish. "She and a bunch of wizards came to visit me in my stable, they said they wanted my tears!"

"Your what?"

"I know right! My tears! Apparently unicorn tears are really really powerful and really really rare because you normally have to find a unicorn out in the wild and get it to cry for you, which is not easy, but these guys, they had some pepper, and..."

Adora's heart rate eventually returned to a normal pace. Swift Wind went on for a couple minutes about Castaspella and wizards and whatnot, she wasn't really listening.

This wouldn't work. In the middle of the day like this, people were too likely to interrupt. And she couldn't always inhale lunch that fast without arousing suspicion. Plus if they were doing something after lunch like they normally did in Bright Moon, she would never have the time.

As if on cue, Catra opened the door and groaned. She was several minutes earlier than Adora had expected her. This time wouldn't have worked at all, even if Swift Wind hadn't interrupted.

"Oh! Hey, Catra, guess what!"

-

Catra was out for some air. There was no saying when she would be back, but it ought to be enough time to try breathing. "When Catra goes out" is hardly a consistent time, but Adora was running out of options at this point. None of the other times she had tried were working. This would have to do.

Except Catra had left Melog behind to watch her. Adora did her best to ignore them and straightened her posture on the bed.

She positioned the flower before her. She nudged it a little. She waited for it to reset. She caught Melog in the corner of her eye.

"Stop watching," she mumbled. Melog mewed and curled on the end of the bed, facing away. For all that meant, being a shapeshifter who apparently didn't sleep.

Focus! Adora waited once more for the flower to reset.

In, one, two, three. Melog's glow illuminated the room almost as much as the dimmed lights.

Hold, one, two, three. It grew and faded with each of Melog's breaths.

Out, one, two, three. Apparently they had to breathe, even if they didn't sleep.

In, one, two, three. Wait, they were breathing in sync with the flower too.

Hold, one, two, three. How did they even know, they must-

Footsteps in the hall. Adora held her breath and readied herself to hide the flower.

The steps grew and faded. Echoes of a conversation passed through the hall outside. Adora let her breath out.

She returned to the flower. She had completely thrown off her rhythm. She waited for it to reset.

In, one- The door opened. Adora gasped loudly and scrambled to hide the flower under the sheets.

Catra quirked an eye from the doorframe. "Am I interrupting something?"

Adora felt her cheeks redden as she shook her head. "No! I mean, no, not at all." Catra looked unconvinced. Adora sighed. "Let's just go to bed." Catra shrugged and began undressing for bed.

This wasn't going to work at all.

-

Adora hadn't done a single breathing session since last week. She knew the guilt was visible on her face. Catra certainly could tell something was wrong, but luckily she didn't say anything.

Adora swallowed hard and entered Perfuma's study room.

"Good afternoon," she called as last time. Adora only managed a "hm" in response as she shut the door.

She sat down at the table and said nothing. Perfuma took initiative. "How have things been this week?"

"Fine," Adora mumbled. "You know, more resting, more medicines, worked on the Fright Zone map a bit. The usual."

"And what about your breathing exercises?" Shit. "Have you found a good time for it?"

"I, uh, well," Adora stumbled over her words. "No." She looked down in shame.

She waited for Perfuma to chastise her but nothing came. But she could feel her eyes. She had to say something.

"It's just, I haven't been able to find a good time, everyone keeps interrupting, and. I just can't sit still long enough to do it. My brain won't stop thinking and I can't focus on the flower."

"That's all the more reason you need to start practicing," Perfuma said calmly, not a hint of hostility or even disappointment in her voice. "If you can get into the habit of it, I think it will really help you relax."

"But how am I supposed to get good at it if I can't even practice?"

"Why do you think it's so hard for you to focus?"

"I don't know!" Adora caught herself and lowered her voice. "I don't know why, I just can't focus on it, even when I get time alone."

"Hmm," Perfuma shifted in her chair a little. "Well let's try to figure that out then. What are you afraid will happen when you try to breathe?"

"Afraid? I'm not afraid of anything, really." Adora paused to find the words. She knew what she wanted to say but couldn't work it onto her tongue. "I guess it just feels awkward," she settled on.

"Okay, afraid might not have been the right word. I guess what I mean to say is, what are you worried might happen? Is there anything you're watching out for, even if you don't mean to?"

"Well I guess I watch for anyone who might walk in, but-"

"Oh! Right there!" Adora snapped her mouth shut and subconsciously sat up straighter. Perfuma winced ever so slightly and took a breath. "Sorry, I didn't mean to interrupt your thought."

"No, it's okay, I'm sure whatever you heard was probably more important than my rambling." Adora made a conscious effort to relax her posture again.

Perfuma smiled a little sadly, but continued nonetheless. "Well, I think what you said about watching for people is important."

"I mean, I just keep half an ear on the door, to make sure nobody interrupts."

"Why would it be so bad if somebody interrupted?"

Adora blinked. "I dunno. I guess I want to do the breathing alone, so I can focus."

"Except you can't focus, even when you are alone."

"... yeah."

"So then why are you worried about somebody walking in?"

"I... don't know." Adora tried to think. What *was* she worried about? Being caught? But she's not doing anything to be caught at. So why was she worried about it? Think, think.

Adora started to speak and as quickly stopped several times, trying to find the words for her thoughts. Perfuma was endlessly patient.

"I... I guess it feels. Awkward?" Wait, didn't she already say awkward earlier? "Embarrassing?" she tried again.

"Hm, now we're onto something," Perfuma said as if Adora hadn't just been staring at a wall for two minutes.

"Yeah, I guess it feels embarrassing."

"What does? The breathing itself or getting caught?"

"Both? I guess? I dunno, I just feel really... awkward about it." She already said awkward twice but whatever. Words were hard.

"Do you know why?"

"Hell if I know." Adora was completely lost here.

"Well, have you ever done anything like this before?"

"Like in the Horde?"

Perfuma nodded. "Or after. Anything at all."

"Well, no, not really." She chuckled a little wryly. "Honestly, I've hardly even relaxed before without Catra."

Perfuma smiled like she had been waiting for her to say that. "And that's why it feels so embarrassing."

"Because I've never done this stuff before...?"

"Exactly. Relaxing and working on your emotions like this is a vulnerable process. Vulnerability can make us feel weak, like we need to protect ourselves. In the Horde, you were raised to hide weakness at any cost. That's why the breathing makes you feel so uncomfortable. Your brain has been programmed to act like it's still in the Horde, so you feel like you need to hide weakness. But you're not in the Horde anymore, and being vulnerable is not the same thing as being weak." Adora kind of nodded along as Perfuma went. She was getting the idea, she thought. "Does that make sense?"

"Oh, uh. Yeah? I think so."

Perfuma nodded. "So now that we know what the problem is, we can figure out a solution."

"Okay," Adora said. Wait, was that her cue to suggest a solution? She had no idea. "Um, I..."

"You mentioned Catra earlier?" Perfuma prompted.

"Oh, yeah. She's very good at helping me relax. It's the purring," she added with a smile.

Perfuma giggled a little. "Well maybe you could try doing your breathing with her?" Adora frowned. "Having someone to watch your back while you breathe might make you feel better about doing it, and I'm sure she would love to do her breathing with you too."

"Her breathing?" Adora repeated. "Does Catra do this too?"

Perfuma nodded. "I assigned her the same breathing technique when we started. It took her three weeks to get into a regular schedule, but now she does it three times a day or more."

When did that happen? Adora ran a hand through her hair. "I don't know, I've never seen her doing it so she probably likes to be alone for it and I don't want to bother her if she's getting better and I'm not even sure you should really be telling me any of this and -"

"Adora," Perfuma interrupted as gently as one could. "Catra asked me to share anything we worked on in her sessions that I think might be helpful to you. She wouldn't do that if she didn't trust you with that information or if she didn't want to work on it with you."

Adora thought for a moment. "Did she really?" she asked, pride sneaking into her voice.

Perfuma smiled broadly and nodded. "I think trying your breathing with her might really help, based on what you told me about how you like to relax."

Out, one, two, three. "Okay. Okay, I'll ask her about it."

-

Adora tenderly raised her arms to pull on her nightshirt. It still hurt to move her left arm high enough to fit in a shirt, but she had to do it herself. She needed to at least be able to do that much. She looked in the mirror, into her own eyes, searching for any signs of She-Ra's telltale magical glow. Nothing.

Adora sighed and composed herself before leaving the bathroom. She didn't want Catra to worry about her too much. She did enough of that already.

Catra was waiting for her on the end of the bed. She was in her nightclothes but clearly had other things on her mind.

"Are you okay?" she asked, emotions plain on her face. Mostly concern, some irritation. She knew Adora was hiding something from her.

Adora feigned ignorance. "What? Yeah, why?" She didn't even know why she did it, but she was too far in now. It was instinct.

Catra narrowed her eyes. "Well, you've been kinda jumpy the last few days. Fidgety. More than usual, I mean. You're checking the doors like you're expecting an ambush." She softened her expression as much as she could. "What's up?"

"Nothing, I just -" Catra's look told Adora she was buying none of it. Adora sighed. "I haven't been doing the exercises Perfuma assigned me," she mumbled with a bit of a blush.

Catra nodded. "Breathing?" Adora averted her eyes and nodded back. "She give you one of those flowers too?"

Adora blinked. She pulled her hand out of her pocket, revealing the enchanted dandelion. "How'd you know?"

"I lost mine months ago," Catra chuckled.

Catra didn't seem to be saying any more so Adora prompted her. "Did she, uh, assign you the same thing?" she asked, sounding for all the world like she was asking about their homework in the Fright Zone.

Catra giggled, realizing the same thing. "Yeah, you can borrow my notes."

Adora laughed with her a little and grew quiet. "How do you do it?"

Catra shrugged a little awkwardly. "It took some getting used to. But I'm good at finding quiet places to hide."

"Don't you feel awkward doing it though? Like, embarrassed that somebody will see you?"

"Nobody thinks anything of it when I sneak off to hide, so even if somebody did find me, I could pass it off as just being me." That made sense. Even Adora hadn't noticed Catra had apparently been doing this for months now.

"So, uh, I wanted to ask," Adora stuttered. "You don't have to if you don't want to, I know you like doing things alone, especially, uh, therapy type things, but I was just, uh- "

"Do you want to do your breathing with me?" Catra mercifully interrupted.

"Yes please."

Catra smiled sweetly. "Sure."

Adora fidgeted with the tip of her ponytail. "So, should we do it, like, now or..."

Catra shrugged. "Whatever. I usually do it whenever I have the time."

"Okay," Adora said, recognizing the invitation. Catra slid down the side of the bed so she was leaning on her shoulder against it. Adora grunted as she sat behind her such that their backs were together.

Adora put the flower on the floor in front of her. She situated herself and concentrated on the gently breathing petals.

In, one, two, three. Hold, one, two, three. Out, one, two, three.

In, one, two, three. Adora heard Catra take a deep breath and soon felt her breathing even out behind her. Catra leaned her head back against the crook of Adora's neck. Adora wondered how she could keep pace without a visual aid.

Out, one, two, three. It was better. Adora wasn't sure if it was because it was so late she knew nobody would bug them or

because she wasn't trying to hide it from Catra, but she felt like she was doing better now.

In, one, two, three. But her thoughts still wandered, like they were right now. She still couldn't fully focus or ground herself like she's supposed to.

Out, one, two, three. "Hey Catra?"

"Hm?"

"Would you mind, uh, purring?" Adora waited for a response. "It's just, it helps me relax and I, uh..."

Catra seemed to get the picture. After a second, a rumble started up in her chest. Adora felt it echo down her neck and into her stomach. Almost immediately she could feel the tension leave her body. Muscles she didn't know were tensed relaxed and her thoughts slowed down. She turned her gaze back to the flower at her feet.

Adora found she no longer had to count in her head in time with the movement of the petals. She simply followed along in their rhythm. She reveled in the sensation of Catra's purr rumbling throughout her brain, stilling her wandering thoughts and capturing most of her attention. Her remaining attention was directed on her breathing. She focused on the feeling of the air passing through the top of her throat, the faint whistling sound only she could hear that it made as she breathed.

She began to sort of zone out. She felt relaxed in a way she never had before. Entirely in the present, nothing but Catra's purr and her breathing. Adora felt at peace. Was this what Perfuma meant by being grounded?

An indeterminate amount of time passed and Catra stretched her arms. She stood up, still purring. "Well, that's about how long I usually go for," she said. Adora had hardly noticed the passing of time. "Did that work better for you?"

Adora's head was still a little fuzzy. Her neck tingled in the absence of Catra's purr. "Yeah. Yeah, it helped a lot, actually. Thanks."

Catra smiled. "Just tell me when you want to do your breathing and I'll sneak off with you."

"Thank you." Adora winced as she rose to her knees, gratefully taking Catra's hand to help her to her feet. "Really. It's much easier with you there."

Catra's smile widened and her purr increased an notch in volume. "So you're saying I'm the only thing that can get you to relax?" she teased.

Adora grinned back at her. "Only because I know you're not sneaking up on me!"

She leapt at Catra, taking her by surprise and tackling her giggling onto the bed. Catra squeaked and struggled under Adora's loose grip. She could have pinned her easily if it weren't for her injuries (although Catra might dispute that claim). As it was, Catra was able to wriggle her way out and slip around behind Adora, pulling her backwards.

Adora's head landed on Catra's stomach. Their giggling faded and Catra reclined against the headboard. Adora's wounds ached at the exertion, but the pain was overpowered by that warm feeling in her chest. Catra threaded a claw along Adora's scalp, ending on her ponytail which she undid. She slid the band onto her wrist and began running her hand through Adora's hair.

Adora shivered at the sensation and leaned into it. If she could she would have started purring too. Adora scooted a little farther up Catra to rest her ear at a better position to listen to her purring. She pulled her legs up towards her chest and tangled them with Catra's. She pulled the blanket up over her shoulders with her left arm and rested her right beneath Catra, hand idly massaging the fluffy fur under her ribs.

Adora shut her eyes and let out a contented sigh. Catra continued to purr and stroke her hair as Adora began to drift off.

"Hey," Catra whispered, faltering in her stroking. Adora turned her head to look up at Catra but still kept her ear rested on her chest. Catra gave her the most warm and sincere smile. "I'm proud of you."

Adora turned to puddy in her arms. She tried to say something but only managed to produce an undignified squeaking sound. Catra rolled her eyes and nearly hissed, "Don't start. Let me finish."

Adora nodded her head and bit her lip to contain herself.

Catra sighed and continued, "I'm proud of you for seeing Perfuma and doing her stuff and. For trying to be better. I know how hard it can be to improve yourself." She turned her eyes back to Adora and was met with what Adora assumed must be what Catra called one of "those looks."

"Shut up," Catra scoffed with a smile, pushing the palm of her hand onto Adora's cheek, forcing her comically enlarged eyes off of her.

"I didn't say anything," Adora mumbled through a grin and Catra's palm.

Adora reached the arm that wasn't sandwiched beneath Catra and pulled her hand gently off her face. She brought it to her lips and softly kissed it. "I love you," she whispered.

Beneath the blanket, Catra coiled her tail around Adora's leg. "Love you too," she whispered back, extricating her hand from Adora's lips and resuming stroking her hair.

The sound of Adora's happy hums mixed with Catra's purring as the gentle hum of the magical lights slowly faded.

Chapter End Notes

Adora is dead. Overdosed on sugar from all this Catra fluff. Catra does her breathing whenever she gets a minute, often more than the three times a day she's been prescribed. Adora, meanwhile, does it like clockwork after every meal with Catra acting as her timer. Instead of something like music to calm her for the breathing, she uses Catra's purring because if you can't tell I'm absolutely in love with the idea that Catra's purring is the only thing that can make Adora actually relax. She also diligently uses the flower as guidance, whereas Catra shuts her eyes and goes at her own pace.

Up All Night

Chapter Summary

> When one of Castaspella's treatments makes Adora sick, Castaspella and Catra begin to trust each other over their shared care for Adora.

Chapter Notes

> The Second Catra Chapter, in which Catra discovers not all water is uncomfortable. Content warnings for vomit, pain, and a pretty horny scene (but it doesn't go very far because I'm no good at writing smut). References to scars from Show me your scars, I'll show you mine are made, so reading that might be good for context, but it's not critical.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A knock came at the door. Catra rolled her eyes and sighed. It was too early for this.

"Adora? Are you decent?" Castaspella called, although she was already halfway in.

"Come in," Adora called back. She set down her pencil and rose stiffly from her chair. Catra rolled off the bed to make room for her and grumbled to herself. Castaspella set her bag on the dining table and began unpacking a few of her usual things.

"So, what's today's miracle cure, doc?" Catra asked with undisguised sarcasm. Adora shot her a look. Anger briefly flared in Catra, but she quickly extinguished it. Catra didn't like Castaspella or her methods, but she was still their only shot at curing that infection. She settled on a "sorry" shrug directed at Adora.

Castaspella ignored Catra's jab and proudly presented a small bottle, no larger than a tube of lipstick. It was shaped like a teardrop and its walls were finely engraved with what appeared to

be gold. The liquid within appeared to have no color, but a familiar gold and blue magical hue undulated behind the glass.

"This is a Unicorn Potion." Castaspella hunched over and lowered her voice as if telling a story to children. "It is the rarest and most powerful healing potion in the world. Made from a dozen healing herbs, three days and nights of constant enchantment, and the fresh tear of a unicorn, this potion can heal any ailment. A single sip can mend a broken bone in hours, a vial can bring a warrior from death's door to fighting shape by morning."

Castaspella stood upright and regained her composure. "Normally, it is almost impossible to find a wild unicorn, let alone capture its tears," she explained, voice professional again, but still with an excited edge. "However, thanks to Swift Wind, all we had to do this time was ask politely."

Adora eyed the shifting lights in the bottle. "So... it's made from Swift Wind's tears?"

Catra scrunched her nose. "That's disgusting."

Castaspella turned sharply to Catra. "Would you have said the same thing if it were another unicorn's tears?"

Catra huffed and said nothing.

"But, Swift Wind isn't a regular unicorn," Adora said. "I mean, he is now, but before I, y'know," Adora made a waving motion with her hands and a *psheww* sound, "zapped him with She-Ra magic, he was just a regular horse. Will the potion still work with his tears?"

Castaspella nodded confidently. "In fact, it ought to make it even more powerful. The fact you share a magical bond with the unicorn in question should make the potion even more effective with your body."

"Should," Catra repeated sharply.

Castaspella shot her a brief side eye. "Yes. We have never experimented with She-Ra magic before, but based on everything we know about alchemy and about She-Ra, this is quite likely the most powerful healing potion ever created."

"Hm." Catra's tail flicked in irritation. Melog leapt down from their bed atop the dresser but did not change in color or size.

"Hey, I'm sure it will be fine," Adora said, trying to cut the tension. She held out her hand and took the bottle from Castaspella.

Adora pulled the cork off and nearly gagged. Catra could smell it from here. She didn't catch the smell of it as much as she felt the magic of it. She didn't know what Adora smelled, but it set Catra's hackles on end.

Castaspella offered a nervous smile. Melog jumped onto the bed behind Adora. They bumped into her back and Catra grew nervous. Melog had a good nose for danger and they were already trying to support Adora. Catra sensed something was wrong too.

Before she could say anything, Adora toasted and downed the potion with the expertise of someone who had endured soup day in the Fright Zone for eighteen years. Her expression told Catra it tasted as bad as it smelled. Adora cringed as she let her breath out.

"How do you feel?" Castaspella asked.

Adora winced and clutched at her gut. "Agh, it burns."

"Well, that's-"

"Ah!" Adora cried out and doubled over. "Ah, it really burns!"

Catra was next to Melog in an instant, her hand on Adora's back.

Castaspella floundered. "Where, where does it burn?" Panic spread into her voice.

"Ah!" Adora cried again. "In my gut! On the wound!" Tears streaked down Adora's cheeks. It took a significant amount of pain to make Adora cry; Catra rubbed harder.

"Let me try healing it!" Castaspella exclaimed, the excitement in her voice overcome by anxiety.

She muttered a frantic incantation and produced an arcing green and yellow ribbon of magic between her hands. She had barely touched the end of it to the wound when Adora screamed even louder. She leapt back from Castaspella and into Catra. She hadn't even reacted that strongly when Catra sewed her arm back together. Melog turned red and positioned themselves on Adora's lap between her and Castaspella.

"Hey, hey, you okay?" Catra frantically asked. Castaspella was frozen, spell still arcing between her fingers.

Adora winced and tried to suck air through her teeth. "Yeah, I'm-" Her eyes went wide. She barely had enough time to push Catra out of the way before she emptied her stomach over the edge of the bed.

Catra had never seen vomit *glow* like that before. It shimmered a sickly purple, with flecks of green flaring throughout.

After several seconds Adora managed a breath. "I-"

She vomited again, more green than purple this time. Fresh tears fell. Melog turned blue again and curled themselves around Adora's back, purring very loudly. Adora managed half a breath and puked again.

Catra rubbed her back helplessly as Adora struggled for breath. Castaspella was still just stood there, a dumb look on her face.

"DO SOMETHING!" Catra shrieked at her.

Castaspella blinked and the spell dissipated. "I, uh." She looked in horror from the glowing puddle of vomit to Adora's pained

breathing. "I'll get help," she said hoarsely. She turned and frantically ran out the door.

"Wait!" Catra shouted after her, but she was already gone. "What the FUCK!"

Adora gasped. "CatraaAAUGH!" She threw up again.

Catra returned to her. "Hey, hey, I'm here, you're okay. Just try to breathe." The vomit was glowing less now but there was still a remarkable amount of it, even for how much food Adora had been known eat.

"Claws," Adora gasped before doubling over again.

"What?"

Adora managed to force a momentous breath. "Use your claws!" She violently doubled over again with a pained grunt as she continued heaving.

Catra got the picture. She extended her claws and began lightly running the tips up and down Adora's back. Adora sighed a little bit before throwing up again. It glowed a little less each time, until finally she got a second to breathe.

Adora wiped purple and green from her chin and finally took a full breath. Catra kept rubbing with her claws. "You okay?" she asked.

Adora nodded weakly. "I think so." Her eyes shut and more tears fell. "Fuck it still *burns*."

She had barely a minute to catch her breath before the heaving started again. Castaspella finally returned with what appeared to be half the medical staff in Mystacor. One of them caught the next spew with a bucket. Another spread towels across the glowing puddle. Someone else took a sample.

Catra couldn't do anything but keep rubbing. It was going to be a long night.

-

Clang. Clang. Cl-

Castaspella clamped her hand down on the alarm. She forced her eyelids open and rolled over in bed. Three AM. Time to check on Adora.

The poor girl had been through hell today. The unicorn potion had been a total failure. Adora's body reacted extremely violently to the concoction, which likely set her injuries back a considerable amount.

Castaspella pulled on a robe and flicked a light into her fingers. She stumbled out the door with a yawn and did her best to wake herself up along the way.

Castaspella sighed. She had been afraid it might not work. Swift Wind wasn't born a unicorn after all, and without a unicorn tear the potion was basically toxic. Even so, she never could have predicted it would fail so spectacularly. The agonizing internal burning Adora described had come as a complete surprise. Castaspella could only guess it was the result of some interaction with the infection, but it had never shown such a hostile reaction to any sort of magic or magical substances before.

Regardless, it was a damn shame. That potion might have been their best shot at healing the infection. Short of finding a real unicorn tear, they were running out of options.

Castaspella found her way to Adora's room. She extinguished her mage light and gently knocked on the door. She cracked it open. "Adora?" she lightly called. She heard no reply and so let herself in.

Catra's alien companion met her at the door. They blinked at her once and cocked their head. They let out a quiet mew and dimmed their glowing hue. Castaspella couldn't understand them, but she took it to mean, *"Quiet."*

The lights were dimmed to near darkness but not out entirely. Castaspella could make out Adora slumped across the edge of the bed, one arm dangling off, a crusty - but mercifully empty - bucket on the floor. Catra's mismatched eyes glinted even in the dim light, becoming the brightest points in the room. Her arms were wrapped around Adora's middle, her tail coiled loosely around Adora's leg.

"Is she asleep?" Castaspella whispered. Half-lidded eyes blinked up at her.

"Out cold," Catra mumbled back. Even in the dark Castaspella could see the bags under her eyes. Only the sound of her breathing, synchronized with Adora's, pierced the silence.

"How is she?"

"She threw up a bit more but there was nothing left in her stomach." There was not a trace of the hostility from earlier in Catra's voice. "All the heaving really did a number on her, you should probably check her ribs tomorrow."

"I see." Castaspella made a mental note to prepare some ingredients to reapply the healing spells. "Any more burning?"

Catra grunted negative. That at least was a relief. An upset stomach and broken ribs were something Castaspella could handle. She would at least get a couple days to think of something else for the infection.

Castaspella turned to leave but paused on Catra's weary eyes again. She hesitated, then asked, "Have you been awake all night?"

"Hm."

Castaspella saw Catra for the first time. She looked such a little thing, cradling her sick lover in the middle of the night. How could this be the same person who had caused such terror scant

months before? How could even war bring out such things in what seemed now so tender a creature?

Castaspella shook her head. "Well, I'll be back in the morning to check on her. You know where to find me if something comes up." She turned and made towards the door. She paused before the handle.

"And do try to get some sleep, dear. You've earned it." Castaspella quietly shut the door behind her.

-

"Back in a bit," Adora said.

"'kay." Adora closed the door and the sapphire roses retreated behind her into the room.

Catra let out a breath she didn't know she had been holding and reclined against a bookshelf. Perfuma had been very generous in rescheduling Adora's appointment this week to let her recover. Her schedule was always flexible, she said, and with Glimmer helping out, transportation was a non-issue.

Adora didn't throw up anymore after the first night but they still played it safe. The heaving had indeed done a number on her ribs, but a reapplied healing spell and they were back on the mend. After a couple days of chicken broth (which Catra had been secretly taking sips of when Adora was finished), Adora was back on her feet, if a bit unsteadily.

Catra was worried about her, of course. It felt like she had been constantly worried about her for the last four weeks. Maybe it was because what Adora was going through was a little too familiar. More than just being worried about her, Catra wanted to be there for her like Adora was for her.

Adora was exhausted. Catra could tell by the way she moved and spoke, even if she managed to fool Castaspella and the others. Adora said she was just tired from being sick, which was no doubt

true, but Catra could tell more was weighing on her. She hadn't been able to be out in the field doing things for weeks and Catra knew it was getting to her. And that's not to mention that she still couldn't even think about transforming.

Catra shook her head and stood up straighter. She had to get out of her head and just be there for Adora. Whatever it took. Right now, that meant waiting for her to finish up with Perfuma. Catra retrieved a tome from the shelf across from the private rooms. *"On the Histories and Peoples of Salineas"* was written in golden letters across its aquamarine cover.

Catra flipped to where she had left off. She had taken up reading as a hobby at Perfuma's recommendation, and waiting in a library was as good a time as any to read. She found herself especially intrigued by history books. They were often long and dry, but they were accurate. Any history they learned growing up in the Fright Zone was hardly more than necessary strategic information and propaganda. Now that Catra was actually *living* in Etheria, really being a part of it instead of trying to conquer it, she found the histories of the various kingdoms to be fascinating.

Her interest in the violent reign of the Pirate Queen of Salineas was cut short by a particularly grating set of footsteps. There were always a few unfamiliar steps in the library, but Catra had no difficulty making out Castaspella's curt gait.

Catra pretended to keep reading as Castaspella turned the corner. "Oh, um, hello. Catra."

"What," Catra hissed with more venom than intended, but not that much more.

"Well, I was wondering if I could, uh, have a word with you," Castaspella said in a measured tone. Catra sighed and dramatically snapped the book shut. She made no effort to hide her hostile body language. She was still mad at Castaspella for the potion debacle and Catra wanted her to know.

To both their surprises, Melog growled at *Catra* this time.

"She means well," Catra felt them say. *"Listen to what she has to say."*

"Ugh, fine," Catra grumbled, shifting her body to face Castaspella properly. "What is it?"

Castaspella took a moment to start. "Ahem, well. I know you and I haven't exactly... gotten along very well since you arrived at Mystacor. And I think I am to blame for that."

Catra shifted again, this time unconsciously. "I held certain prejudices against you from the war, and in particular I was worried about you and Adora." Catra's tail lashed. "But I did not let myself see that you are a changed person. You're not the monster I thought you were during the war, you're not a bad person. You're troubled and you're doing your best to be better, and you're doing it for Adora."

Castaspella finally looked Catra in the eye. "I'm sorry."

Catra shifted uncomfortably under her gaze. She crossed her arms and looked away.

"Go on," Melog said. Catra sighed.

"Yeah, well. I haven't exactly been very friendly either. Sorry," she mumbled. Castaspella's posture relaxed as she finally let her breath out. "And sorry about breaking into your little spa or whatever," Catra added.

Castaspella cocked her head. "Oh that. It's quite alright, I'm actually rather impressed you found it in the first place. Did Melog help with that?" she asked with a degree of professional interest.

Catra couldn't stop a proud smile. "No, I'm just pretty good at picking up on magic." She quickly regained control of her expression. "Years of practice," she added sourly.

"Ah," Castaspella said as she connected the dots. She fidgeted a little. "I, uh, would also like to apologize for-"

"Don't," Catra cut her off. "You hated her, I hated her. She was awful, now she's dead. I just want to forget about it."

Castaspella sighed in relief. "Agreed." Catra realized she had begun to dig into her palm and retracted her claws.

Melog approached Castaspella and rubbed their head along her knee. Castaspella giggled in surprise and ran a hand along their back, Melog arching into it. She pulled back her hand with a look of wonder and examined her hand.

"I've never studied magic from another world before," she said, voice breathy. "Would you mind if I spent some time with them?" she asked, looking up at Catra.

Catra shrugged. "You'll have to ask them."

Melog turned their head towards her. *"Perhaps."*

Castaspella looked from Catra to Melog and back and scrunched her brow, trying to decipher what they were saying. Her eyes practically sparkled with excitement.

The smell of roses wafted by as the door to the study room opened. Adora headed straight for Catra, her features a little lighter than when she went in. That's good. Catra was glad the sessions were helping, even if Adora didn't realize it. Catra certainly didn't realize it when she started seeing Perfuma.

"Oh good, Adora, I was hoping to catch you," Castaspella said warmly. Adora paused mid-stride and looked from Castaspella to Catra and back.

"Is everything alright?" she asked with a hint of caution.

"Yeah," Catra said. "We were just... talking." Adora looked back to Castaspella, and specifically to Melog fondly rubbing against her

legs, and relaxed.

"That's good." She gave Catra her "I'm proud of you" smile and Catra blushed a little. "So what's up?"

"Well, I was thinking," Castaspella began. "You've had a rough few days to say the least, and I thought you could both use a bit of relaxation. Now that your wounds are on the mend again, how would you and Catra like a visit to the steam grotto?"

Adora's eyes immediately lit up. "Oooh yeah! We still haven't been there yet, that would be great!"

Catra crossed her arms. "Steam grotto?"

"Yes!" Adora was almost bursting with excitement. "It's a bunch of awesome hot springs under the city that are always steaming and they're *so* relaxing. You'll love them!"

"And you just what? Sit in them?" Adora nodded her head eagerly. "Ehh..."

"Trust me, *nobody* is immune to the relaxing power of the steam grotto," Castaspella said. Catra still eyed her suspiciously. "And before you ask, I've already taken the liberty of closing the springs off for the evening. Nobody else will be there."

Catra looked over at Adora who was practically bouncing in place. Catra smiled a little. "Yeah, sure." Adora pumped her fist with a silent "yes!"

"Excellent, I'll have some swim suits and extra towels sent up to your room," Castaspella said. She turned to leave but paused. "Oh, and one more thing. Would it be alright if Glimmer and Bow joined you in the springs?"

"Yeah, I..." Adora turned her head. Catra shrugged. "Yeah, that would be great," she eagerly replied.

Castaspella laughed with a sigh. "Oh that's a relief, because this was Glimmer's idea to begin with."

-

Catra had never worn a "swim suit" before and was decidedly not a fan. The outfit, if it could be called such, was scarcely more than water resistant underwear. Even beneath a bath robe, Catra felt naked. Being naked with Adora was something she'd had plenty of time to get used to, but feeling such in public was very uncomfortable. The most experience Catra had with that was the communal showers in the Horde, but those were also at 6:00 AM in freezing water with soap that was practically battery acid, so feeling exposed was hardly at the top of her concerns.

Catra was just getting used to being around people in public as it was, let alone half nude in a city that already made her anxious. Fortunately, Adora understood, as she always seemed to, and had no problem with Melog cloaking them on their way to the hot springs. (And a good thing too, since they passed a pair of sorcerers about halfway there.)

True to her word, Castaspella had closed off the springs to the public. An ethereal fence and sign that read "Temporarily Closed" barred the entrance to the cave. The spell didn't seem to actually do anything if you crossed it, but it was still appreciated.

Bow and Glimmer were already waiting at the mouth of the cave, bath robes discarded, wearing identical pairs of wrappings as what were provided for Catra and Adora. Bow startled slightly as they materialized from the wall (Melog decided to sit this one out and was headed back), but Glimmer wasted no time in greeting them.

"Great!" she exclaimed, on Catra's shoulder in literally an instant before anyone else could get a word out. Months of resistance training stopped Catra from flinching. "I know you don't like water, but trust me, the hot springs are *amazing*!"

Glimmer continued to babble into Catra's ear as she led them into the cavernous grotto. Catra cast a pleading glance back at Adora. She waved and smiled apologetically as Bow fell into stride behind her, starting up a hushed conversation with a concerned look. Catra didn't have time to ponder that as Glimmer nearly dragged her alongside a pool.

The water was just like in Castaspella's hidden spring. An endless amount of steam rose from the pools, clouding the entire cavern and creating such a humidity that Catra felt like she might drown in the air.

Bow and Glimmer wasted no time in climbing in, Bow wincing a little as the water rose over his belly button. Adora was soon to follow, Glimmer helping her sit down slowly to mind her wounds. The bandages on her arm and torso seemed to repel the water entirely, not a drop sticking to her arm as she rested it along the rim.

She looked expectantly up to Catra and held out her good hand. Catra discarded her robe and took her hand. She stood on the rim and dipped a toe into the water.

She expected it to be searing, but it was surprisingly comfortable. She cautiously sank first her right leg, then her left into the pool, shivering as the water passed her knees. She tested her footing on the slick stones and found a ledge along the end of the pool. She slowly lowered herself into a seated position with a wince, keeping her neck and shoulders out of the water. The steam was even more powerful sitting in the spring. Despite her efforts, even Catra's unsubmerged fur was quickly soaked.

"Wow, never thought I'd see Catra willingly get in water," Glimmer teased. Catra flicked her tail and splashed water directly onto Glimmer's face. "Ah! How did you even do that with your tail!"

Catra chuckled smugly. "Years of practice," she said with a grin.

Adora leaned towards Glimmer and raised a hand to hide her mouth. "She exercises her tail too," she whispered. Their giggling was interrupted by another expertly aimed splash. For having never used her tail in such a manner of attack before, Catra was quite proud of her accuracy.

Adora gasped and splashed Catra back with her hand, a significantly larger amount of water than Catra's tail could move. This meant war.

Catra flicked water across all three of them, and the pool quickly descended into pandemonium. Alliances were drawn and treaties were broken. None were spared the wrath of the water.

"Okay, stop!" Glimmer cried over giggles and splashes. "Stop! We're here to relax!" she shouted in a decidedly not calm voice.

Ceasefire having been called, Catra relaxed and sank a little deeper back into the pool. The water licked at the scar on the base of her neck and she winced. She rose back out a bit.

Glimmer reclined on Bow's chest with a sigh as she sank all the way up to her nose in the spring. Adora opened her arm in invitation. Catra scooted around the step into Adora's embrace, resting against her but not putting any weight on her. She couldn't rest on Adora's breast without getting the scar wet so she settled on her shoulder.

This... was not wholly unpleasant. Being in the spring felt surprisingly not wet. Or at least not wet as Catra thought of it. Wet meant cold and uncomfortable, matted fur and waterlogged tail, dulled senses and heavy limbs. While her senses were dulled by the suffocating steam, it hardly mattered to Catra right now, surrounded by the people she loved most. And as long as she remained submerged, the water warmed her quite pleasantly, which was an entirely new feeling for water to give. The bubbles that rose sporadically from the bottom were also a bizarre sensation, but not an unpleasant one.

Adora sank deeper into the pool with a sigh. She closed her arm around Catra and rested the back of her head on the rocky rim. She slipped her hairband around her wrist and shut her eyes. Catra found her eyes stuck on Adora's beautiful little face. The way a smile tugged at the corner of her lips while she actually seemed to relax was intoxicating. Catra was overcome with that warm feeling in her chest and gave Adora a little kiss on her cheek. Adora's smile became full as she gave Catra an affectionate squeeze around the waist in return.

Catra's eyes wandered down Adora's body. Though the water obscured much of her, wearing nothing but a swim suit, Adora's impressive form was very clearly on display; as was the patchwork of scars that covered most of her body. The impression of the Failsafe on her chest, the branching lightning bolt scar that trailed from it up her shoulder, the bandaged wounds on her stomach and arm... the three sets of claw marks that peeked over the back of her shoulders, the myriad of faint scratches and cuts that crisscrossed her body at random.

Catra found her eyes lingering on a set of scars that ran across Adora's left thigh. Catra made them while she was chipped. A shiver ran down her spine despite the heat of the spring, and yet she couldn't look away from the faded wounds. There was something about them that was oddly... attractive. The way they highlighted the curves in Adora's muscular thigh, the rugged, battle-scarred look that they lent her... despite all the trauma and regret associated with those scars, Catra found they no longer bothered her like they used to. They still dragged up painful memories, but maybe she could make new memories with them.

Catra was stirred from her reverie by a slow gasp from Bow. "Catra..." he whispered as if trying not to wake a baby. "Are you... purring?"

Catra frowned at the realization that she was in fact purring, but found herself surprisingly unalarmed by the situation. She had never purred in front of Bow and Glimmer before, had she? Or in

front of anyone but Adora really. She shrugged and snuggled back onto Adora's shoulder.

Glimmer and Adora had opened their eyes too now. "I know you hate it when people say this," Glimmer said, eyes literally sparkling, "but this is literally the cutest thing I have ever seen in my entire life."

Adora glanced at Catra, expecting the usual rebuttal, but she was as surprised as Catra was to find she had no such response. Instead, Catra nuzzled her cheek against the crook of Adora's neck, scent marking her in public for the first time.

"Normally only Adora gets the purr," Catra said dreamily.

"Yeah, especially in the bedroom," Adora said with half a smirk.

Catra sat up and poked a claw into Adora's breast. "You'd purr too if you could, princess."

Bow and Glimmer exchanged glances as Catra and Adora's eyes locked. Adora's eyes were filled to bursting with pride, but Catra's held a devious leer.

"Wow look at the the time, we should really be getting to bed," Glimmer said hastily. She elbowed Bow. "Right, Bow?"

"Oh, uh, yeah, bed time," Bow said awkwardly. Adora looked confused but Glimmer was giving Catra a look that said "you owe me."

"Have fun, you two," Glimmer said with a suggestive smirk. She winked and Catra and Adora were alone in the pool.

Catra wasted no time in pressing closer into the crook of Adora's good arm. "I hope she didn't teleport them straight onto the bed," Catra chuckled. (Author's note: she did.)

Adora giggled. "Yeah, that would make quite a mess." (Author's note: it did.)

Catra rose out of the water slightly. She brought her lips to Adora's neck. "Why don't we make a little mess of our own," she whispered, grazing her fangs gently along the soft flesh of Adora's neck.

Adora's breath caught as a blush swallowed her features. She groped dumbly at the general area of Catra's bra clasp as Catra moved to straddle her lap. Adora's hands somehow finding no purchase, Catra decided to take charge.

She lowered herself onto Adora's chest, careful to avoid actually putting any weight on Adora's still healing ribs. She pushed Adora down into the pool up to her chin. The water around Catra's chest and throat jumped as she purred into a kiss. She broke the kiss and trailed her fangs along Adora's chin as her claws threatened to ruin another bra beneath the water.

Catra frowned when Adora made no response. She pricked Adora's back beneath her bra with a claw.

"Ah, huh," Adora mumbled, head snapping up. Her hands were rested on Catra's back but her legs were completely limp beneath Catra's.

Catra rolled her eyes and sank back into the water. She rested her head on Adora's shoulder and purred as loud as she could, the water between them vibrating with each breath.

Adora's head sagged again and she bolted back up. "Sorry," she began to say.

Catra cut her off with a pointed claw on her top lip. "Shh," she purred into Adora's ear. Adora's eyes almost rolled back in her head as she sagged against the edge of the pool. She was asleep in seconds.

Catra was a little disappointed, truth be told. But she wouldn't pass on the opportunity to let Adora rest, especially now. She was more than happy to lay at Adora's side and purr into her ear all night if it meant she would sleep.

Catra sank up to just below the scar into the water. Her wet fur stuck to her skin and chilled her in the air, but in the bubbling water, it floated almost blissfully, lifted by the gently rising current. Catra continued to purr unconsciously as she began to drift herself. She traced a claw along the line of Adora's bicep, careful not to prick her awake, admiring the muscle definition Adora had worked so hard for.

Catra yawned in that squeaky way that would have driven Adora wild if she was still awake. She was hesitant to fall asleep like this, exposed in an unfamiliar and public place, and especially in water. But Castaspella was right, damn her, the hot springs were *very* relaxing. Catra was only able to wonder if there was a limit to how long they could stay in before she joined Adora in a dream.

Chapter End Notes

> I'm noticing a pattern of ending chapters with Catra and Adora falling asleep in each other's arms.
> Melog brought them back to their room in an hour or so.
> Indulging my headcanon that Adora looks like Geralt in terms of scars and musculature, and in the classic hot tub setting no less.

A Perfect Soldier

Chapter Summary

> Perfuma tries to get to the root of the problem and realizes she may have bitten off more than she can chew.

Chapter Notes

> Content warning: References to past child abuse and psychological trauma from Adora's time in the Horde, as well as a small panic attack after. Fluff time is over, it's emotional growth time, and that starts with some very painful memories.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Helloooo," Perfuma nearly sang as Adora entered the room. Adora shut the door behind her and waited half a second for the hiss of the seal. She pulled up the chair and took up her usual position. She sat close enough to the wall to lean on it, but refrained from actually doing so. It would look lazy. Plus with her arm still kinda fucked up she probably couldn't anyway.

"Hi," Adora said, half a smile on her lips.

"Are you feeling any better?" Perfuma asked, oozing with sympathy.

"I am, thanks. Just needed some rest. And a trip to the steam grotto."

Perfuma chuckled. "Ooh, I've been meaning to try that one of these trips. It sounds very relaxing."

Perfuma waited her usual breath of delay before beginning. "Well, we didn't get a chance to talk about your breathing last time, since you were still pretty sick. How has it been going?"

Adora unconsciously puffed her chest out a little. "Great, actually. Catra and I do it together now after lunch and before bed." She was going to say more but caught herself before she said something embarrassing.

"That's great!" Adora silently chastised herself for keeping quiet. She was supposed to talk to Perfuma. What good was this if she didn't talk? "I really think this will help you in the long run if you keep it up." But Perfuma moved on without noticing so Adora kept quiet.

Adora awkwardly nodded and hummed in agreement. Perfuma waited a moment before continuing. "I would like to talk about some potentially emotional things today." Oh shit. Perfuma smiled softly at her. "Would that be okay?"

Adora took a second to respond. She had not expected her to ask like that. "Oh, uh, yeah, I guess."

"We don't have to if you're not ready yet, there's no rush."

"No!" Adora said too quickly. She bit her tongue. "I mean." She took a breath. "It's okay. I'm ready." This was bound to come sooner or later, might as well get it over with.

Perfuma considered her for a moment. Adora clenched her right fist together and prayed she wouldn't notice.

"Very well," Perfuma finally said. "But just remember, we can stop at anytime." Adora nodded.

Perfuma sat up a little straighter. "I'd like you to tell me about growing up in the Horde."

"Oh, uh." Adora rubbed her neck. "I mean. Don't you already know? Like, I know you talk to Catra, and I'm sure Scorpia too..."

"Yes, I have learned much about the Horde, but every experience is unique. I want to hear about your experience."

Adora blew out a breath loudly. "Geez. Where do I start?"

"Why don't you start with what you remember that was good?"

"Ha, that's a short list." Perfuma cocked her head encouragingly. "Well, I mean, Catra and the squad were the only real good from that. Especially Catra."

"Were you two close back then?"

"Oh yeah. I mean, not like now, but heavens know we both wanted it to be like now. Looking back, I can hardly think of a single thing we did together that wasn't one or both of us secretly trying to flirt. I don't think even we knew we were doing it," Adora chuckled.

Perfuma giggled with her. "What about the others?"

"Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio?" Perfuma nodded. "I mean, we were all pretty close. All good friends, we hung out a lot. Wasn't really anyone else to hang out with. I wasn't as close with them like with Catra though. She and I were... special.

"We were inseparable. She even slept at the foot of my bunk, curled up like a little kitty!" Perfuma laughed kindly as Adora doted on her memories. "And her mane was so much thicker back then, I'm pretty sure she was like 70% hair most of her life."

Adora sighed. "But besides being adorable, I think I really liked to hang out with her because she treated me... normal, you know?"

Perfuma shook her head. "What do you mean? Did the others treat you differently?"

"Well, no, I mean-" Adora paused to collect her thoughts. "Okay, so in every squad's fifth year of training, a squad leader is assigned. Normally there's this big trial and exam and everything - or so I'm told." Adora looked down. "Shadow Weaver just automatically made me the leader," she mumbled. "Said she didn't

need a test to know I was *special*." Adora sneered at the last word.

"Did Shadow Weaver ever hurt you?" Perfuma asked, voice as gentle as floating dandelion.

Adora grimaced. "No, not me. But, well." She gave Perfuma a glance. "It's Shadow Weaver. You've *met* her. I'm sure you've heard lots about her too."

Perfuma nodded sadly. "More than I wish needed to be said."

"Yeah."

Adora stared at the table for a long minute. Perfuma waited with her, giving her time to recoup. Adora was grateful for her endless patience. She took advantage of the silence to mull things over.

"She hurt the others a lot," Adora finally said, quietly. "Especially Catra."

Adora ground her teeth. "But not me though, never laid a finger on me," she grumbled with disgust. "She doted on me. Told me I was perfect and special and that I had to keep the others from dragging me down."

Adora huffed dryly. "You know what the worst part was? I believed her. I ate it up. I played right into her hand. I was her perfect little soldier."

Adora sighed. "I hate how much I loved it," she said almost to herself, unable to raise her voice. Perfuma was silent, seeming to urge Adora to vent, and she was happy to oblige.

"I loved it so much I was blind to everything else. Nothing but *her* vision of me mattered. What she wanted, I wanted. And it cost Catra so much.

"A couple weeks after the Heart, I saw how many scars Catra has hidden under her fur. So many electrocutions, so many whip

lashes. So many of her own claw marks." Adora's eyes were cloudy when she looked up at Perfuma. "So many times I didn't do more because I wanted to stay on Shadow Weaver's good side. How many of those scars wouldn't be there if I had done something?" Adora's voice cracked on the last word.

Perfuma nodded sadly. "I understand what it's like to feel like you have to protect others, especially those you love. When I first took responsibility in Plumeria, I was overwhelmed with the pressure. Every time someone got in an argument or died in a raid, I felt like I had failed them.

"I had to learn to acknowledge that I was doing everything I could, and I couldn't do more than my best. And sometimes my best wasn't what I thought it was, sometimes doing my best meant taking a day off to sleep because that's all I *could* do that day. Pushing myself further would have just been hurting myself."

Adora felt Perfuma's eyes on her. "What happened to Catra isn't your fault. You are not responsible for the actions of your abuser, *no matter what* they might have tried to make you think."

Adora nodded her head and wiped her eyes clear. "I think this mentality that you need to protect the others has stuck with you. Even though you're out of the Horde, your brain doesn't know how to operate any differently. We need to teach it that you don't need to protect everyone anymore."

"Except I do," Adora said meekly, averting her eyes again.

"Why do you say that?"

Adora met Perfuma with a cold stare. "I'm She-Ra. Protector of Etheria. It's my *duty* to protect the world." Adora stared forlornly at her right palm. "And now I can't even do that."

Adora shut her eyes and reached inside herself. She raised her right arm and formed her fingers around an invisible hilt. Knives stabbed at her heart where there should have been a blazing

radiance. She didn't care. She pressed the blades deeper and reached further.

Perfuma stood up abruptly. "Adora, stop!" Adora's furrowed her brow in concentration as her insides were rent asunder by a thousand wicked edges. "You're hurting yourself!"

With that word, Perfuma shot a vine to entangle Adora's arm. She forced it aside and broke Adora's concentration. Tears mingled with sweat as Adora looked up at Perfuma.

"How can I protect the world if I can't even be She-Ra," she whispered.

"The war is over, Adora," Perfuma pleaded, struggling to keep her voice calm. "You don't need to save the world anymore."

"THEN WHAT GOOD AM I ?!"

Unnatural silence descended on the room. The magical seal blocked out all ambient sound, not a footstep or bird could be heard. Only the sound of Adora's heavy breathing pierced the silence.

"Did you bring your flower?" Perfuma asked quietly. Adora nodded her head. "Let's do some breathing."

Adora realized she had stood up. She pulled the dandelion bud out of her pocket and sat back down with a wince. That stunt she pulled was not a smart move.

"Would you like me to count?" Perfuma spoke as if she tread upon ice. Adora shook her head.

Perfuma shut her eyes and Adora sat up straighter. She made a conscious effort to keep her fingers spread apart and nails faced upwards.

Minutes passed. Adora focused on her breathing as much as she could. Her breaths were ragged and tearing but she didn't care.

She kept rhythm with the flower and nothing more. Her mind was ablaze with memories. With each breath of the flower she dispelled another vision. Wicked words and a crimson mask. Dark lightning and a tiny scream. Bloody claws and tearing metal. Tears began to rise again and she blinked them back.

Perfuma let out a deep breath and opened her eyes. "Would you like to stop for today?"

Adora shook her head, not looking up from the flower. "No," she rasped, remembering how to use her voice. "No, I need to finish this."

Perfuma nodded her head lightly. "I understand."

Adora waited several more breaths before speaking.

"The hardest part of being She-Ra wasn't the responsibility or the sacrifice. I was used to that. Even if I shouldn't have been." Adora finally tore her eyes from the flower. "It was leaving Catra." Perfuma's eyes overflowed with sympathy.

"I hate how I just... *abandoned* her. I offered her the chance to come with me but..." Adora shut her eyes and turned her head down. "I never went back for her. I could have done so much more. I could have tried to convince her but. But all I did was drive her further away."

Adora wiped tears from her cheeks. "For three fucking years. I can't even imagine what she went through. I could have stopped it. I could have helped her. If I had only tried..." A lump in her throat choked her.

"You are not responsible for Catra's actions," Perfuma quietly said. "Shadow Weaver raised you to think that, but it's not true, and it never will be. You are responsible for nobody but yourself." Perfuma gently set her hand on Adora's. "You did the best you could. Nobody could have asked you to do any more than that. Catra made her own decisions. And in the end, it led to you finally being together."

Adora did not meet Perfuma's eyes. "The war is over now, Adora," Perfuma repeated, voice as soft as a petal on the breeze. "You don't have to protect Catra, or Etheria, or anyone else anymore."

Adora pulled her hand back. "I know," she whispered. "I *know* the war is over, I know everyone is safe. But I can't stop. I don't know why, but I just *can't stop*."

Adora finally looked at Perfuma, eyes pleading. "Please, how do I *stop?"*

Perfuma's calm composure broke down. "I don't know," she whispered. "I'm sorry." Adora's eyes drifted down to her palm.

"I'm sorry for the part I played in this," Perfuma said, voice small. "When I first met you, met She-Ra, in Plumeria, I put so much pressure on you. I thought you were literally the same She-Ra from the legends, over a thousand years old, returned at last to save us all. I saw the sword, but not the frightened eighteen year old girl who held it.

"I don't have the answers for you. I'm still learning how to be a therapist and I'm frankly out of my depth." She stood up and set her hand on Adora's shoulder. "But I promise, I will do everything I can to learn how to help you. You *will* get through this. I promise."

Adora did not return her gaze. "Thank you."

-

Adora stalked stiffly into the library, jaw set and fist clenched

"You were in there a while," Catra said, a hint of worry spilling into her voice.

Adora's nails dug into her palm and she quickened her pace.

"You okay?" Catra asked, concern now obvious as she fell into step beside Adora.

Adora shook her head and ground her teeth.

"Do- do you wanna talk about it?" Catra had to half jog to keep up with Adora's brisk pace.

Adora shook her head again and blinked back tears. She needed to get back to their room. She had worked Catra through enough panic attacks to recognize one herself. She just needed to keep it together until they got back.

Catra seemed to recognize it too as she nodded Melog ahead to clear the path. Grown to the size of a tiger, their alien bulk and threateningly red hue cleared away any potential obstacles.

Adora fixed her eyes on the floor beneath her feet. Melog was just ahead of her, near enough to follow without looking up. Catra was beside her, close but not touching. She knew as well as Adora that they needed no interruptions before they got back. Adora's breathing became more ragged with each step. It took all her willpower not to tense her left arm.

Her breath was rapid and shallow when they finally rounded the corner on their room. Catra rushed ahead to get the door and ushered Adora inside. Adora made straight for the bed and almost got there too. Three steps in, the dam burst.

Her right arm flailed in a spasm and she spat half a scream out through clenched teeth. She clutched randomly in the direction of her face, only barely managing not to tear her left arm open anew. She began to lose balance as panic overwhelmed her senses.

Catra was on her in an instant. She supported Adora on her good side and put her right arm over her shoulder.

"It's okay, you're okay," Catra said frantically as she guided Adora towards the bed.

Adora's breathing was completely unhinged, hyperventilation beginning to choke her. Tears streamed down her cheeks as she

clung to Catra like a drowning woman to driftwood.

Catra set her down on the end of the bed and immediately tucked Adora into her chest.

"You're okay, I'm here," she purred, rubbing her hand soothingly along Adora's back. Adora buried her face in Catra's collarbone and dug her nails into her fur.

Catra wrapped her tail around Adora's waist and made every effort to purr as loud as possible. She began gently rocking Adora and whispering variations of, "It's okay, I'm here, it will pass."

The tide of raw emotion that threatened to overwhelm Adora slowly receded. With each rock and each little circle Catra made on her back, Adora's breathing evened out a little more. Now she was just crying, still holding onto Catra for dear life.

Eventually, Adora ran out of tears and she felt the panic fully leave her. In fact, she felt everything leave her. Nothing within her rose to fill the void left by the faded panic attack. Only Catra's purr was there to fill that emptiness.

Her grip on Catra loosened.

"You okay?" she asked in so tender a voice one could scarcely believe it to be Catra's.

Adora sniffed and nodded her head into Catra's chest, not pulling back. "Yeah."

Catra purred a little louder on instinct. "Do you wanna talk about it?"

Adora shook her head and clutched Catra a little tighter. Catra lightly kissed her scalp.

"I'm gonna lie us down, okay?" Adora nodded weakly and Catra eased them back onto the pillows. Catra began to run the tips of her claws along Adora's back and she finally melted into her arms.

After long minutes, Adora's breathing finally returned to normal. She let herself be swallowed by Catra entirely, purr consuming her mind and fur flooding her senses.

"You did great," Catra whispered. "Panic attacks suck, but you made it."

"Fucking scary," Adora mumbled into Catra's chest, already half asleep.

"Yeah." Catra ran a claw through Adora's hair, pulling out the tie and letting hair fall over her shoulders. "Do you wanna change?"

Adora grunted negative and wiggled somehow even closer into Catra. "Thank you," she whispered. Catra's purr redoubled in strength, sending Adora quickly into a restless sleep.

Chapter End Notes

> This chapter feels really important in my head as I write it and think about it, so I can only hope that my writing can live up to the significance of the topic.
> That's also why Perfuma doesn't have an answer right now and won't by the time the fic ends: I don't know anything about a martyr complex. However, I do know about living with anxiety and depression, so I'm willing to write about some therapy for that stuff, but I don't want to presume to know how to write therapy for a martyr complex. Plus it's in character for Perfuma, being experienced with general mental health stuff but not quite being a professional therapist yet.

Second Opinion

Chapter Summary

> Five weeks have passed and Castaspella still can't figure out how to heal the infection. In desperation, she contacts the only other person on Etheria who might be able to help.

Chapter Notes

> Finally getting back to the infection. Content warning for depression cuz panic attacks take a lot out of you man.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora woke at dawn, as she always did. No matter how she tried, she could never break that habit instilled in her by the Horde and reinforced during the war. She would usually bask in Catra's warmth for a little bit before her muscles started to cramp or, more often, her brain forced her up. But this morning her brain was silent.

Her muscles still ached from sitting still too long but Adora didn't have the energy to move or care. She wasn't quite tired, she didn't feel exhausted like she was so used to. She just felt empty. Apathetic. Catra's fur was the only thing she could really feel, and even that felt somehow distant. Like rain on a window.

Adora stared up at Catra's peaceful form, the gentle rise and fall of her breath, the occasional twitch of her ear. Eventually Catra stirred and her mismatched eyes flitted open.

"How long have you been up?" Catra muttered half into the pillow.

"Dawn."

Catra blinked slowly and stretched, yawning with a little squeak at the end. When Adora produced only the shadow of a smile, Catra immediately tucked Adora's head into her chest and began to

gently purr. Adora let herself be pulled in without resistance. The rumbling against Adora's ear was shaky, inconsistent with sleep. Catra gently kissed Adora's scalp and began stroking her hair.

"How do you feel?" Catra whispered.

"Tired." Adora wasn't actually tired, she wasn't able to fall back asleep at all. In fact, she wasn't even sure if she had slept the previous night, it was all such a haze. But she didn't know how else to describe it.

Catra kissed her head again. "You'll be pretty beat for a couple days, it's normal after a panic attack. Especially the first. You know how I get after one."

Adora nodded her head slightly. That made sense. Catra was always very quiet and clingy after a panic attack.

"Come on," Catra whispered, sitting up a bit in bed. "Let's at least go through the motions."

Adora let Catra lead her out of bed into the bathroom. She splashed some water on her face in an attempt to come to. They still hadn't undressed for bed last night, so they slipped on some comfier clothes. Catra grabbed a bagel and Adora took a meager bite to satisfy Catra's worry.

Adora still made no resistance when Catra led her back to the bed. Catra pulled the blanket halfway up and leaned in for a kiss. Adora pulled away with a faint smile. Catra was practically beaming at the expression.

Her face softened as she asked, "Do you wanna talk about last night?" Adora shrugged. "What happened with Perfuma?" Catra ventured when Adora said nothing.

"We talked about the Horde. She said she couldn't help me. Not yet at least. Things got... emotional. Guess it got to me." Adora turned her head towards Catra and made the best smile she could. "I'll be alright though."

"Well, let's just take it slow today, yeah?"

Adora nodded and sank her head back onto Catra's chest. "Yeah."

Catra pulled her in and held her. She purred steadily now, and Adora began to feel the tickle of fur on her cheek again. Doing nothing like this somehow made it feel a little better. It complemented the nothing she felt. But the warmth of Catra's fur, the caress of her claws, the rumble of her purr, they all worked to fill the void in Adora's brain where there should have been emotion, or at least energy. Adora sighed. This wasn't unbearable with Catra there to do nothing with her.

Catra's ear twitched. An instant later a knock came at the door.

"Adora? Are you up?" Castaspella's voice echoed from beyond the door.

Catra groaned. "Shit, is it that late?" she swore into Adora's hair.

Adora heard the door open and Catra sat up straighter.

"Hello, girls," Castaspella said. "Adora, dear, are you ready for your checkup?"

Adora opened her mouth but no words came out. Catra spoke instead.

"No. We're closed, come back tomorrow," she hissed with a kind of venom Adora rarely heard from her anymore.

"Well, I-" Castaspella cut herself off. She seemed hurt by Catra's words, a first as far as Adora could tell. She paused for a breath and returned with a forced smile. "Whatever is wrong, I'm sure I can be of assis-"

"I said no," Catra interrupted. "Adora needs to rest. Leave." Catra bared her teeth slightly. From across the room, Adora could hear Melog begin to growl.

Adora sat up a little in the bed and set a hand on Catra's shoulder. Catra shot her a worried look. Adora forced a smile to her lips and nodded. Catra sighed. "Fine. What do you want?"

Castaspella did not seem to be paying attention; her eyes were locked on Melog's body and teeth shining like blood. She blinked and tore her eyes away from them as Melog relaxed their mane.

"Ahem, yes. The enchanters, this time, worked up something for you. It's a bandage, woven from threads of Swift Wind's mane and painted with healing runes. When applied to the wound, it should-"

Adora finally spoke. "Casta, is this going to work?" Her voice was low and grumbly, as if she were half asleep. She met Castaseplla with a stern gaze, or as close to one as she could manage. "Is any of this going to work?"

Castaspella was silent for a moment, debating herself, and sighed. "We've tried every healing spell, herb, and potion known to us, which I'm quite certain is all of them. You have been well rested and under constant care for weeks. But the wound refuses to heal and the infection shows no signs of improving."

She met Adora with a defeated gaze. "You're right. Nothing is working. I don't know what to do." Adora felt Catra's fur stand on end against her arm.

"Can't you ask someone else?" Catra said, voice rising in volume as she spoke. "There has to be *somebody* else who might know something you don't."

Castaspella shook her head. "I have considered an outside opinion, but every shaman, herbalist, and doctor on Etheria either trained here or uses methods known to us."

"Well there has to be *something!"*

Castaspella opened her mouth but quickly shut it. Her brow furrowed in thought. She paced briefly across the room and stiffly

addressed them. "The only person I can think of who might be able to help is... Princess Entrapta."

"Entarpta?" Catra's fangs were visible again. "She's not exactly a medical professional, you know."

"She's not a doctor, but she is well versed in all aspects of science, including biology. She thinks differently than we do here at Mystacor, she may be able to see something we cannot. And if the infection was caused by some kind of First Ones monster, nobody knows more about the First Ones than she."

Catra opened her mouth to object.

"Call her." Catra's head spun around to Adora.

"Adora, you can't be serious, Entrapta doesn't know the first thing about caring for real people!"

"But Casta's right. None of Mystacor's healers can find anything that will work and Entrapta might know something they don't. She's the only other person on Etheria who might be able to help."

"But-" Catra shut her eyes. She sighed concession. She set her hands below Adora's ears and pressed their foreheads together. "Okay."

Castaspella awkwardly cleared her throat. "I will see about contacting her. It may take a few days for her to arrive. Preparations will have to be made..."

Catra shot her a side-eye. Melog grew a little and stood up. Castaspella cleared her throat again. "I'll leave you two be, then. I'll let you know when we receive word from Entrapta."

-

Adora waited for Entrapta in the same medical examination room she had first been brought to. The rest of the Best Friends Squad

was there, as were Melog and Castaspella. (Swift Wind wanted to be there too, but he couldn't fit through the door, which was very rude of it.) Catra paced anxiously back and forth past Adora's examination table, Melog on her heels. Bow and Glimmer sat in a couple chairs that had been set against the wall, and Castaspella checked the medical cabinets to keep busy.

Adora felt a bit better after a couple days of nothing. Not even the usual daily checkups were there to interrupt these unprecedented levels of Catra cuddling. It was actually quite nice once Adora regained enough energy to appreciate her girlfriend. She even did some idle map work to pass the time. She was still feeling a bit drained though, like she hadn't gotten enough sleep, despite sleeping more hours a day than not.

Her physical wounds as well were mostly healed. Her ribs were nearly back to full strength, thanks to Castaspella's healing magic, and her arm no longer needed stitches. She still had to be easy on it though, and she made a point of wearing long sleeves to hide the enormous, still-fresh scar that ran the length of her forearm. The only thing that hadn't made any progress was the infected wound.

An upbeat hum announced Entrapta's arrival to the room, Castaspella smoothing out her robes, Bow and Glimmer siting up a little straighter, Catra and Melog halting in their rounds.

"Hello!" Entrapta called to nobody in particular as she swung through the door on her hair. She smiled broadly and scanned her eyes between the assorted faces.

"Ahem," Castaspella said when Entrapta made no indication of speaking. Entrapta just stared at her. "Good afternoon, Princess Entrapta. Welcome to Mystacor."

"Hi." Entrapta's hair idly began to fiddle with a light fixture.

"... would you like to inspect Adora?" Castaspella said with a hint of irritation mixed with confusion.

"Oh! Yes!" Entrapta said, recalling her hair from the half-dismantled light. "So, what seems to be the problem?" she asked Adora, retrieving a datapad from Etheria-knows-where.

Adora lifted her shirt. She unwrapped the bandage and revealed the wound, still glowing faintly green. "This." Entrapta flipped her mask down and inspected it closer. "This is where I was struck by some sort of anti-She-Ra monster the First Ones made at the Heart of Etheria. Prime took control of it and when it hit me, it caused some sort of infection that stopped me from becoming She-Ra. A few weeks ago, I was hit there while She-Ra and the wound re- ow!"

Without warning, Entrapta scraped a slice of tissue from the inside of the wound. Adora gasped as the scalpel sliced exposed flesh.

"Oh, sorry," Entrapta said, raising her mask. "Should I give a you a heads up next time?"

Adora clenched her fist and screwed her eyes shut. "No, I'm alright," she said through gritted teeth.

"Great!" exclaimed Entrapta, flipping her mask back down and apparently having already forgotten the incident. She placed the sample into a small rectangular container which she then inserted into her datapad. She bounced on her hair, swaying back and forth in anticipation. The others exchanged nervous glances. Entrapta's hair drifted back towards the light fixture as seconds turned to minutes. Only a beep and green light from the datapad spared it.

"Aha!" Entrapta flipped her mask up and skimmed through the datapad with remarkable speed. She nodded as her hair flew across the screen, pulling up a dozen different windows and dismissing them just as quickly. "Faaaascinating," she breathed, eyes the size of saucers. That couldn't be good. Nothing Entrapta found fascinating was ever safe.

"Well, I have good news and bad news," Entrapta said, addressing Adora. "The good news is, I know what the problem is." A collective sigh of relief was released. "The bad news is, I can't fix it." A series of small groans echoed the room.

"That is, I can't fix it here," Entrapta explained. "You see, there is a high concentration of nanobots in the wound."

Adora quirked an eyebrow. "Nanobots?" That didn't sound good.

"Yes!" Entrapta skipped up next to Adora on her hair and raised the datapad for her to see. "Millions of microscopic robots that self-replicate and travel throughout your bloodstream!" Adora saw on the screen a blurry image of several round, tube-looking shapes which she took to be some kind of cell, and a swarm of tiny metallic spheres.

"These bots don't have lasers on them, do they?" Catra joked in an attempt to lighten the mood.

"Actually they do!" When Entrapta noticed Adora's horrified expression, she quickly explained, "They appear have tiny lasers mounted on their bodies, not dissimilar to larger Horde war bots, which they likely use to bore into cells. They harvest the interior of the cell for fuel and use that fuel to reproduce and spread, destroying more and more cells at an exponential rate!"

Okay, that *really* didn't sound good.

"Wait, you said like Horde bots?" Glimmer asked.

"Yes, they appear to be of Galactic Horde origin, if their material composition is anything to go off of."

Entrapta didn't seem to be explaining any further, so Adora prompted her on. "How did they get in there?"

"Well, you said that's where you were struck by the anti-She-Ra monster, right?" Adora nodded her head. "When Prime briefly took control of Etheria, he must have upgraded the creature by

embedding it with these nanobots. When it cut you, the nanobots spread throughout your bloodstream and infected your body. I am 96% certain that's the cause of the infection you described. Imbued with the anti-She-Ra magic from the creature, the nanobots only had to spread and reproduce in order to cripple She-Ra." Entrapta was getting very excited.

"Can you fix it," Catra sharply interrupted before Entrapta got too far lost in her theories.

"Yes! I mean no! I mean maybe! I'll need to take Adora back to my lab in Dryl to do it, I need my equipment and Hordak's assistance."

The room went silent. If Entrapta noticed the concerned, bordering on hostile, looks directed at her, she made no indication of it.

"You need, uh, Hordak's assistance?" Bow gently asked when nobody else made a move.

"Yes! Hordak is the foremost expert on Galactic Horde technology. With my understanding of First Ones' tech and his knowledge of the Galactic Horde, we ought to be able to come up with a solution."

"Are you sure that is wise?" Castaspella said with a stern tone to her voice.

"Absolutely! Hordak is the smartest person I know," Entrapta replied, apparently oblivious to Castaspella's tone. Castaspella looked like she was about to say more when Adora intervened.

"Look, I'm sure if Entrapta trusts him, we can trust him too," she said, giving her best attempt at a reassuring smile to the others.

Entrapta stared at Adora, then at Castaspella, then back at Adora. "Ohhh, you don't trust Hordak! I get it, he tried to kill everyone here, including me, at least once. Don't worry, he's changed now." Entrapta smiled broadly at the crowd, unaware that her

reassurances did little to assuage their fears. "He's a good friend," she added when nobody said anything.

A good friend? That was something Adora never thought she'd hear *Hordak* described as.

"She's right," Catra chipped in. "Hordak's not half the villain he tries to be."

"Do you trust him?" Castaspella asked pointedly.

"For what it's worth? Yes."

Castaspella seemed unconvinced, but Adora took initiative. "When should we leave?"

Entrapta turned her attention back to the group, hastily replacing pieces of the now fully dismantled light fixture. "As soon as possible, right now if we can! Glimmer, can you-"

Castaspella interrupted her. "I think it would be best to give Adora time to-"

"No." Adora turned to face Castaspella. "I need to do this."

Castaspella opened her mouth but nodded concession.

Adora pulled her shirt down and got up with a grunt. "Let me get Swifty and then Glimmer can take us."

"Great! I'll tell Hordak to get ready!"

Chapter End Notes

> For the record, I don't think Hordak ever actually tried to kill Entrapta, at least not directly, or Castaspella for that matter, but it made for a good line.

Maybe News

Chapter Summary

In Dryl, Entrapta and Hordak give Adora the news.

Chapter Notes

Lots of (probably painfully inaccurate) medical stuff but nothing graphic or painful, although there's certainly plenty of angst and internalized ableism.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora was ready to leave within the hour. Glimmer would teleport her, Catra, Entrapta, and Melog to Dryl so they could immediately begin the scan. Swift Wind was coming too, but he prefered to fly when possible. Adora would have offered to go with him, but she could feel Castaspella staring daggers at her for even thinking about it, so instead Bow kept him company on the flight over.

Swift Wind leapt off Mystacor's floating island and disappeared into the clouds, Bow hollering along the way. Glimmer held out a hand and the five of them linked hands (and spectral paws) in a cricle. She concentrated for just a second and in an instant, they were outside the gates of Dryl.

"Hang on," Glimmer said. Another blink and they were inside the courtyard now, at the gate of the Crypto Castle. "Sorry. Didn't wanna risk teleporting us into a wall from so far away."

"Much appreciated," Catra mumbled, turning a little green.

Entrapta was already gone. The girls exchanged glances and followed her inside. The Crypto Castle looked much the same as it had the last time Adora was there, if a bit more cluttered. There was enough half-dismantled Horde tech - Etherian and Galactic alike - crowded in boxes and piled in corners to fill a junkyard.

"Welcome to Dryl," a low, cold voice said from the shadows. A pair of crimson eyes lit in the darkness and heavy steps echoed through the halls.

Adora snapped to attention and Glimmer raised her fists, glitter beginning to fall from her fingers. Hordak stopped in his tracks, halfway hidden in shadows that seemed to cling to him, and quirked an eyebrow.

Catra's laugh cut the tension. "Hey Hordak, what's up," she giggled, grinning at Adora. Adora's cheeks flushed and she relaxed her stance. Glimmer glanced from Catra to Hordak and slowly lowered her fists.

"Oh, good, Hordak!" Entrapta called, already halfway around the corner of the castle's labyrinthine halls. "Can you show them around, I'm gonna get things ready!" A metallic clatter suggested she had disappeared into a vent.

Hordak turned to them, and inclined his head politely. "This way."

Hordak led them down the passage directly ahead of them, turning without hesitation at every crooked corner and random intersection. The silence was unbearable, though Catra seemed to be drinking in the awkwardness radiating off of Adora and Glimmer.

"So, uh, Hordak," Glimmer fumbled. "You... live here now?"

"Yes," Hordak replied, without emotion and without interrupting his pace.

"... with Entrapta?" Glimmer prompted, trying to get something going to fill the silence.

"Among others." Glimmer coughed and Catra chewed on her fist to hold back a laugh.

Glimmer exchanged a shrug with Adora and they kept walking. She looked as awkward as Adora felt. Adora knew Hordak wasn't

her boss/enemy anymore, but his appearance said otherwise. He had returned to his old aesthetics since she had last seen him at the trial. He had looked rather frail then, humbled and exhausted, but now he looked every bit the dark lord he once was. His eyes were still blood red, and his crimson teeth still shone menacingly when he spoke. He still wore power armor too, red lights that couldn't have served any purpose other than aesthetic illuminating the joints. Together with his bat-like features, it granted him an imposing presence that beggared power. And yet, he was also currently politely ushering them inside like they were here for afternoon tea.

"Here we are," Hordak announced, leading them into a small room populated by a coffee table that might have actually been a piston, and a smattering of uncushioned metal chairs. Hordak waved his hand towards what could only generously be called a seating area, and Adora and Glimmer awkwardly took their seats, while Catra reclined against the wall, Melog beside her.

"Is there anything you require?" Hordak asked in that iron voice that felt so out of place playing host.

Adora and Glimmer shook their heads. "No, no, we're good."

Hordak clasped his hands behind his back and stood still as a gargoyle. Catra's grin only widened with each passing minute of unbearable silence.

"I, uh, like your armor," Glimmer said more quietly than she needed to.

"It is of Entrapta's design."

Glimmer nodded her head. "Yes, it's very. Shiny."

Hordak raised an eyebrow. "It assists me in day-to-day activities, if that is what you are asking."

"No! No, not at all, I just." Catra snickered and Glimmer shot her a look. "It's very shiny."

"Hm." Hordak's expression was impossible to read. Adora wasn't sure if he was glaring at Glimmer or if he just had a resting brooding face.

Adora's eye was drawn for the first time to the magenta crystal on Hordak's collarbone. It was clearly a First Ones' crystal, glowing faintly against the shadows that somehow found a way to swallow Hordak. She squinted at it and found writing engraved on it.

"Aw, that's cute," Adora said to herself. Hordak cocked his head and she shrank a little involuntarily. "Your crystal?" Hordak frowned and looked at his chest. "The writing on it?"

Hordak ran a claw over the engraving. "I was unaware that was writing," he said matter-of-factly.

Adora was surprised, she thought Entrapta would have told him all about that. "Yeah, it's First Ones' writing. It spells L-U-V-D. Loved." Hordak's eyes widened ever so slightly. "I thought that was sweet."

Hordak opened his mouth as though to speak - revealing those almost vampiric fangs that caught the light like a dagger in the dark - and shut it again. His ears flicked and Adora could have sworn she saw him blush. A peal of laughter split from Catra as she doubled over. This time Hordak was definitely glaring.

Adora didn't have time to process the implications of a blushing Hordak because Entrapta burst into the room, giving Adora and Glimmer a start.

"Okay! All set! Adora, come with me!" A tendril of hair wrapped around Adora's arm and tugged her out of the chair and towards a door. Adora sent a pleading look towards Catra who gave her a little smile as she caught her breath.

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Adora hunched over in an industrial chair in the waiting room, knee bouncing anxiously. Entrapta said the results of the scan

should only take a few minutes to process. Adora had a lot of tension built up. She had to remain perfectly still in the scan-tube-thing, and combined with the stress that had been building all day waiting for Entrapta's diagnosis, Adora was a little wound up to say the least.

Catra set a hand on Adora's shoulder. It was just her and Melog in the room with Adora; Bow and Swift Wind had arrived during the scan, but they and Glimmer were waiting outside to give Adora some space (and Swift Wind still couldn't fit through the door).

Adora squeezed Catra's hand and sat up straight. Melog nuzzled her legs and mewed.

"They say you're gonna ruin your back like that," Catra said. Based on the look Melog gave her, that was not, in fact, what they said.

The door hissed open and Adora's head snapped up. Entrapta shuffled in, uncharacteristically sheepishly, clutching a datapad to her chest. Hordak followed behind her, apparently unable to move in a way that did not cover his face in shadow such that his eyes glowed ominously.

"So?" Adora looked from Entrapta to Hordak. Neither said anything. "What's the news?"

Entrapta fiddled with her datapad. Her hair wandered towards her mask but didn't quite pull it down. "Well, we have confirmed my hypothesis," she began, voice lacking its usual excitement. "The infection is caused by a swarm of nanobots in your bloodstream. They are of Galactic Horde origin, mixed partially with First Ones' tech. In addition to harvesting the physical material of your cells, they also appear to siphon the She-Ra magic contained within them, which is why they are so effective at reproducing."

Adora's heart beat faster the more she heard. "Okay, so..." she composed herself. "How do we stop it?"

"There are two main obstacles with destroying the infection," Entrapta explained. "First is the bots in your bloodstream itself. They're constantly moving around and multiplying, making it incredibly difficult to track down and destroy all of them, and we do have to destroy *all* of them, because if even one survives, it will reproduce at an exponential rate, bringing the infection back eventually."

"But you can destroy them, right?" Adora asked with a pleading look in her eye.

"Well, there are a few ways we could do it. We could inject a corrosive virus that destroys any metallic objects in your body, but that runs the risk of also destroying your blood iron, among other things. A controlled electrical pulse could short circuit the bots, but a shock of sufficient strength would likely be highly damaging to you as well. Or we could try pumping your blood out, cleansing it of bots, and pumping it back in, but then any clean blood reintroduced to a contaminated system would become contaminated itself, rendering the process moot."

Entrapta paused to catch her breath. Catra and Adora's faces were both a mix horror and despair. "But the exact process can be worked out with a little research," she assured them. "There's a... bigger problem."

Entrapta stared at her feet and flipped her mask down. "I. I think Hordak should explain this part."

Hordak's ear twitched and he stood up straighter. "Very well." He cleared his throat and turned to face Adora.

"In addition to the bots flowing freely throughout your body, clumps of bots have anchored themselves to your blood vessels and created sort of factories in several locations. They have integrated themselves so thoroughly with your cells that it is almost impossible to distinguish bot from cell. The only way to remove these factories is to remove the surrounding regions of tissue. For the factory located in your femoral artery, for example,

removing a chunk of your leg would not be much of an issue. It becomes much more of one for the three located in your heart."

Adora touched her hand to her chest. Catra squeezed her shoulder. "So... what does this mean?"

"It means that even if we were to completely cleanse your bloodstream of nanobots, a risky process we have yet to fully develop, the factory bots fixed to your body would be impossible to remove without causing significant, likely fatal, damage." Hordak's face almost imperceptibly softened. "There is no way to safely destroy the infection." *I am sorry.*

The room was silent but for the constant hum of electricity. Adora stared aghast into space, struggling to process what she just heard. There was no cure. She would be like this forever. Crippled. Useless. Weak. Catra hugged her softly. Adora took one look at her eyes, filled with as much turmoil as her own, if not more, and collapsed against her chest.

"There's no way to safely destroy the infection *that we know of!"* Entrapta interjected, flipping up her mask and sounding like her usual chipper self again.

Adora lifted her head from Catra's chest. "What do you mean?"

Entrapta's eyes grew in excitement. "Well! So far we have only discussed scientific possibilities. There might be a cure of a magical nature that we haven't yet thought of."

"Castaspella already tried that," Catra said. "She tried every cure in Mystacor, nothing worked."

"They think solely in magical terms," Hordak said, voice ever so slightly beginning to mirror the excitement in Entrapta's. "When combined with technology, we may be able to discover something that the sorcerers could not."

Adora sat back up, wiping tears from her eyes. She would *not* cry in front of Hordak. "Like what, sir?"

Hordak cocked his head. "Well, you said you were infected once before, yes?" Adora nodded. "And this infection has only been bothering you again since you were injured? How was the infection alleviated the first time?"

"It was at the Heart. Catra told me she loves me," Adora said. Catra shuffled a little awkwardly, but Adora was beyond embarrassment at this point. "I told her I love her too, and when we kissed, She-Ra came back."

Hordak furrowed his brow but Entrapta leapt to her feet. "Fascinating! It seems the emotional significance of that moment stirred She-Ra awake enough to purge the infection herself, summoning enough energy to cleanse the bots instead of feeding them! Or perhaps the magic from the Heart of Etheria overwhelmed them, allowing She-Ra to emerge and keep the remaining at bay! Or maybe..."

Entrapta descended into a fit of frantic and excited babbling, tapping furiously at her datapad, pulling two more from her hair as well.

Hordak gave them an attempt at an apologetic smile, but instead just bared his teeth unsettlingly. "Return in the morning and we shall have something for you," he said. "In the mean time, I have prepared rooms for both of you, as well as a place in the courtyard for your steed."

"Oh that's alright, we only need one room," Adora reassured.

Hordak frowned. "In that case, I shall have an extra mattress moved in."

Catra chuckled. "Just one bed will do," she said with a taunting look in her eye that began to set Hordak's hair rising. Adora unconsciously held her breath and sat up straighter.

Hordak took a breath and smoothed out his hair. "Very well. This way, please." Did Hordak just say "please?" Maybe he really was

changed. He walked briskly towards the door, darkness following in his wake like a cloak. Then again, he was definitely still Hordak.

Adora followed him out, but Catra hesitated in the door. "Uh, Entrapta," she stammered. "Before we go..."

"Yes?" Entrapta directed her full body attention at Catra.

Catra winced and looked away. "The monster also got me at the Heart." Entrapta blinked at her. Catra sighed. "Do you think there could be bots in my blood too?"

Entrapta leaned back on her hair and considered for a second, a strand of hair mimicking a thumb at her chin.

"No, I don't think so." Catra's shoulders visibly relaxed. "In addition to the physical material of the cells, the nanobots also have to harvest the raw magical energy in Adora's body to reproduce. Without the immense magical power of She-Ra permeating every cell of your being, any nanobots that did enter your blood stream would have been unable to reproduce and thus been destroyed by your immune system."

Adora didn't quite catch all that, but it sounded good. She and Catra exchanged a glance that said they felt the same.

"Of course, I could always take a sample if you want to be sure," Entrapta added, pulling an alarmingly large syringe from the depths of her hair.

"No! No, I'll take your word for it."

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Swift Wind's mane was the softest thing in the universe. Sorry, Catra, but Swifty's got even you beat here. Horses were already the perfect animal, but Swift Wind was even more perfect. He was smart like a person, a genuine friend, not a pet. Maybe a loud and somewhat immature person, but a friend nonetheless.

But for once he was silent as Adora stared at nothing, idly running her hand through his mane. Adora didn't have to say anything for him to know she needed quiet comfort right now. Sacred bond and what not. And Adora figured it showed on her face too. She could tell her eyes held an empty look, mirroring the uneasy apathy she felt.

Swifty bumped his head gently into her, and she smiled a little. Adora hugged his neck, and he wrapped a wing around her in silence. They didn't need words and even Swift Wind knew now was not the time for joviality.

"Hey," Catra said quietly from behind Adora. Swift Wind moved his wing aside and Adora released his neck. "I filled Bow and Glimmer in on what's happening. They said they want to give you space to absorb all this, but they're always one call away. They'll be in Bright Moon but they can be out here in an instant if you need them."

"Okay. Thanks."

Swift Wind bumped his head into Adora's shoulder. "I'll be here too. And I know when you're down, so don't try to hide from my support."

Adora kissed him on the nose. "Thanks, Swifty."

Melog rubbed against her leg and she ran a hand through their mane. Adora did not understand the meaning of their mew, but she felt the intention. They joined Swift Wind in the makeshift sleeping area Hordak had mentioned as Catra led Adora to their room.

Adora was silent the whole way there, staring at the floor.

"Are you okay?" Catra asked so softly as the door hissed shut.

"For some reason," Adora said quietly. "I dunno, I don't feel super scared. Just kind of... empty." She searched Catra's eyes for answers.

"It's called depression," Catra said with a voice that spoke of experience. She pulled Adora in for a hug and began purring. "I asked one of the wait staff to bring some food up in an hour or so. Let's take it easy 'til then, yeah?" Adora nodded into Catra's chest as she sat them down.

Catra continued to purr and began running her fingers through Adora's hair, pulling the tie out as she always loved to.

"I guess I wasn't really expecting good news," Adora said after a while, "so a maybe was the best I could hope for."

"Maybe it just hasn't hit you yet," Catra said, purr faltering. "Nanobots eating your blood is a pretty crazy thing to be hit with."

Adora chuckled a little despite herself. "Yeah. Not as crazy as Hordak though."

Catra smiled a little and raised an eyebrow. "Yeah? That so?"

"What, do you *not* think it's weird, seeing the former Dark Lord of the Fright Zone - our old *boss* - politely ushering us in for tea?" Adora scoffed, a bit of energy returning to her voice.

"Ha, I practically bullied Hordak into letting me run things during the last year of the war. He's not as scary as he thinks he is." Catra gave Adora a devious smile. "That's why we were winning, by the way."

Adora pushed her hand into Catra's cheek. "So you've told me, jackass."

Catra gasped dramatically. She flashed her fangs in a grin and bit Adora's hand. Adora recoiled on playful instinct and they wrestled on the tiny military cot. Eventually the giggling died down and they settled back into a comfortable position, Adora's head on Catra's chest.

"I can't believe you called him sir though," Catra teased.

"What! I did not!"

"Oh yes you did! When he was asking about how you stopped it the first time." Catra held her hand to her forehead in a mock salute. "Like what, sir," she said in a mocking voice.

Adora slapped her hand away and Catra grinned wickedly at her. She didn't even try to retaliate. She knew she'd won this round and was already purring in victory.

Adora conceded defeat and rested her ear on Catra's chest. Catra kissed her scalp and resumed running her hand through Adora's hair.

"You'll get through this," Catra whispered.

Adora felt her energy slip away again. "You promise?" she said weakly.

Catra squeezed her. "I promise."

Adora just held her tighter.

Chapter End Notes

> I love the idea that Hordak is just naturally such a villain that he always moves like a vampire. He can't help but constantly be spooky and it's very unsettling if you're not used to it.

Wet Timber

Chapter Summary

> Entrapta provides a series of increasingly intimate activities for Catra and Adora to share in hopes of creating an emotional response powerful enough to summon She-Ra.

Chapter Notes

> Content warning for horni, but nothing explicit, because I'm no good at writing smut. Plus the chapter's already long enough. Also excruciating pain and self-hatred at the end. But horni too.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora couldn't sleep. Her mind was ablaze with all the ways Entrapta might be able to come up with to help her. And all the things that would happen if she didn't. But Catra couldn't sleep much either, it seemed, so they felt comfort in being miserable together. As the sun finally rose, Catra rose with it for once. She and Adora shared breakfast in the courtyard with Swifty and Melog for company.

All of the food in Dryl was in miniature, so they had to take the entire plate of pancakes. At least the syrup bottle was normal sized. They found a place to sit near the edge of the industrial courtyard, overlooking the mountainous valley below. Pancakes teetered precariously on the rail as the four of them admired the sunrise in silence.

The sun passed close by a moon, making the morning darker than it should have been. A few stars were still visible, sparkling as hard as they could to be seen through the sky. The birds hadn't realized it was dawn yet, and the bugs had already gone away, so the air was perfectly serene. From out here, even the continuous clamor of the Crypto Castle's machinery was muted.

The wind blew westwards, wafting fresh air into them and the stench of industry away. Adora sighed with the wind, gazing longingly into the sky. How she yearned to climb on Swifty's back and go meet the sunrise herself. She could even take Catra with her now too (provided they flew slow enough). But Adora knew she was in no condition to fly, physically or mentally. That was fine though. She was anxious to hear Entrapta's findings.

Fortunately, Entrapta was as eager to share her theories as Adora was to hear them. She found them not long after they finished breakfast.

"Great, there you are!" she shouted from across the courtyard. Swift Wind's ears perked up, Melog stretched, Adora turned around, Catra continued to admire the dawn. Entrapta closed the distance alarmingly fast with her hair, skittering along like a giant purple spider. "I have good news!"

Catra turned her head. "Let's hear it."

"Okay! I said I have good news, what I mean to say is that I *might* have good news!"

"What's your plan?" Adora asked bluntly. She was too tired to work through Entrapta's babbling right now.

Entrapta didn't seem to register Adora's brusqueness. "Well, I have several theories running, as does Hordak, so while he's looking into those in the lab, we can start work on my first theory!

"The first time the infection was temporarily cured, it was because She-Ra resurfaced with incredible strength, overwhelming the bots' ability to harness energy and destroying most of them. I believe this surge of power was caused by the emotional significance of the moment of confession between you two. If we could recreate such a response, Hordak and I might be able to take advantage of the weakened infection to cleanse it entirely!"

"That's great!" Adora said, feeling something like hope again. "How do we do that?"

Entrapta's eyes lit up. "That's where the experimentation begins!" she said, voice giddy with excitement. "The first time it was a kiss that did it. Perhaps that will work again?"

Catra raised an eyebrow. "That was our first kiss. Adora and I have kissed a thousand times since then. I don't think it will create the same response."

"Probably not, but we have to try it anyway! Failure is always an option in scientific experimentation!"

Hopefully not in this experiment, Adora thought. "No reason not to I guess." She flashed half a smile at Catra.

Entrapta pulled a recorder out of her hair and clicked it on. "Hypothesis one, experiment one: kissing." She looked expectantly at Catra and Adora. "Proceed when ready!"

Catra rolled her eyes and dropped from her perch on the rail. She grabbed Adora by the collar and pulled her in for a long, remarkably sensuous kiss. They had to be thorough, of course. To confirm the accuracy of the data. Their hands began to work up their backs, cupping each other's chins. Catra's scratchy tongue massaged the roof of Adora's mouth, her fangs nipped at her lip on the way out.

Swift Wind whinnied. "Alrighty then. I'll be anywhere else. You know how to reach me." With that he leapt over the rail and dove into the valley. Melog ran after him, leaping onto his back, apparently to his surprise considering the sound he made. Adora giggled a little.

Entrapta was furiously taking notes. "Any reaction?"

Adora looked at her hands and shrugged. "Nothing."

"How do you feel?"

Adora looked at Catra, breathing a little heavily from the kiss, her short but growing hair swaying in the morning breeze, a half

cocked smile revealing a single fang. "Happy."

"Experiment one, supplementary: No reaction, subject feels happy," Entrapta said into her recorder. She clicked it off and stowed her datapad. "Excellent! Onto the next!"

"What do you have in mind?" Adora asked.

"Well, continuing along the vein of stimulating emotional response through romantic affection, we should try increasing the intimacy of the activities." Catra and Adora stared blankly at her. "Like a date?"

"Ohhh," they said in unison. Entrapta was getting good at noticing when she needed to clarify something.

"We'll start with a walk through the valley, nature has been known to have a healing effect on people. After that, we'll do a romantic dinner, and then who knows!" Entrapta kicked her feet off the ground with a shrill giggle. "This is so exciting! I'll inform the wait staff and get a skiff warmed up!"

And just like that, she was scampering off again, hair clambering over obstacles like an octopus swimming through the air.

Adora shook her head. "This is gonna be a long day of testing, isn't it?"

Catra elbowed her lightly. "Hey, I could get used to this kind of science."

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The hike lasted clear into the afternoon. Dryl's signature tiny food made excellent for packing on a hike, if not the most filling. They took it slow and leisurely, talking and stopping to enjoy all the wondrous things Etheria had to show them. They even napped under a tree after lunch. It felt great to finally be out in some fresh air after having been cooped up in Mystacor for so long.

Entrapta did her best to keep her distance to preserve the integrity of the experiment, but it was still disconcerting to catch a glimpse of her scuttling through the canopy like a six-legged monkey. Still, most of the time Adora managed to forget she in an experiment.

Her ribs began to ache a little about halfway through, and her feet were sore from walking so much after so long in bed, but Adora enjoyed it. It felt good to finally push her body again. She knew she had lost some muscle definition during recovery and she was eager to earn it back. Even if she couldn't start on that yet, this was a good way to scratch that itch in her brain.

She didn't think of it as hurting herself, but she didn't think Catra would agree. So Adora drank the pain willingly and projected the joy it brought her. Some part of her knew this probably wasn't healthy, but a larger part needed it right now.

The sun lay lazily in the sky by the time they returned to Dryl. Entrapta had given them a lift down to the valley, but they walked the remainder of the way back up the mountain to the gates. A quick debriefing later and they were in the showers for a break before the next experiment: dinner.

The showers were communal and lined with steel, just like they grew up with, except this time they could totally make out in the shower. Not as sexy as it sounded, actually rather inconvenient. They reluctantly agreed to just quickly clean up instead.

Adora frowned at her spare clothes as she toweled herself off.

"What's wrong?" Catra asked, thoroughly running every inch of her fur through a series of towels.

"I dunno, it feels weird to wear normal clothes to our romantic dinner."

"Not like we brought dress clothes. And neither of our hosts seem like very fancy dressers."

"Maybe Entrapta's staff have something we can borrow?"

"I doubt they have anything with a tail," Catra muttered.

Adora stared at the clothes messily folded on the bed and was struck with inspiration. She tore the sheet from the bed and retrieved her knife from her pack. Catra gave her a side eye as she wrung out her tail. A few cuts and hairpins later and Adora had finished her masterpiece.

"Ta-da!" She turned around to present her makeshift dress to Catra. A shoulder fell off as she raised her arms, exposing her chest. "Okay, we'll wear clothes underneath," Adora mumbled, covering herself in a towel again. "But isn't this better?"

Catra frowned and wrapped herself in a towel, finally having dried herself to her content. "But why?" The confusion in her voice sounded very genuine.

"What do you mean why? It's a fancy dinner, we gotta dress up!" Adora gave Catra her best puppy dog eyes. "For the integrity of the experiment."

Catra failed to suppress a grin and rolled her eyes. "Fine. But you're making mine too."

"Deal!"

Another montage of horrendous tailoring and a ruined bed sheet later, and there was another dress for Catra. Adora even used a red sheet she found in the closet, to complement her own white bed sheet.

Catra pulled the dress (if it could be called such) over her underclothes and grimaced in the mirror. "I don't like dresses," she grumbled. She lifted her leg and sneered at how the fabric fell away to her thigh.

Adora meanwhile was distracted by a sloppy cut on the back that very intentionally revealed Catra's shoulder blades. "I dunno, I

think you look pretty good."

Catra turned around with a cocked eyebrow. "You know this is just a bed sheet, right?"

Adora smiled dopily. "I'm not complaining."

Catra shook her head and failed to hide a blush as she pinched the bridge of her nose. "This is so stupid."

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"Aha, there you are! Come on, dinner is ready!" Entrapta paused and looked Catra and Adora up and down. "Ooh, makeshift dresses, I like it! This will maintain the authenticity of a romantic meal, I should have thought of that."

Adora gave Catra a "told ya so" grin, earning a toothy smile in return that pointedly bared Catra's fangs. Adora giggled, satisfied in her victory.

Entrapta led them into Dryl's communal cafeteria, which had been emptied of people and furniture for the occasion. A single table in the corner was set with a maroon tablecloth (definitely not a repurposed Horde banner), fine silverware laid neatly before two chairs. A candelabra lit the table in a romantic mood light, the overhead lights dimmed and windows shuttered.

"Go ahead and take your seats, I'll be watching from the other room!" Entrapta said, pointing at a camera set up in the corner. "But try not to think about me. Enjoy your meal!" And with that she was scurrying up the wall and into the vents, like some sort of humanoid squirrel.

Catra watched her go with some form of morbid fascination, but Adora was hungry. She bowed and held her hand out for Catra. "This way, ma'dam," she said in her cheesy fancy voice.

Catra rolled her eyes and smiled, taking her hand and letting herself be led to the table. Adora kissed her hand as they sat

down and was rewarded with a playful bap from Catra's tail.

The chairs were surprisingly comfortable by Dryl standards. At least not everybody in the city shared Entrapta's industrial pragmatism.

A waiter was out to greet them very soon after they sat down. "For this evening's meal, the chef has prepared a roast ham, glazed in honey, as well as mashed potatoes, cranberry sauce, and homemade stuffing." Adora recognized most of that. The ham sounded good. "Would the ladies like anything to drink with their meal?"

"Apple juice, please," Adora said. She found apple juice went well with most things, and of all the juices she had tried, she liked that one the best.

The waiter nodded and looked to Catra. "Surprise me."

"Very good."

Catra yawned as the waiter left and reclined a bit in her seat. "So how ya feelin'?"

Adora wiggled her shoulders. "Fancy." Catra rolled her eyes. "But really though, that hike was great. It felt *so good* to finally get some fresh air and actually move again."

"Didn't overwork yourself?"

"Oh stop worrying, I'm fine!" Adora said with a smile. "I haven't felt this good since we went to that festival."

Catra chuckled. "Oh yeah, I remember that. When was that? Three months ago?"

Adora cocked her head. "Four?"

Catra squinted in thought. "Yeah, four." She shook her head. "Hot damn, has it really been six months?"

Adora smiled at her. "Seven."

Catra blew out a long breath. "Yeah, seven... When are we gonna go to space anyway? I thought we would have gone by now."

"Yeah me too. But everyone's so busy with reconstruction and politics and stuff." Adora shrugged. "Maybe on the anniversary, that would give us time wrap a couple things up."

Catra was about to say more but waiter returned with their drinks. They set a beer mug of apple juice down for Adora (which she quite appreciated, those glasses were sick) and a glass of red wine for Catra. Catra sniffed the wine and sloshed it around once or twice before taking a testing sip.

"How is it?" Adora asked with interest. She remembered some of Catra's other reactions to alcohol.

Catra took another sip and shrugged. "Not bad."

"High praise from miss spit take," Adora teased.

"Hey, you should have warned me better. How was I supposed to know vodka was made to literally punch you in the mouth?"

"You know Frosta drinks vodka?"

"What, the little one? Bullshit."

Adora giggled. "No really, I've seen her down shots like they're nothing at her birthday parties. She wasn't even drunk after either, they're freakin' tough up north."

"You would be impressed by that," Catra teased at her. "You're probably tipsy just smelling this." Catra raised her glass and sloshed the wine at Adora.

Adora shrugged, grinning ear to ear. "What can I say, it's a gift."

Adora raised her apple juice mug in a toast as their giggling died down. "To us."

Catra smiled broadly. "To us."

They clinked glasses and each took a drink. "I might have to ask the waiter what this is when they come back," Catra said.

"That good?"

"Eh, it's alright. I like those other ones more. What were they called? The fruity ones with the salt?"

"Margaritas?"

"Yeah that's it. I like those more. But this seems easier to make for myself."

They continued idle chat until the wait staff brought their food out a few minutes later. Adora was pleasantly surprised to find it was all in normal sized portions, specially prepared for them. Catra's thoughts of her wine were quickly forgotten as the savory scent of the ham greeted their senses.

The ham was hands down the best thing brought out, as evidenced by how much of it Adora ate. After a while the waiter just left the whole ham on the table. But it was just so *good*, with that crispy honey glaze on the edge of each little slice of heaven. Adora also discovered the little bread rolls made for excellent sandwich buns.

Hot pumpkin pie topped with whipped cream was brought out for dessert, which was a new one for Catra. Adora wolfed hers down in hardly five bites, while Catra picked at it cautiously at first, then with suppressed gusto once she got a taste.

"I still can't believe you thought it was going to be a whole pumpkin," Adora giggled as Catra finished her slice.

"It's called *pumpkin* pie!" Catra scoffed through a full mouth. "What else was I supposed to expect it to look like?"

"I don't know, like a *pie*. Something made *out of* pumpkin, not an actual pumpkin," Adora taunted. "I mean, what, did you expect me to drink my apple juice straight out of the apple too, like some sort of fruit vampire?"

"Don't tell me you didn't make that mistake your first time too."

Adora leaned back smugly. "Maybe I did, maybe I didn't, but you weren't there, so you'll never know."

"Hm. I bet Sparkles does," Catra said, narrowing her eyes.

Adora matched Catra's glare. This could be dangerous. Glimmer knew almost all of Adora's first food experiences. She had to figure out how to keep Catra from getting that information from her. Perhaps a bribe?

Her scheming was cut short by Entrapta's abrupt entrance through a vent above the table. "Experiment three, supplementary!" she shouted without prelude. She held the recorder in Adora's direction.

Adora considered for a second. "Well, I still feel happy. But way happier. And fuller."

Entrapta hummed as she scribbled notes. "Enough to spark a response from She-Ra?"

Adora looked at her hands. Nothing. "No. Normally it should be but..." She gently tried to reach inside but was quickly stopped by pins and needles. "But it's like the infection is holding her back. I can't reach her."

Entrapta clicked the recorder and stashed her pad. "That's okay, I still have two more experiments to try!" She clapped her hands and multicolored lights flashed on, startling Catra. The cafeteria

was lit up like a dance floor, dim mood lighting illuminating the space. "Up next is dancing!"

Catra stretched her arms as she stood up, that messily low cut dress doing exactly what Adora hoped it would. She held out a hand to Adora. "Shall we?"

Adora took her hand and let herself be led onto the dance floor. There wasn't any music yet, which made things very awkward, but they could work with it. Adora settled her hands on Catra's waist, Catra's hands around her neck, and they began to rock to no rhythm in particular.

"Oh! Right, music!" Entrapta called from the darkness at the edge the dance floor. (She seemed to have adopted Hordak's uncanny ability to blend into the shadows, revealing nothing but the glowing magenta eyes of her mask.) A second later a slow song kicked on, sounding like it was already partway through.

Catra leaned in closer and rested her head against Adora's chest. Their hands drifted together, one pair close to their bodies, the other lazily held outwards.

"These things really do look awful," Catra mumbled into Adora's chest. The V-neck of Adora's "dress" was already fraying at the edges. It would be indecent if she wasn't wearing a sports bra underneath. It happened to fall away in such a way as to highlight the lightning bolt scar that split her chest.

"I think I did pretty good for a novice tailor." There were the right number of holes at least. She even made one for Catra's tail. Okay, maybe it was twice as big as it needed to be, but it's the thought that counts.

Catra shut her eyes and sighed dreamily. "Yeah. I guess you did."

Adora became lost in the moment. Their footwork was sloppy but never stumbling, they knew exactly where the other was going to step before they did. A purr crept up from Catra's chest. Adora felt it vibrate into her own rib cage, soothing her with every breath.

She leaned her cheek down to rest on Catra's head, her little cat ear flicking adorably as Adora's hair brushed against it. Adora shut her own eyes now and soaked in Catra's presence.

Several minutes later and the song slowly faded out. Catra looked up at Adora as they both opened their eyes and stilled their feet. They kissed long and sweetly, pulling away with reluctance.

Adora tried to reach inside as she looked into Catra's eyes. She felt so close to reaching She-Ra, like a word on the tip of her tongue, but there was something blocking her. Even as she ignored the pain in her abdomen, she felt a barrier in the front of her brain. A dam in the emotions she normally channeled to call upon She-Ra.

"Experiment four, supplemental!" Entrapta bounded over to them, recorder in hand.

Adora sighed and shook her head. "Still nothing." Entrapta looked at her expectantly. "Same as last time, it's like there's something in the way."

Entrapta clicked the recorder off and hummed. "Well, since you two have been together for a few months now, perhaps something more intimate is required to stimulate the necessary emotional response."

"Like what, exactly?" Catra cautiously asked.

"Sexual intercourse!"

Catra and Adora's faces both flushed bright red.

"But we've, uh," Adora cleared her throat, "we've already had sex, before. It's not new like at the Heart."

Entrapta blinked in contemplation. "Have you tried it since the injury?"

Adora exchanged a glance with Catra. "No, but-"

"Great! It might not work but, but like I say, failure is always an option. I'll get my notes, where will-"

"Woah woah woah. Hold the fuck up," Catra interrupted. "You are *not* watching us have sex."

"But I've recorded every other experiment so far," Entrapta protested, unaware of the problem. "It is crucial in proper scientific research that the same methods of observation be used in every-"

"No."

"But, but," Entrapta made puppy dog eyes, "but the dataaaa."

Catra's fur ruffled a little. Adora stepped in.

"Entrapta, what if we take notes for you?"

Entrapta opened her mouth but finally seemed to notice Catra's fluffed tail and slightly bared fangs. She rubbed her chin and considered.

"Hmm... alriiight, I guess." Her hair shot out in three directions and returned with a datapad, her recorder, and a pen for some reason. "But be sure to take thorough observations!" She shoved the recorder into Adora's hands and Catra barely caught the datapad. Nobody caught the pen. "Record every action that takes place! Oh, and it's especially important to note exactly when each of you-"

"OKAY! GOODNIGHT!" Catra grabbed Adora's shoulders and abruptly turned them away.

"That was mean," Adora scolded as they walked back to their room.

"Good thing I know you like bad girls then," Catra growled.

Adora grinned hungrily and they walked a little faster. Their dresses were practically already falling off of their own accord by the time Catra locked the door behind them.

Adora paused to fiddle with Entrapta's recorder. "Okay, now how do I..."

Catra swiped it out of her hand and clicked a button on the side. "Experiment five: fuck Adora's brains out." She clicked the recorder again and tossed it aside.

-

Entrapta did not give them the luxury of sleeping in. She was knocking on their door at the crack of dawn, before even Adora was fully awake.

Catra punched the door panel. Entrapta looked from her glare, to Adora's disheveled hair, to the ruined bed sheets piled by the bed.

"How'd it go, do you have any notes?"

"No," Catra deadpanned. Entrapta looked incredibly disappointed, but was quickly distracted by Adora.

Adora stood up and extended her hand. She shut her eyes and focused. She breathed deeply like she had been practicing. She slowly and calmly probed inwards. She was met with a sharp jab in her stomach.

"Gah! Still nothing!" She turned to Entrapta. "There's got to be something else we can try, right?"

Entrapta rocked back on her hair and pulled an extra datapad from her belt. "I have several working theories, however I'll need more time to research them further."

"How long?" Adora dreaded Entrapta's response.

Entrapta cocked her head. "Hmm, two weeks, maybe three?"

Adora groaned. "No, no, no! The infection's only going to get worse the longer we wait, there has to be *something* we can try!" She turned to Entrapta. "Please, tell me you have something!"

Entrapta opened her mouth but quickly shut it thrice in succession. "We could... no, it's too risky. I need to do more research."

"Entrapta, whatever it is, we need to try it. *I* need to try it." Entrapta looked away. "Please." Adora's voice was hollow.

Entrapta sighed heavily. "If you access your sacred bond with Swift Wind, it could provide an energy surge powerful enough to overwhelm the infection, like at the Heart. BUT! If the surge isn't enough to completely overwhelm the infection, it will only make it stronger, dangerously so."

"We have to try it," Adora said, voice between stern and pleading.

"Adora, maybe she's right," Catra said softly, placing a hand on Adora's shoulder. "We don't want to risk making things worse."

"We've waited long enough!" Adora turned on her heel to face Entrapta. "I'm *tired* of waiting for a cure, we're doing this!" She shook Catra's hand off her shoulder and brushed past Entrapta.

Swift Wind was already waiting for her outside, Melog pacing between his legs. He already knew what she was planning.

"Adora, are you sure about this?" he asked as gently as a horse could.

"Yes." Adora briskly walked up to him and placed her hand on his muzzle. She felt the concern radiating off of him. She sighed and pressed her nose to his, running her hand down his mane. "Please, Swifty. I need this. I need this to work."

Swift Wind whimpered and lowered his horn to Adora's head. Adora heard Entrapta babbling into her recorder in the distance. Catra was silent. She pressed her forehead against Swift Wind's.

Swift Wind shut his eyes. Adora felt his horn begin to glow beyond her eyelids. Time slowed as an invisible wind kicked her hair. For the briefest instant, she felt the magical energy being absorbed by her body.

But just as quickly, it was cut short. Agony erupted from Adora's stomach. Swift Wind tried to pour in more energy but the pain only grew. Adora's veins ignited with metallic flame. Every muscle in her body simultaneously clenched in agony, paralyzing her. She couldn't even open her mouth to properly scream. Swift Wind tried to pull away, but so intense was Adora's pain that he too became paralyzed by it as it surged into his body through their bond.

Adora heard distant shouting and suddenly Melog was between them. They shoved Adora away from Swift Wind's nuzzle. Adora's body went limp but the pain remained. It overwhelmed her senses so completely she could know nothing else. As she finally blacked out from the pain, the last thing she saw was Catra's face, damp with tears.

-

It took the entire day and enough painkillers to drug a horse to get Adora stable. Entrapta wasn't a doctor, but she was more than capable of treating Adora. Catra's hand never left Adora's for five and a half hours.

Entrapta had managed to quell the worst of it. The bots were so present in her bloodstream that even the unrefined techniques Hordak had been developing were sufficient to purge some. But it wasn't enough. She could still hardly move, every beat of her heart sent a wave of agony through her body.

Entrapta finally retired for the evening, satisfied that Adora was stable enough for the night. Adora had never seen Entrapta exhausted like that before. She still wanted Adora to stay in the medical room overnight though, in case anything came up. A medical bot was monitoring her while Entrapta was away.

Catra sat next to Adora's bed, rubbing her thumb gently along Adora's palm. Every touch on Adora's body brought fresh pain, except Catra's. Her touch somehow soothed it, brought the briefest of relief to her broken body.

Broken. That's all she was now. Crippled. She could never be She-Ra again. She could never help anyone again. Useless. And it was all her fault. Because she was so fucking *stupid.* Everybody warned her. But she wouldn't listen.

"Hey, it's okay," Catra whispered, wiping a tear from Adora's cheek.

"Go to sleep," Adora croaked.

"Not until you do."

Adora sighed. She shut her eyes, but knew she would find no rest. Not when she could barely think through the pain.

Catra slept in her seat, her hand never leaving Adora's.

Chapter End Notes

> This feels like a good time to remind everybody that Adora WILL be fine by the end of the story.
> Overall not super happy with the end of this chapter. It felt like a very abrupt shift from the mostly fluff that took up the entire rest of the chapter. But then again that small talk over dinner scene is also my favorite scene in this fic, so it balances out I suppose.

Hand in My Hand

Chapter Summary

> Nothing worked. The infection has crippled Adora and the surgeries are all too risky to attempt. There may be no cure.

Chapter Notes

> Are y'all ready to CRY because this chapter is the climax and the title is from After the War and just thinking about that song makes me tear up. Main content warning for this one is chronic pain.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Good morning." Entrapta's voice was unusually subdued. She sounded tired. Adora opened her eyes. She hadn't slept. Not really. Catra's eyes flitted open. She lightly kissed Adora's hand and stretched, working out an evening of kinks in her back.

Entrapta pulled up the medical bot's log and ran through it. "How do you feel?" Adora blinked slowly. "Never mind, stupid question. Can you move your arm?"

Adora did so. Slowly, painfully, but she raised it.

"Good. Can you sit up?"

Adora took a deep breath and willed her body upwards. She swung her legs over the end of the bed like lead, Catra's hand on her back for support. Her head spun as she sat upright, but it passed quickly enough.

Entrapta flipped her mask down. "I'm... going to be blunt with you. The infection has nearly tripled in severity. We've done our best to suppress it, and we have at least stopped it from crippling you, but I'm afraid there's nothing more we can do about the

pain. All of the surgeries Hordak has been working on are too risky to even consider. All we can do now is wait."

Adora said nothing.

-

The remainder of the day was spent testing Adora's limits. The pain had fallen off dramatically since yesterday, but it was still constant. As she acclimated to the pain, Adora began to regain more motor functions. By three o'clock she was standing. By six she was walking. By nine she was in her room with Catra.

Bow and Glimmer visited the next day. They brought cheesecake and ice cream. Perfuma offered to visit for a session, but Adora declined. She was too numb to talk. Swift Wind was also sore and lethargic, Adora's weakness infecting him too through their bond. Entrapta regularly checked on her like Castaspella had before. She found as little success in each visit.

-

Three days later, Adora rose at dawn, as she always did. She had been awake for much longer this morning, though. Even with Catra's comforting warmth and lulling purr, it was hard to rest. The pain in her veins had lessened enough for her to function, but the fog in her mind had only thickened. She had no more tears to shed.

Even so, her restless brain could not be sated. She had to get up. She sluggishly worked her way out of bed, Catra so exhausted she didn't even stir. Adora shakily stood to her feet. Her hand reached briefly for the cane Entrapta had left for her, but she stopped herself. She didn't need help to walk. She wasn't that bad. She couldn't be.

Melog blocked the door. They looked into her empty eyes for a long second before they bowed understanding and stood aside. They mewed gently as she passed, and Adora could have sworn it sounded like, *"Be well."*

Adora limped into the courtyard to greet the sunrise. She leaned on the wall for support, knowing sitting would only cause more problems. She shut her eyes and lifted her chin to the burgeoning rays of light, seeking the warmth therein.

"Good morning," came a low rumble from behind her.

Adora's heart leapt out her throat as she spun on her heels. "Ah! Lord Hordak! Sir!" She clacked her bare feet together, her hand snapping to her forehead in a hasty salute, wisping strands of hair across her face.

Hordak stood at ease, arms clasped behind his back, feet spread, back slightly hunched, and wore... a night gown? Adora remembered where she was and released her stance with a wince.

"Uh, sorry," she mumbled sheepishly. Her hands still found their way behind her back in an unconscious mimic of Hordak's stance.

"Hm." Adora still couldn't tell if he was glaring or not.

It was bizarre to see ~~Lord~~ Hordak so humbly dressed; she had never seen him without armor or Horde robes before. His posture was also unusual. He stood as though he were trying to stand to attention but was unable to fully straighten his back.

"So..." Adora awkwardly started. "What has you up at this hour?"

"A lifetime of warfare has fixed my circadian rhythm to a military schedule," Hordak replied without pause, as if those were all words regularly used in casual conversation.

Adora processed for a moment. "Yeah. Me too."

They both stood silent, half at attention, in the dim light of dawn.

Hordak finally broke the silence. "How are you feeling?"

Adora blinked back to the present. "Oh, uh," she hesitated for a second. "Not good."

Hordak cocked his head. "What are your symptoms?"

"Everything hurts. Burns. I can... feel my blood eating away at my body with every heartbeat."

Hordak nodded. "You are at least able to walk, a promising sign, though I would discourage much more physical activity."

Adora chuckled dryly. "Yeah, I've heard that one before," she muttered.

Hordak quirked an eyebrow. "I do not know much of Etherian physiology, but I am versed enough to know rest is a critical part of the healing process," he said with a slight edge to his voice that raised Adora's hackles.

"Yeah, I know, I-" Adora took a grounding breath and smoothed out her hair. "I need some food. Walk with me to the cafeteria?"

Hordak quirked his head and nodded. He fell into step beside Adora, hands still clasped. Despite towering a foot over her, Hordak felt very small next to Adora. She found herself having to slow even her limp to keep him from falling behind. He walked stiffly, not like a soldier, but like an old man.

They arrived at the kitchen, a serving bot rushing to greet them. Adora took two mini-bagels and plate of baby sausages from the platter, but Hordak waved the bot aside. Adora picked a table overlooking Dryl's courtyard and sat down. The bot placed a glass of undefined dark red juice next to her plate.

She took a testing sip from the glass (cranberry juice, she decided) as Hordak sat down in the chair next to her. He grunted as he bent his legs and tried to hide a wince as his back touched the chair.

Adora swallowed her bite and gave Hordak a worried look. "Are you okay?"

"I am fine," Hordak sharply replied, a little too quickly. When Adora continued to give him a concerned eye, he added, "It is merely pain, nothing to cause concern."

"Is it... chronic?" Adora cautiously asked.

Hordak growled and turned his shoulder under Adora's worried stare. Through a gap in his night gown, she saw a patch of hideously disfigured, almost dead, skin. She gasped and Hordak whipped his arm around with surprising speed and bared his teeth with a low hiss.

"I'm sorry, I didn't mean to prod," Adora hastily apologized. "I just..." She sighed. "I just wanted to know how you live with it."

Adora stared at the table. "I just feel so... useless. So weak. Like I've failed everyone, even myself." Her voice began to crack. "I don't know how anyone can live like this."

Hordak looked taken aback. He stared at her with an expression Adora had never seen him make before. Sympathy and sadness played across his alien features. For the first time Adora could remember, he looked concerned, and not in a "my evil plan is falling to ruins" kind of way, but genuinely caring.

Hordak rolled up his sleeve and bared his arm to her. The clearly defined white and dark blue skin of a regular Horde Clone was completely deteriorated. Hordak's blue skin looked sickly, spreading out in uneven tendrils of decay. The musculature of his arm was nonexistent. The necrotic skin retracted almost completely to the bone, to the point of revealing a gaping hole between the bones in his forearm.

"It is a genetic disease, a defect in my cloning," he stated matter-of-factly. "It necrotizes my muscle tissue and saps my strength. It also causes considerable pain when agitated even slightly."

"Is that why you're always in your armor?"

"Yes. My own attempts at halting the disease bore no fruit until Entrapta designed for me a new exoskeleton." He rolled his sleeve back down. "That is why I was never in the field before the final year of the war."

They were both silent. Adora's sausages went cold. She rested her right arm on the table and stared into the palm. "So how do you... handle it?"

Hordak followed her gaze. "Entrapta's work on the armor provides considerable, but not complete, relief from the pain, though I am unable to sleep in it. I have become accustomed to suffering during my time on Etheria."

Adora sagged back in her chair, eyes downcast. "I see," she said quietly.

Hordak's brow moved in a way it never had before, working itself into a concerned knot. His crimson eyes were glassy, as if on the verge of tears.

"The armor provides a measure of comfort," he forced himself to add, "but it is Entrapta herself that provides the most relief." Adora looked up at him. "Ever since my hunger for conquest has died, it is through her company that I have been able to sustain myself through the pain." Hordak hesitated, clearly treading in uncharted territory. "Perhaps your Catra can provide you with similar strength."

Tears trickled across Adora's cheeks. Hordak looked somewhat alarmed but made no move.

Adora sniffled and wiped her cheeks. "Thanks," she said through a sad smile.

-

Adora worked her way slowly back through the courtyard towards her room and Catra.

"Adora!" she heard a cry halfway there. Adora smiled at Catra as she raced up to her. "Are you okay?"

"Yeah, I'm alright," Adora said, still a little emotional.

Catra sighed in relief, then anger. "You can't just run off on me like that! I was worried sick!"

"Yes, mother," Adora said, elbowing Catra lightly.

"I'm serious. You're in no condition to..." Catra caught herself. She knew how sensitive Adora was about being taken care of.

Adora smiled warmly. "I know. I'm sorry." Catra returned her smile, beaming at the little bit of life that had seemed to return to Adora.

Adora looked up at the mid-morning sun; one of the moons seemed like it might pass by it. "You think there's gonna be an eclipse today?"

Catra shielded her eyes from the sun and squinted. "Maybe." She glanced at Adora with a hint of excitement. "Do you wanna find somewhere to watch?"

"Yeah. Somewhere high and quiet."

Catra bounded ahead of Adora, leaping up the Crypto Castle's ramparts with the experience of a childhood spent traversing the Fright Zone. She would climb ahead, out of sight, then return shortly to guide Adora up a gentler way. Eventually they made their way to the highest east rampart, overlooking the valley below.

Catra reclined against a crate and Adora reclined against her. Catra wrapped her arm around Adora's shoulder and Adora placed her ear against Catra's collarbone. Catra's tail coiled around

Adora's leg and her purr began to rumble into Adora's skull, soothing her.

"How are you feeling?" Catra asked gently.

"Better with you," Adora said. And she wasn't just being corny either, she actually *did* feel better with Catra. It must have been a placebo, but at the end of the day it didn't really matter. It hurt less when she was with Catra, and that's all that mattered.

The sun started to dim as the moon passed in front of it. An otherworldly shimmering shadow pattern covered the world as the eclipse began to darken the sky.

"Do you think we're right under it?" Catra asked. There was an excited edge to her voice, like there rarely had been since they were so young.

In a couple minutes, the shimmering faded as darkness fell upon Dryl. They were in fact in the perfect place for a total eclipse, what luck. It had practically turned to night now.

Adora gasped as she looked back at the sky. The stars were out, full as night. That great band of stars that Entrapta called an arm of the galaxy split the sky, passing right behind the eclipsed sun. Grand pink and purple clouds, larger across than Adora could even fathom, colored the heavens, dotted with a billion shining worlds.

Eclipses were pretty common on Etheria, on account of all the moons, but Adora had never experienced one like this before. The moon that happened to be blocking the sun this time was a smaller one, and it was perfectly sized to the sun. It covered it exactly, creating a tiny ring of silver light shone past its edges like a halo.

Adora tore her eyes from the starscape and glanced at Catra. She gazed into the stars, eyes wide with all the breathless awe and wonder a child. Adora's breath caught as she was enraptured by Catra's beauty. Time seemed to halt as she admired her. It was as

if the whole of the universe was reflected upon a yellow and blue canvas in her eyes.

It *was* the whole universe she saw, Adora realized. All of Adora's universe was there at her side, everything she had ever wanted since before she even knew what wanting was, held in her arms. Adora was scarcely able to process the wave of joy that swept her away into Catra's arms. She felt as though she were floating through the cosmos, bound to the world only by Catra's grace. She had never felt so speechlessly *happy* before.

Tears fell from Adora's eyes as she smiled at Catra with all her heart. Catra looked away from the sky only after the last star faded from view.

"Oh! Are you okay?" Catra cupped Adora's chin and wiped the tears from her cheeks.

"I have never been more okay," Adora breathed, still completely smitten by Catra's perfection.

Adora threw her arms around Catra and buried her face in that lovely fur on Catra's chest that was a little bit longer than anywhere else. Happy sobs wracked her body and her smile never faltered.

Catra rested her arms on Adora's back, rubbing gently. "Shh, you're okay. I'm here, it's okay, you're safe."

She was right. Adora was *safe*. For the first time in her life, she felt truly safe. No more fighting, no more war... no more She-Ra. Just Catra's warmth. Nothing else in the universe mattered.

Adora pulled her head up from Catra's chest. "I love you so much." Her smile was so wide it was beginning to ache. "No words could ever describe how much I love you. You are everything I have ever wanted, you're *perfect.*"

Adora took Catra's hand between her own. "I don't know what's going to happen to me, but I don't care anymore. Not as long as

you're there with me. Nothing could ever be wrong if you're with me."

Catra was crying too now. "Adora, I..." She didn't know how to handle this much emotion either, so Adora just kissed her. Their hands cupped each other's heads as they embraced in pure joy.

Adora had never felt better in her life. She never would, she decided. Nothing in existence could ever possibly compete with the unbridled perfection of this moment.

"Adora," Catra gasped, pulling away from the kiss. She stared at Adora with awe. "Your eyes," she breathed.

Adora looked into Catra's mismatched eyes and saw her own shining within them like the stars before.

Her limbs no longer burned. She sat up in excitement. She shut her eyes and called timidly inwards, almost afraid to try again. She was finally answered.

A burst of golden light enveloped Dryl as all the magic of Etheira poured into Adora's muscles. She-Ra knelt before Catra, outshining the sun itself.

Adora peeked her eyes open and grinned at her armor. She saw that resplendent golden plate and the shimmering gemstone in the center. She cried out in joy, laughing as she took Catra in her arms, sweeping her off her feet and into a kiss. She spun Catra three feet off the ground as she danced in rejoice.

Dust swirled around them as Swift Wind's powerful wings beat excitedly. "Adora!" he cried with unconstrained excitement. "You're okay!"

Adora ran to meet Swift Wind, leaping to meet him midair. She tackled him to the ground laughing, rubbing her nose against his. "You're okay! You're okay!" he continued to shout.

Catra leapt onto Adora, and Melog was soon racing in to join the pile. Adora pulled Catra into a kiss, holding her above the ground with one hand. As the kiss broke, the collective laughter died down and everyone worked to disentangle themselves.

"You are okay, right?" Swift Wind asked, rolling back over onto his knees.

Adora stood up and properly inspected herself. She pressed her stomach, lightly at first, then with more force. It was still sore, even as She-Ra. As she pulled her hand away she stopped as she caught sight of her left bracer.

A massive crack ran down the front of the bracer, in the same place as the wound on her arm. Adora ran a finger across the crack, finding it did not go all the way through, and seemed to leave the bracer mostly functional.

"Well, better than before." Adora showed the bracer to Catra. "But not quite all the way I guess." Catra's face became worried as she approached and inspected the crack herself. "My stomach is still sore too, we should go see Entrapta." Catra nodded.

Swift Wind whinnied and bowed his head in offering. Adora grinned and leapt onto his back in a single fluid motion, like she had longed to do for so so long. She held out a hand to Catra. "Shall we?"

Catra just stared at her for a second, a bit of a blush filling her cheeks. She-Ra's heavenly aura, Adora's radiant smile, the way her hair billowed like a kite in the wind, the absolute *size* of her biceps, the crack on her bracer that said she was still human, still Adora; safe to say Catra needed a minute. She lightly placed her hand in Adora's, moving as if in a dream.

The yelp that left her lips and the way she clung to Adora as she was hefted onto Swift Wind's back in a single swing like she weighed no more than a kitten said she was definitely awake now though. Swift Wind beat his wings and launched off the ground at

a near ninety-degree angle. Adora shut her eyes and cried out in unison with Swift Wind as she felt the wind on her face for the first time in too long. Catra meanwhile clung a bit tighter to Adora and started muttering something like a prayer.

Swift Wind leveled out below the clouds, letting the wind carry them on his wings. Catra finally opened her eyes and relaxed a little. They made one pass around the city before beginning their descent into the courtyard below.

Entrapta and Hordak had both heard the commotion and awaited them at the gates to the Crypto Castle. Entrapta was bouncing with excitement and Adora could have sworn Hordak was smiling.

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Entrapta wanted to begin the operation as soon as possible, before the infection had time to recover. She-Ra's return purged the majority of the bots in Adora's bloodstream, but the factories were still producing more. Adora was quickly put under anesthesia and Entrapta and Hordak operated on her.

Even with the infection weakened and She-Ra's healing powers returned, the wound on Adora's stomach still refused to close. A skin graft was applied to cover it, but Adora will have to always be careful of putting to much pressure on that spot - even as She-Ra.

The gash on her arm was fully healed, but an enormous scar still ran the length of Adora's left forearm; another for the collection.

As many of the factories that could be safely removed were; enough to slow the rate of the infection, but not to prevent it from returning. Adora will have to continually cleanse her bloodstream with She-Ra's magic or else it could spiral out of control again. Furthermore, the pain was still ever present, a constant ache in her veins. It will remain, day and night, for as long as she lives.

But as Adora woke from surgery, as she found her hand in Catra's, as she saw the faces of Bow and Glimmer at her bedside, she

decided she could live with that.

Chapter End Notes

Bonus: Adora being prepped for surgery
Just magically giving Adora all of her She-Ra powers back felt counter to the whole theme of the story, but taking them away permanently was also way too harsh. So I settled on something that permanently weakens She-Ra in a way that is representative of Adora's growth during this story, but doesn't hinder her ability to go on space adventures and generally be a badass.

Epilogue

Chapter Summary

Adora acclimates to life with the infection.

Chapter Notes

Alternative title: Continuing to indulge my headcanon that Adora looks like Geralt in terms of both scars and musculature.
A little lewd because they're both nude and in bed, but that's just because I needed all of Adora's scars visible. If you haven't read Show me your scars, I'll show you mine, this chapter references the events in there a few times. Not required reading, but it will provide a bit of context for some scars, and it makes a nice mirror of the concluding scene.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Thanks again for agreeing to this on such short notice," Adora said. She sat in the Bright Moon gardens, mid-afternoon sun warming her skin against the chilly winter breeze.

"Of course, it's no trouble at all," Micah said. "In fact, I just gave this lesson to Glimmer a few weeks ago, so I already have it all planned out."

Micah grunted as he took his seat on a cushion opposite Adora in the cobblestone ring.

"Well, let's begin." Micah cleared his throat. "Passive casting is a technique wherein a spellcaster maintains a spell's effect for extended periods of time without having to devote their full attention to the spell. It requires intimate familiarity with the spell being cast and months of meditation and practice to learn this technique." Micah smiled. "Or at least that's what I would have said before Glimmer mastered it in under a week."

Adora raised her eyebrows. "Wow, is she really that good?"

"Well, yes," Micah said, pride spilling into his voice. "Though I suspect her connection to the Moonstone also goes a long way. By having both a natural and learned connection to magic, she has a far greater ability to control magic than likely anyone in the world. Maybe even more than anyone in history, if she practices enough."

Micah shook his head. "Anyway, I think this will be even easier for you, on account of it being such a simple spell you want to cast, and the fact that She-Ra is the living embodiment of magic on Etheria. For any princess, but for you especially, using magic is less like wielding a tool and more like flexing a muscle.

"Nevertheless, this technique is all about focus. Tell me, Adora, have you ever tried meditation before?"

Adora puffed out her chest. "As a matter of fact, I have." She deflated a little. "Er, well, I've done some breathing exercises before. I dunno if that counts or..."

Micah chuckled. "No, that will do nicely. Let's start with some deep breathing." Micah readjusted his position to sitting crisscross and Adora did the same. "Focus on your breathing and ground yourself completely in the present."

Adora shut her eyes and began counting breaths in her head.

"Good," Micah said after a few minutes. "Now, without interrupting your breathing, begin to cast the spell."

Adora reached inwards and called on She-Ra. She willed cleansing magic to surge through her veins, alleviating the constant ache a little more with each beat of her heart.

"Now, without stopping the spell, return your full attention to your breathing."

Adora did as instructed. The magic almost immediately faltered. "Do not let the spell fade. Recast it if necessary, but try not to let it get that far. Return to your breathing for as long as you can before the spell begins to falter, then bolster it again, and repeat."

Adora renewed the magic. She inhaled and golden light filled her veins. She exhaled and it carried metallic corruption out of her body. She began to count her breathing again, but kept a corner of her mind on the spell.

She felt Micah's eyes and opened her eyes. He was beaming at her. "Very good," he said proudly. "You figured that out even faster than Glimmer did, and she smashed the old record."

Adora smiled a little awkwardly. "Yeah, well, I am She-Ra though, so I don't know if I count. It would be like if I entered in a weight lifting competition as She-Ra, you know? Kinda seems like cheating."

"Nonetheless, after only a few minutes of practice, you've already kept the spell going through a conversation."

Adora looked down at her chest. "Oh yeah, I have." She smiled. "Nice." As if she jinxed it, the flow of magic faltered just a little, and she had to pause to readjust.

"The less you think about it the better," Micah said. "It's like when someone says 'you are now breathing manually.' You weren't aware of it until you started thinking about it, but now you have to concentrate on it."

Adora nodded, breathing deeply again to recenter herself.

"Now, there are limitations to this technique," Micah explained. "First of all, nobody is able to cast magic in their sleep. In a light sleep it might hold, but in a deep sleep the spell will certainly fail. So you'll probably be pretty sore in the mornings.

"Secondly, passive casting generally does not agree with active casting. If the caster expends too much energy on other spells,

they may inadvertently draw energy from the passive spell, or exhaust their magical stamina, causing the spell to fail. I imagine this will be much the same with She-Ra, so you must be cautious when using your powers."

Adora nodded. "I understand. I've gotten a lot better at being mindful of myself, so I don't think it will be too much of a problem."

"I'm glad," Micah said in a fatherly tone. "You don't know how much we all worried every time you worked yourself to the point of exhaustion."

Adora leaned back and looked upwards, towards her bedroom balcony where Catra was reclined on the rail, watching her from afar. "I think I have some idea."

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Catra lay purring in afterglow. She was still on top of Adora, their limbs entangled, but Catra decided she was comfy there. Adora didn't seem to be objecting, and Catra knew she could still breathe when she laid on her.

Catra was latched onto Adora's back. One leg went under, one over, Adora's legs, heels touching. One arm was under Adora's head, acting as a pillow, the other lazily draped across Adora's stomach. Catra's ear was comfortably pressed into Adora's neck, looking over her right shoulder. Her tail thumped rhythmically on the bed, slowing as Catra caught her breath.

Catra couldn't stop her eyes from wandering downwards, across Adora's chest, but not for the good reason. She found herself tracing the lightning bolt scar that shot from Adora's sternum, where the imprint of the Failsafe was burned into her skin. It crossed her left breast and branched out around her shoulder, crawling up her neck and down her back.

Catra's eye followed from the lighting bolt down Adora's left arm. A massive scar from the gash still split her forearm. It perplexed

Catra. Adora was a very hard woman to scar after she became She-Ra. Most of her scars were from Catra herself, staying only because of the emotional turmoil that prevented She-Ra from properly healing them. The rest were left by magical super weapons of some sort.

But why had this left a scar? It was just a regular old cut. Granted, a very large and painful cut, but otherwise completely mundane. Left by a nameless enemy combatant, not a dear friend she was forced to fight by circumstance. Perhaps it was too late to heal it by the time Adora got her powers back. Catra knew that once a scar was set, not even She-Ra could remove it. But it had only just healed enough to remove the stitches when they left for Dryl. Surely she should have had time to heal it before it scarred?

"I can feel you staring," Adora mumbled.

Catra's ear flicked. "Sorry. Hard not to."

Adora turned her head towards Catra as best she could. "Should I cover up?"

Catra shook her head into Adora's neck. "No, I'm okay." Catra stared at Adora's arm again. "I'm just distracted by the new one."

Adora raised her arm and turned it to inspect it. "What about it?"

"I don't understand why it scarred in the first place. Surely you had time to heal it, right?"

Adora lowered her arm and stared into the sheets. "I..." She let out a breath. "I want it to stay."

Catra's heart sank. "Adora..."

"It's! Not like that." Adora sighed. She began to roll over and Catra disentangled herself. They settled nose-to-nose, Catra's arm still under Adora's head. She bent her arm to begin stroking through Adora's hair, her tail finding its way to Adora's waist.

"I... want it to be a reminder for me of what can happen if I don't take care of myself. And..." Adora pressed her head into Catra's arm. Catra shifted her hand to begin massaging her scalp.

Adora steadied her breathing. "And I want to wear it proudly, because I'm not afraid of being weak anymore. I think that's why She-Ra's bracer is cracked, because I... accepted that part of myself and I guess it manifested in She-Ra. Like the parts of you guys in my armor."

Catra stilled her hand. "Is that also why you've only worn long sleeve shirts since we got back from Dryl?"

"I-" Adora tucked her chin in. "It's not that simple."

Catra waited patiently as Adora gathered her thoughts. She resumed her massaging.

"I guess... I guess I've accepted it for myself, but it's harder to show it to others, you know?"

Catra nodded with understanding. "Have you talked to Perfuma about this?"

"Yeah. Well, the showing weakness part. Not the, uh, scars."

"Wear a short sleeve shirt to your next meeting." Adora opened her mouth to protest but Catra brought her other hand to her lips. "Trust me. The longer you bottle it up, the worse it will get."

Adora conceded and nodded. She snuggled into Catra's arm a little more.

"Besides," Catra said, lowering a claw to Adora's bicep, "it'll show off those muscles of yours."

Adora flashed a smile. "Oh yeah? You like my muscles?" She reached her arm around Catra's waist and pulled her in, making a point of flexing as she did.

Catra smiled back as her tail wound around Adora's arm. "Mmm, yeah. And your scars."

Adora blinked at her. "Really?"

Catra averted her eyes and shrank a little in Adora's grip. Adora relaxed enough to let her move, but Catra stayed put.

"I don't know," she mumbled. Her eyes drifted down Adora's body, across the patchwork of claw marks. "It still hurts to look at them," she admitted. She looked back at Adora. "But they're part of you. And I love all of you."

"I wish I could heal them. If only so you didn't have to look at them."

Catra shook her head. "Do you remember what you told me when I discovered your scars? The night after the Heart?"

Adora nodded slowly. "I said it was in the past. That it was okay, and that I forgive you."

"Exactly. It's in the past."

Adora hummed. "Still. It just feels wrong. But at the same time..."

"You like them?"

Adora nodded her head. "Yeah. And I'm not sure if it's for a very healthy reason or not."

Catra quirked an eyebrow and looked Adora up and down again. "I have to admit, there is an appeal to them. That badass battle scarred look is kinda hot."

"I just wish it wasn't my girlfriend that made most of them."

Catra shrugged. "They're there now. Maybe we could make some better memories with them."

Adora smiled. "Yeah. I'd like that."

They leaned into a kiss. Catra readjusted as she pulled back, propping up on her elbow. Adora rolled onto her back and Catra let herself really look at Adora's scars for the first time.

She remembered all of them. The faint pair of claw marks under on Adora's right cheek, the first ones, left at the Sea Gate. Four cuts on her left cheek, a remnant from the Battle of Bright Moon. The impression of the Failsafe, pressed into her chest by the raw power it held. The lightning bolt scar that mirrored Catra's, made when Adora channeled all the magic of the Heart through her body. The four gashes on her left thigh, from when Catra was chipped. A dozen other marks from all their encounters during the war.

Catra's eyes almost glanced over Adora's stomach. There had once been a jagged scar there, left by the monster at the Heart of Etheria. But when the infection returned, Adora wasn't able to heal it again, so a skin graft had to be applied. The result was that it was much less obvious at first glance, but was still clearly visible if she looked for it.

Catra ran a fuzzy finger gingerly over patch of skin. "Does it still hurt?"

"Almost always." Catra's hand instantly shot back. "It's not that bad," Adora quickly assured her, guiding Catra's hand back to her stomach. "Not when you're here." Catra looked up at her.

"She-Ra's powers are tied directly to my emotional state," Adora explained. "When I'm sad or confused, She-Ra is weaker. But when I'm happy or," she looked directly into Catra's eyes, "in love, She-Ra is stronger." She squeezed Catra's hand. "You literally give me the strength to fight off the infection."

Catra blinked a tear from her eye. "You're such a sap."

"Don't blame me, I can't control how She-Ra magic works."

Catra rolled her eyes a little. "Of all the princesses, you had to become the princess of *love.*"

"Well what does that make you the princess of?"

Catra blinked at her. "I'm not a princess?"

Adora grinned. "Well *I'm* a princess, and you're my girlfriend, so that makes you a princess too."

"I think that only works if we're married."

"Well would you like to be one?"

Catra gaped at her, momentarily at a loss for words. "Did. Did you seriously just propose to me?"

Adora's eyes went wide and a blush swallowed her features as she realized too. "Uh. I mean. Yeah? Shit, I dunno." She gave Catra a hopeful and pleading sort of look.

Catra gave her the sincerest smile. "Yes," she whispered. Adora let out half a chuckle as Catra pulled her in for a long kiss.

They caught their breath when the kiss finally broke. Catra crawled up a little and rested her ear on Adora's breast, purring very loudly. She listened to Adora's powerful heartbeat. She could almost hear the magical glow humming within her veins, the constant effort Adora had to maintain to hold off the infection. One that apparently Catra herself provided the energy for. The thought made her purr a little louder.

"Let's keep this between ourselves for now," Catra said after a minute.

"Oh yes thank you," Adora sighed. "I really didn't mean to do that. I mean, I obviously still want to marry you, and soon if possible, but I wanted the proposal to be something, I don't know, grander. Flowers and applause and an emotional speech." Adora stopped as her brain caught up to her tongue.

Catra giggled and snuggled into Adora's chest. "It's okay. I don't like making a big deal out of things anyway." She pressed a kiss

into Adora's lightning bolt. "Besides, I couldn't think of a better way for a dork like you to propose than by accident," she added with a smirk.

Adora smiled back. "Well, you're stuck with this dork now."

Catra purred louder than she ever had. "Nothing would make me happier."

Chapter End Notes

The end! I spent *months* working on this, I hope it turned out good.
My personal thoughts are that the majority of it is a bit bloated with semi-pointless fluff and environmental descriptions that are fun to read but don't really contribute to the story. I guess that's just my style, and there is a charm to it, but I feel like some fat could have been trimmed off the Mystacor chapters. The ending as well feels kind of rushed compared to how long we spent in Mystacor. But then again, this is just fanfic and I'm always overly self-critical. Overall, I'm very happy with this story.
Thanks to everyone who left comments (or will leave comments after I post this). I may not reply to many of them, but I read them all and each one literally makes my day.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!